

SIR to begin in national Capital; over 13,000 BLOs deployed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Ashok Kumar on Monday said the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Delhi will begin on Tuesday, with over 13,000 booth-level officers (BLOs) undertaking a door-to-door verification exercise.

Addressing a press conference, Kumar said the issue of voters whose houses were recently demolished in the anti-encroachment drive in the city will be taken up with

the Election Commission.

As such people cannot be approached at their given address, they may fill up Form 6 mentioning their new address, he said.

The door-to-door survey will conclude on July 29, and the draft electoral roll will be published on August 5. After that, claims and objections can be filed by the voters and political parties from August 5 to September 4.

The CEO's office will issue notices to voters if needed and will address claims and objections from August 5 to October

3. The final electoral roll will be published on October 7, said the Delhi CEO's office.

Kumar said the electoral rolls were frozen on June 16 and by that date, Delhi had 1,45,10,298 registered voters.

A total of 2,48,992 voters were added to the voters list from January 1 to June 16 this year. The verification process will continue during the monsoon period.

The enumeration form must be filled by each voter so that their names appear in the final electoral roll, he said, adding names of those who



Delhi Chief Electoral Officer Ashok Kumar addressing a press conference on Phase III of the SIR of electoral rolls in New Delhi on Monday PANKAJ KUMAR

fail to fill up the forms will be removed from the draft roll.

Delhi has 1.45 crore voters, 77.11 lakh male and 67.98 lakh

female electors. Third-gender voters number 1,024, while voters with physical disabilities are 76,155, he said.

There are 3,29,130 young voters (18-19 years), whereas those over 100 years are 192.

The national capital has 13,033 polling stations, across seven Lok Sabha and 70 Assembly constituencies.

During the SIR, the BLOs will provide each voter with two copies of the enumeration form to fill out their details as per the last SIR in 2002. One of the forms will be kept as an acknowledgement, while the other will be returned to the BLO.

No document has to be submitted along with enu-

meration forms. For the convenience of the people, the voter list of the last SIR (Year 2002) has been uploaded on the website of the CEO.

Helpdesks have also been set up in all district headquarters and voter centres of respective Assembly constituencies.

In case any elector has settled in Delhi after 2002, the person will be required to fill the last SIR details of his/her native state from where he/she came and was registered as an elector in that state. The electoral roll of all states is avail-

able on the EC's portal.

In such cases where the name of an elector does not appear in the voter list of the last SIR (Year 2002/2003/2004/2005) as the case may be, but the name of parents/grand parents appears in the voter list of the last SIR, the person has to fill details of their parents/grand parents in the enumeration form.

Voters can also submit their enumeration form details online. Each BLO will make at least three visits to any house found locked during the door-to-door survey.

LG reviews Delhi traffic drive, says congestion down at 34 key hotspots

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday reviewed the city's traffic management initiatives and said congestion had reduced significantly at several major bottlenecks following measures introduced earlier this year, while directing authorities to intensify technology-driven enforcement and address remaining trouble spots.



has so far been completed at these 34 locations, while interventions at the remaining 28 are planned in the next phase.

Among the most notable improvements, congestion on Pustha Road in Kailash Nagar dropped by 82.59 per cent, followed by a 74.29 per cent reduction at Khajuri Chowk and a 66.01 per cent improvement in traffic flow around the Teen Murti roundabout.

Officials, however, acknowledged that conges-

tion had increased at four identified locations due to factors such as ongoing road construction and infrastructure works. Traffic rose by 349.87 per cent on Bhavbhuti Marg, 14.93 per cent near Max Hospital in Saket, 7.55 per cent at South Extension Part I and 1.28 per cent near Naraina Flyover.

The review also identified Dwarka Mor, Sarai Kale Khan, Mukarba Chowk and Dabri Gol Chakkar as critical bottlenecks requiring urgent infrastructural and

operational interventions.

Traffic Police informed LG Sandhu that regular coordination meetings and joint surveys are being conducted with agencies including the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), Public Works Department (PWD), National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC), New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to remove encroachments and streamline traffic movement.

Appreciating the efforts made so far, the LG said he would personally visit several congestion hotspots to assess the progress on the ground.

Emphasising that seamless mobility is essential for the capital's competitiveness and its image as a global destination for investment and tourism, the LG assured the Delhi Traffic Police of full administrative support and called for sustained efforts to build a smarter, safer and more efficient transport system for the city's residents.

HC cancels bail of 57-year-old caretaker in Janakpuri POCSO case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday cancelled the bail granted to a 57-year-old private school caretaker accused of raping a three-year-old girl inside a school in West Delhi's Janakpuri, holding that the trial court had erred in granting him relief in a case involving serious charges under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

Avacation bench of Justice Vinod Kumar allowed petitions filed by the Delhi Police and the complainant, chal-



lenging the May 7 order of a Dwarka court granting bail to the accused, Lalit Kumar. The High Court directed the accused to surrender before the jurisdictional POCSO court on July 1 at 2 pm.

"I have agreed with the State and the petitioner. Both petitions are allowed. Accused Lalit Kumar is directed to surrender before the jurisdictional POCSO court on July 1 at 2 pm," the court said.

Appearing for the Delhi Police, Additional Solicitor General SV Raju argued that the trial court wrongly granted bail despite the gravity of the allegations. He said the case involved serious charges under the POCSO Act and pointed out that the child had identified the accused and made specific allegations. The defence denied the allegations, saying the prosecu-

tion's case lacked foundation.

The alleged incident took place on April 30, the toddler's second day at the private school in Janakpuri. According to the complaint lodged by the child's mother on May 1, the girl returned home complaining of pain.

She later told her mother that a staff member had taken her to an isolated area within the school and sexually assaulted her.

Based on the complaint, police registered an FIR and arrested the caretaker on May 1 after the child identified him. He was then remanded to judicial custody.

Husband held for stabbing wife to death in Karkardooma

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police on Monday claimed to have solved the murder of a 30-year-old woman within hours of the crime by apprehending her husband, who allegedly travelled from Lucknow to Delhi and fatally stabbed her. At the same time, she was asleep in Karkardooma village.

According to police, a PCR

call was received at Anand Vihar police station on Sunday reporting that a woman was lying in a pool of blood inside a room in Karkardooma village.

A police team rushed to the spot and found the victim, identified as Sonam Joshi, dead with multiple stab wounds.

Senior police officers, along with the Crime Team and the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) team, inspected the scene and collected evidence.



The body was sent for post-mortem examination. Police said Sonam, a native of Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh, was working as a full-time domes-

tic helper in Noida. She had recently come to stay at her sister-in-law Kaushal's residence in Karkardooma village.

During the investigation, police identified the accused as Sonam's husband, Anuj Joshi (35), a resident of Lucknow who earns his livelihood by operating an ice cream cart. According to investigators, he allegedly purchased a knife in Lucknow before boarding a bus to Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE

TRIDENT HILLS PRIVATE LIMITED

16th floor, DLF Square, Jacaranda Marg, DLF City Phase II, Gurugram-122002, Haryana

Whereas, Smt Luxmi Devi & Others in collaboration with Trident Hills Private Limited are in the process of undertaking the development of a Residential Colony (under NILP Policy-2022) in the revenue estate of village Islamnagar, Sector-3.4 & 4A, Pinjore Kalka Urban Complex, District Panchkula, in accordance with the License No.125 of 2022 dated 18.08.22 granted by Director, Town and Country Planning, Haryana, Chandigarh (hereinafter referred as "DTCP").

And whereas, DTCP has issued a letter of intent vide memo no. LC-4871-B/JE(SB)/2026/20344 dated 09.06.26 for an additional area measuring 1.71875 acres (under migration from Licence No. 28 of 2010 & 74 of 2013) in addition to the earlier Licence No. 125 of 2022 dated 18.08.22 (hereinafter referred as "said colony"). The earlier approved Layout Plan bearing drawing no. DTCP-8544 dated 18.08.2022 is now proposed to be revised and DTCP has now issued a provisional revised Layout Plan for the composite area admeasuring 52.01041 acres of the said colony.

And whereas, individuals have made bookings / entered into purchase agreement for allotment of plot /flat /property in the said Colony (hereinafter referred as "Allottees").

And whereas, the office of Director, Town & Country Planning, Haryana, Chandigarh requires inviting of objections against the revision of Layout Plan as a pre-condition for allowing such revision in the Layout Plan.

Accordingly, vide this public notice objections are hereby invited from the Allottees on the proposed revision of the Layout Plan of the said colony. A copy of the earlier approved Layout Plan bearing drawing no. DTCP- 8544 dated 18.08.2022 and the in-principle approved revised Layout Plan bearing drawing no. DTCP- 12282 dated 09.06.2026 is available for perusal on our website- www.tridenthills.in. The said Layout Plans can also be perused at the office of undersigned at 16th floor, DLF Square, Jacaranda Marg, DLF City Phase-2, Gurgaon, Haryana (India) 122002 as well as in the office of DTP (Planning), Mini Secretariat, Sector-1, Panchkula.

Any Allottee having any objection on the in-principle approved revised Layout Plan, may file his/her objection in the office of District Town Planner (Planning), Mini Secretariat, Sector-1, Panchkula within a period of 30 days from the date of publication of this public notice, failing which it shall be assumed that there are no objections to the said in-principle approved revised Layout Plan of the colony.

Place: Panchkula
Date: 30.06.2026
Sohan Lal Pant
For Trident Hills Private Limited

UTTARAKHAND POWER CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Govt. of Uttarakhand Undertaking), Corporate Identity No. UA40109UR2001SGC025867/2358,
Victoria Cross Vijeta Gabar Singh Urja Bhawan, Kanwali Road, Dehradun-248001, Telephone - (0135) -2763672-76, Fax- (0135) -2760289
Website: www.uktenders.gov.in

E-TENDER NOTICE (NIT)
Uttarakhand Power Corporation Ltd. Dehradun invites e- tender for following as detailed below:-

S.I. No.	Name of Item	Tender Specification No.	Tender Qty.	Estimated cost (in ₹)	Average yearly Turn Over of Preceding Three Financial Year i.e. 2022-2023, 2023-2024 & 2024-2025 (in ₹)	Earnest Money (in ₹)	Cost of tender document including GST (in ₹)	Date & time of Prebid conference in online mode	Last Date & time of online request for tender and submission of tender in online & Offline mode	Date of opening of bid Part-I in online and offline mode
1	11KV XLPE Cable 3x50Sq.mm	CCP-I/17/ 2026-2027	100 Km	7,82,57,458.00	11,73,87,000.00	15,66,000.00	23,600.00		20.7.2026 upto 17:00 hrs	21.7.2026 at 15:30 hrs
2	11KV XLPE Cable 3x120Sq.mm	CCP-I/18/ 2026-2027	20 Km	2,51,17,452.80	4,00,00,000.00	5,03,000.00	17,700.00		20.7.2026 upto 17:00 hrs	21.7.2026 at 15:45 hrs
3	11KV XLPE Cable 3x400Sq.mm	CCP-I/19/ 2026-2027	50 Km	14,59,58,462.00	21,89,38,000.00	29,20,000.00	29,500.00	08.7.2026 at 12:00 hrs	20.7.2026 upto 17:00 hrs	21.7.2026 at 16:00 hrs
4	33KV XLPE Cable 3x400Sq.mm	CCP-I/20/ 2026-2027	50 Km	19,24,50,900.50	28,86,77,000.00	38,50,000.00	29,500.00		20.7.2026 upto 17:00 hrs	21.7.2026 at 16:15 hrs
5	ACSR Rabbit Conductor	CCP-I/21/ 2026-2027	3000 Km	22,94,89,770.00	34,42,35,000.00	45,90,000.00	29,500.00		21.7.2026 upto 17:00 hrs	22.7.2026 at 15:30 hrs
6	Stay wire GI 7/3.15mm (7/10SWG)	CCP-I/22/ 2026-2027	200 MT	1,70,43,800.00	3,40,08,000.00	3,41,000.00	11,800.00	08.7.2026 at 12:30 hrs	21.7.2026 upto 17:00 hrs	22.7.2026 at 15:45 hrs
7	Stay Set GI 20x180mm	CCP-I/23/ 2026-2027	20,000 Nos	1,44,05,000.00	2,88,10,000.00	2,89,000.00	11,800.00		21.7.2026 upto 17:00 hrs	22.7.2026 at 16:00 hrs

For further details, please visit the website www.uktenders.gov.in

NO.: 460/1/EE/(CM)/UPCL/A-2 Dt. 29.06.2026

SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER Corporate (C&P-I)

"SAVE ELECTRICITY IN THE INTEREST OF THE NATION. Use LED Bulb, Save Electricity (Toll Free No. 1912) "Pay Electricity Bill Online 24x7 from www.upcl.org". (For information on Electricity theft, informer may report to Toll free No 1800 180 4185/ Fax No. 0135-2760911)

PUBLIC NOTICE
This public notice is being given by M/s Devika Fin-Vest & Stocks Private Limited (Here-in-after referred to as company) in accordance with directions given by the RBI vide their approval letter through email dated 17.06.2026 for change in Management / Board of Directors in compliance with the terms and conditions of Certificate of Registration issued by the Reserve Bank of India to M/s Devika Fin-Vest & Stocks Private Limited.(CIN- U67120DL1994PTC448401) having its registered office at H-9, Green Park main, New Delhi-110016 permitting the company to carry on the business as a Non -Banking Financial Institution.

- Mr. Umesh Kumar aged about 62 years R/O 8/153, E-5, Lawyers Colony, Bypass Road, Dayal Bagh, Agra (U.P.) a qualified professional (Ex-Banker) and has a rich experience of more than 33 years has been appointed as a director in the company with change in the management and Board of Directors of the company.
- Mr. Saurabh Gupta aged about 39 years R/O 55, Jaipur House Colony, Agra (U.P.) a qualified Professional (MBA) and has an experience of more than one year in NBFC business.
- Mrs. Amarjeet Sachdeva aged about 72 years R/O 158, Manas Nagar, Agra (U.P.) a qualified Professional (Ex-Banker) and has an experience of more than 35 in banking industry.

Reason for change in control:- Barring unforeseen circumstances, the present management is confident of activating the business of the company and to ensure sustain growth.

Any person who is aggrieved by such change may lodge his / her complaint with DNBS, RBI at the regional office at 6, Sansad Marg, New Delhi-110001 or at the registered office of the company at H-9, Green Park Main, New Delhi-110016 within a period of 30 days w.e.f. date of publication of this notice. Such complaints shall be forwarded to DNBS, RBI, by the company in due course.

Note:- A certificate of Registration to carry on the business of a Non-Banking financial institution obtained from the Reserve Bank of India in terms of Section 45IA of RBI Act, 1934, it must be distinctly understood, however, that in issuing the certificate of registration "that, the Reserve Bank of India does not undertake any responsibility for the financial soundness of the company or for the correctness of any of the statements made or any commitments made or opinion expressed.

For Devika Fin-Vest Private Limited (Abhishek Jain) Director Dated: 25.06.2026

Umesh Kumar Saurabh Gupta Amarjeet Sachdeva (Proposed Director)

The Pioneer Classified

LOST & FOUND

I, S. VIJAYAKUMAR S/o S. SEETHAPATHI, R/O D-946, Gaur Green Avenue, Abhay Khand-2, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad (U.P.) 201014 have lost my Original Allotment Letter and Possession Letter of my above address property issued by Gaursons India Ltd. If found contact: 9810002278. PD(1508)

I, Scaria, Father of Salas Scaria, R/o- Noozhumuriyil (H), PO Ezhasherry, Dist-Kottayam, Kerala- 686651 have changed my name from Scaria V, vide affidavit dated 29/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(1512)C

I, Shiyadulari, Mother of JC-295676P N/ub Sub Dinesh Kumar Verma, R/o- Vill-Pahikhurud, PO-Bighapur, Teh-Bighapur, Dist- Unnao U.P-209865, have changed my name from Shiyadulari to Siya Dulari, vide affidavit dated 29/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(1513)C

I, Salimma Scaria, Mother of Salas Scaria, R/o- Noozhumuriyil (H), PO Ezhasherry, Dist- Kottayam, Kerala- 686651 have changed my name from Salimma Scaria to Salamama Scaria, vide affidavit dated 29/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(1507)

I, Meenakshi also known as Meenakshi Chauhan D/o Balbir Singh and W/o Yudhvir Biswas Arya aged 45 years R/o D-1-A/126, Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058 have changed my name after marriage to "Meenakshi Chauhan Arya" for all future purposes. PD(1507)

CHANGE OF NAME

I, KULDEEP SINGH, S/o Shivnath Singh R/o A-405, IRWO Palm Court Rail Vihar Society, Alpha-1, Greater Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar (U.P.) 201308 have changed my name from KULDEEP SINGH to KULDEEP SINGH SAINI. Henceforth I would be known by the name of **KULDEEP SINGH SAINI** for all purposes. PD(1506)

I, Kuldeep Singh, S/o Shivnath Singh R/o A-405, IRWO Palm Court Rail Vihar Society, Alpha-1, Greater Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar (U.P.) 201308 have changed my name from KULDEEP SINGH to KULDEEP SINGH SAINI. Henceforth I would be known by the name of **KULDEEP SINGH SAINI** for all purposes. PD(1506)

I, Shiyadulari, Mother of JC-295676P N/ub Sub Dinesh Kumar Verma, R/o- Vill-Pahikhurud, PO-Bighapur, Teh-Bighapur, Dist- Unnao U.P-209865, have changed my name from Shiyadulari to Siya Dulari, vide affidavit dated 29/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(1512)C

I, Salimma Scaria, Mother of Salas Scaria, R/o- Noozhumuriyil (H), PO Ezhasherry, Dist- Kottayam, Kerala- 686651 have changed my name from Salimma Scaria to Salamama Scaria, vide affidavit dated 29/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(1513)C

ESAF
ESAF SMALL FINANCE BANK
GOLD AUCTION NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the public that gold ornaments pledged with ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd. against various loan accounts and remaining overdue/ unredemmed delinquent/ repeated notices will be auctioned off without assigning any reason. Participation in the auction shall be deemed acceptance of all terms and conditions of the Bank. The Minimum Reserve Price will be fixed by bank on the basis of IBJA Rate as applicable on the basis of purity of Gold.
Place: Thrissur (Sd/-) Authorized Signatory
Date: 30 June 2026
ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Reg: Flat/Dwelling Unit Bearing No. D-112A on 1st Floor, Block-D, Super area approximate 1340 Sq. Ft., 124.80 Sq. Mtrs.) and covered area (128.88 Sq. Ft. (04.68 mtrs.) in the project Known as "SAYA ZION" Built on Plot No. GC-06/II of GH-01, situated at Sector-04, Greater Noida, Dist. Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P.; hereinafter referred to as "said property". Be it known to all that our clients, Mr. Bhaweshwar Kshatriya, Mr. Piyush Kumar & Mrs. Priya Kshatriya (hereinafter called the "Purchasers") intend to purchase the said property from Mrs. Shivani Saini for self and natural Guardian of Ms. Moni Saini (hereinafter called the "Sellers"). It has been further informed that initially, Mr. Sushil Kumar Saini & Mrs. Shivani Saini were the owner of the said property vide Buyers Agreement dated 30.08.2015 and subsequently Tripartite Sub- Lease Deed on 20.09.2018 executed in their favour. And after the death of Mr. Sushil Kumar Saini, GNIDA had mutated the said property in the name of Mrs. Shivani Saini. Ms. Mouly Saini vide Mutation Letter dated 18.06.2025. The sellers have also informed the purchasers that the said property is not mortgaged anywhere and there is no charge or dispute or any litigation pending regarding the said property. Any person including Bank/s, Financial Institution/s, relative/s having any claim, right, title or any interest of any nature whatsoever into or upon the aforesaid property is hereby called upon to make the same known, in writing, with documentary evidence, by Registered Ad Post, to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 days of publication of this notice and in the event of no response having been received to the notice, the title of the seller to the said property shall be deemed to be clear of any charge or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever and any subsequent claim shall not bind our client/Purchaser, in any manner whatsoever. ShrivantArora, Advocate M/s, Lfge, Defence Offices A-74, Lfge, Defence Colony, New Delhi -110024 PD(1514)C

PUBLIC NOTICE
Known to all that my client Saroj Kumar Sharma owner Plot No. 16, Kharsa no. 8/11, Village Rajpur Khurd, Vikas Koj Extn. Block A, Mohan Garden Uttam Nagar, New Delhi,, and My Client Purchased aforesaid property from belasis Singh Bhadouria vide notary document dated 07.11.2025 now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed to all concerned parties that no person any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as valid and void. If any person having any claim, right in respect of the said property contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication. AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION Ch. No. 760, Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75 Mobile - 9999013918

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the general public that: Mrs. Bhawana Sharma, 2. Mr. Yash Sharma, 3. Mr. Sujay Kumar were the possessors of the Entire Ground Floor and Second Floor "With Roof right" built on Property Bearing no. 50, area measuring 29.30 Sq. Mtrs, situated at Sector-63 Karama Kuri Dwarka Residential Scheme, Dwarka New Delhi, through Conveyance Deed dated 29.04.1999 executed by POI Thrigh DDA in favour of Mr. Bal Krishan Sharma and Vijay in respect of Plot No. 50, area measuring 29.30 Sq. Mtrs. Unfortunately, Late Bal Krishan Sharma died on dated 23.06.2016 and left behind his legal heirs are Mr. Yash Sharma, 2. Mr. Yash Sharma, 3. Mr. Sujay Kumar. Thereafter, Relinquishment Deed dated 01.02.2019 as doc. no. 847 executed by Mr. Yash Sharma, 2. Mr. Yash Sharma, 3. Mr. Sujay Kumar in favour of Mrs. Bhawana Sharma and Vijay in respect of Plot No. 50, area measuring 29.30 Sq. Mtrs. Unfortunately, Late Vijay Sharma died in dated 30.03.2026 and left behind his legal heirs are: 1. Mrs. Bhawana Sharma, 2. Mr. Yash Sharma, 3. Mr. Sujay Kumar. Thereafter, SPA dated 12.06.2026 executed by First Floor in property bearing no. 50. 1. Mrs. Bhawana Sharma, 2. Mr. Yash Sharma, 3. Mr. Sujay Kumar intend to transfer the ownership of above said floor by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Raj Kumar Sharma (Yash Sharma) self and SPA of Mrs. Bhawana Sharma. Subsequently, Mr. Raj Kumar Sharma the process of mortgaging the said Plot with ICICI Bank Ltd/ ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 15 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 15-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of any person. If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 15-day period by contacting Law Offices: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-4/A, Sector-16, Vardas, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s) - +91012-04499711, e-mail: accounts@vnorth.in.

Delhi EV policy drops incentives for strong hybrids despite rising sales

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy, approved at the Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday, dropped strong hybrids from the incentive scheme despite steady sales growth in the segment.

There was a proposal of a 50 per cent exemption to buyers of strong hybrid vehicles in road tax and registration under the draft of the EV policy, but it was dropped during final consultations, said Transport Commissioner Niharika Rai.

According to official data, the sale of hybrid vehicles,

although below two per cent, is growing steadily. Among total vehicle registrations in Delhi this year, the share of fossil fuel-based hybrids stood at 1.7 per cent, and electric hybrids accounted for 1.2 per cent.

A total of 4,410 hybrid four-wheelers were sold this year between January and May as compared to 3,456 in the same period in 2025, a jump of around 27 per cent, as per data available on the Vahan portal.

The hybrid vehicle sales stood at 961 during January-May 2024. In 2025, a total of 7,767 EV hybrids were sold as compared to just 4,982 in 2024, registering a year-on-



year rise of around 56 per cent.

During consultations involving the stakeholders and the Group of Ministers (GoM) formed to frame the EV Policy, the opinion was divided. Incentivising strong hybrids was strongly advocated by supporters of the proposal, citing its contribution to faster adoption of EVs in neighbouring Uttar Pradesh.

According to hybrid vehicle manufacturers' data, the sale of strong hybrids registered a 175 per cent rise in monthly sales, after July 2024, when an exemption was granted in road tax and registration fees. The average sale of strong hybrids in UP was 538

before the exemption.

Non-inclusion of strong hybrids in the subsidy scheme under the Delhi EV Policy 2026 means that buyers of these vehicles will continue to look to other states, including UP, for incentives, leading to a loss of hundreds of crores of rupees to the city Government, officials said.

Hybrid vehicles use twin energy sources, mainly from conventional fuels like petrol and diesel, as well as energy produced by regenerative mechanisms.

This means less use of fossil fuel and improved emission standards. These vehicles capture

energy normally lost during braking by using the electric motor as a generator and storing the captured energy in the battery.

The hybrid EVs are powered by conventional internal combustion engines in combination with one or more electric motors that use energy stored in batteries.

A wide variety of hybrid electric vehicle (HEV) models are currently available. Although HEVs are often more expensive than similar conventional vehicles, some of the cost may be recovered through fuel savings or through Government subsidies, officials added.

New EV policy focuses on charging infrastructure; rollout from July 1



Delhi CM Rekha Gupta, Ministers Manjinder Singh Sirsa, Pankaj Kumar Singh and Ashish Sood during a press conference at Secretariat in New Delhi on Monday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The new EV policy, approved by the Delhi Government on Monday, focuses on charging infrastructure expansion and aims to set up 30,000 charging points over the next four years. The policy, approved by the State Cabinet headed by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, is likely to be implemented from July 1 this year for four years till March 31, 2030.

The chief minister said that a robust charging network would be the foundation of the policy's success. "Accordingly, more than 30,000 EV charging points will be installed across Delhi during the policy period. The required land has already been identified, and charging infrastructure will be developed across the city on a large scale in the coming months," she said in a statement.

Transport Minister Pankaj Singh stated that charging infrastructure is crucial for achieving faster adoption of electric vehicles in the city, and as such, the policy envis-

ages installation of more than 30,000 EV charging points across Delhi.

"It also lays down a phased roadmap for electrification of commercial transport, passenger vehicles, goods carriers and school bus fleets," Singh added.

The issue of expanding charging infrastructure was discussed in detail in a recent meeting chaired by Delhi Chief Secretary, in which a target of setting up 32,000 by 2030 was finalised, officials said.

The officers reviewed preparedness for charging infrastructure expansion, including at the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) depots, for the upcoming induction of e-buses under the National Electric Bus Program (NEBP) and PM E-Drive scheme, in the meeting.

The transport department is the overall coordinator, and Delhi Transco Limited (DTL) is the nodal agency to closely monitor and ensure compliance regarding the setting up of EV charging infrastructure.

The power department

earlier recommended the incorporation of specific targets in the Delhi EV Policy 2026 for charging infrastructure. The Transport department had recommended setting up 32,000 charging points by 2030, as was communicated by it to the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) and the Supreme Court.

Officials said Delhi witnessed "record" expansion of charging infra in the last one year, with the total number of charging points rising to over 10,000, of which more than 3,000 were added in the past few months. The three major power discoms in the city—BRPL, BYPL and TPDDL—have led the initiative.

In 2025-26, BRPL and BYPL installed over 1,600 EV charging points and battery swapping stations across 1,241 locations—the highest ever in a single year, discom officials said. Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) energised 3,783 EV connections, out of which 1,641 EV connections got charged in 2025-26.

Electric-only rule for new auto-rickshaws from 2027 draws union backlash

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government's decision to make the registration of all new auto-rickshaws in the national capital electric-only from January 2027 has drawn criticism from auto unions, which termed the proposed transition "abrupt and forced".

The new electric vehicle (EV) policy, which was approved by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta in a meeting on Monday, also introduces a purchase incentive of up to ₹50,000 in the first year, followed by ₹30,000 in the second year and ₹20,000 in the third year.

"Any forced, sudden move like only EV auto-rickshaw registration from next year is a disruptive move. What the

Government should actually do is strengthen the charging infrastructure and move the Supreme Court to relax the cap on fresh registration of three-wheelers," Rajindra Soni, general secretary, Delhi Auto Rickshaw Sangh, said.

"We also want the subsidy for the vehicles to increase to around ₹1.5 lakh from both the Centre and the Delhi Government, as the current incentives are not enough. New auto-rickshaws cost around ₹3 lakh; how will the poor manage this? There was no consultation with us before finalising the policy," Soni added.

The new EV policy also proposes a scrapping incentive of ₹25,000 to three-wheeler owners. As per the latest economic survey, 94,931 auto-rickshaws were



registered in the national capital till March 2026.

"According to a study, of the total vehicular pollution in Delhi, 46 per cent is caused by two- and three-wheeler vehicles. The EV policy focuses on converting the old fleet into a new pure EV policy-compliant fleet, for which we are giving subsidies," Niharika Rai, Commissioner, Transport Department, said.

Officials said dealers will inform the purchaser at the time of booking of the vehicle whether that model is eligible for the EV purchase incentives — which will be in the form of direct benefit transfers. To get the scrapping incentive, a certificate of deposit issued by an authorised scrapping facility will have to be submitted on an online portal being created.

"We are yet to get the full

details of the policy. But for now, electric-only vehicle registration should be given more time by the Government. The incentives for transition are also not enough; there should be an increase," Harish Sabharwal, national president of the All India Motor Transport Congress, the apex body of several buses, taxi and auto-rickshaw associations in the Delhi-NCR region, said.

In addition, under the new EV policy, an incentive of Rs 15,000 for owners scrapping old Gramin Sewa vehicles registered in Delhi has been proposed, provided a new electric Gramin Sewa vehicle equipped with lithium-ion or other advanced battery technology is purchased within six months of the scrapping.

New EV policy will reinforce Delhi's clean mobility lead: Ministers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Hailing the new EV policy, Transport Minister Dr Pankaj Singh and Power Minister Ashish Sood said it is expected to reinforce Delhi's leadership in clean mobility, promote affordable electric transportation, reduce vehicular emissions, and create a sustainable transport ecosystem for the city and its people.

Dr Pankaj Singh said "The implementation of the Delhi EV Policy 2026 will be led by the Transport Department as the nodal department.

The Department undertook extensive consultations with stakeholders, vehicle manufacturers, industry representatives and experts



before finalising the policy. Every constructive suggestion received during this consultative process has been carefully examined and incorporated wherever appropriate."

The Minister added that pollution reduction is the

central objective of the policy. "The benefits under the policy have been structured in a manner that encourages faster replacement of highly polluting vehicles with cleaner electric alternatives. Special emphasis has been laid on commercial vehicles

and freight transport, which contribute significantly to vehicular emissions.

This policy has also been designed with future requirements in mind, so that Delhi can continue its transition towards sustainable mobility over the coming years. I am confident that this policy will play a transformative role in reducing pollution and improving the quality of life for every citizen of Delhi."

Ashish Sood said "As the Chairman of the Group of Ministers, I am proud to share that this new EV policy is truly pro-people, progressive, and built for the future.

We worked closely with leading experts, the International Solar Alliance, and research institutes like CPRI to design a framework

that makes electric mobility practical for everyone. This policy is about giving Delhi a cleaner tomorrow and ensuring healthy living for every citizen."

"The Delhi Cabinet has cleared an EV policy that delivers real, actionable solutions rather than empty promises. While the previous Government did very little with their 2020 framework, our Group of Ministers under the leadership of Chief Minister Smt Rekha Gupta has created a robust plan shaped by industry experts and key stakeholders. This policy will aggressively phase out polluting vehicles and replace them with green, clean alternatives to give Delhi the breathable air it deserves."

Gig workers' body backs EV policy but seeks job protection

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Welcoming the Delhi Government's new Electric Vehicle (EV) policy as a significant step towards tackling air pollution, a gig workers' body on Monday urged the authorities to ensure that the transition does not come at the cost of workers' livelihoods.

The Gig Workers Association (GigWA) said the shift to electric mobility should be "just and worker-centric", stressing that delivery personnel, gig workers, auto drivers and other informal workers who rely on two-wheelers for their daily income should not be forced to shoulder the financial burden of the transition.

"The Government must ensure a smooth transition by providing interest-free loans, adequate subsidies, affordable charging and battery-swapping infrastructure, and social protection measures for workers," GigWA Organising Secretary Nitesh Kumar Das said



The association also demanded that existing vehicle owners should be allowed to continue using their vehicles and that no worker should suffer any wage or income loss because of the policy.

It further said platform companies, which depend heavily on gig workers, should share responsibility in helping workers switch to electric vehicles.

"A cleaner future cannot be built at the cost of workers' livelihoods," Das said.

The remarks came after the Delhi Cabinet approved the new EV Policy 2.0, which aims to accelerate the adoption of electric vehicles in the national capital and curb vehicular pollution.

Under the policy, buyers of electric

two-wheelers will receive a subsidy of ₹30,000 in the first year, ₹20,000 in the second year and ₹10,000 in the third year.

The policy also provides for the phased withdrawal of CNG-powered two-wheelers, with only electric two-wheelers to be registered in Delhi from April 1, 2028.

Addressing a press conference earlier in the day, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said around ₹15,000 crore would be invested under the policy over the next four years to promote electric mobility and reduce vehicular pollution in the city.

The policy will come into effect from July 1 and is aimed at making Delhi a pollution-free city by March 31, 2030, Gupta said.

She said the new policy places special emphasis on the transport sector and provides a roadmap for the phased transition from conventional fuel-powered vehicles to electric vehicles, while introducing incentives and measures to encourage wider adoption of EVs across different vehicle segments.

Schools plan phased shift to electric buses under new EV Policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Schools in the national capital on Monday said they will begin planning a phased transition of their bus fleets to electric vehicles in line with the Delhi Government's EV Policy 2026. Welcoming the policy, some schools are preparing to ask transport contractors to induct EV buses, while others are assessing operational requirements before switching.

Calling it a positive step towards cleaner transport, Meenakshi Kushwaha, principal of Birla Vidya Niketan, said, "All our buses are on contract. Once the policy is notified, we will ask the contractors to replace them with electric buses. We will procure Electric Vehicles as required under the policy."

The Delhi EV Policy 2026 proposes that schools across the national capital ensure at least 10 per cent of their bus fleets transition to electric within two years of its notification, increasing to 20 per cent by the completion of the third year and 30 per cent by March 31, 2030.

Mallika Preman, principal of Tagore International School, East of Kailash, said the school currently operates a CNG bus fleet and is assessing the policy requirements.

"We are aware of the provisions of the Delhi EV



Policy 2026 and are assessing its requirements. Any transition, if required, will be undertaken in accordance with the Government notifications and operational feasibility. Until then, our existing CNG buses will continue to operate," she said.

Supporting the move, a representative of Sovereign School, Rohini, said the school would implement the transition in line with the timelines laid down by the Government.

"Once the policy is notified, we will work towards meeting the prescribed targets while ensuring that the transition is smooth and does not disrupt school transport services," the representative said.

Principal of Venkateshwar Global

School, Rohini, Namita Singhal, said the school would gradually adopt electric buses in accordance with the policy.

"The phased targets provide schools adequate time to plan the transition. We will comply with the Government's directions and explore the induction of electric buses based on operational feasibility and the timelines prescribed under the policy," she said.

The Education Department will be responsible for ensuring compliance by issuing necessary directions to schools, integrating the requirements into school recognition and affiliation processes, and monitoring implementation in coordination with the Transport Department.

Heatwave pushes power demand to record 8,748 MW

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The prevailing heatwave conditions caused the city's power demand to reach an all-time high of 8,748 MW on Monday.

The previous highest peak power demand was recorded at 8,656 MW on June 19, 2024, according to the discoms.

"Today, Delhi made history by successfully meeting an all-time high peak power demand of 8,748 MW, shatter-

ing previous records by nearly 100 MW," Delhi Power Minister Ashish Sood said.

According to the real-time data of the State Load Dispatch Centre, Delhi's peak power demand clocked 8,748 MW at 15.17 pm, the highest ever for the city.

BSES discom successfully met the peak power demand in their respective areas, with BRPL meeting 3,906 MW and BYPL meeting 1,876 MW load, BSES said.

Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL)



also "successfully" met its all-time highest peak power demand of 2,497 MW, recorded on the day between 15.15 pm and 15.30 pm, ensuring uninterrupted power supply across its distribution network, said a spokesperson of the company.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), heat wave conditions have been realised at many places over Delhi. This is the second day of the heat wave conditions over Delhi.

IN FOCUS



Devotees throng to offer prayers during the Snana Purnima festival, in Puri on Monday (PTI)

DU offers 1,370 ECA quota seats in 14 categories for UG admissions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The University of Delhi has announced 1,370 seats under the extra-curricular activities (ECA) quota across 14 categories for undergraduate admissions in the 2026-27 academic session, even as registrations under the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS-UG) are already underway.

According to the university's ECA seat matrix, theatre has emerged as one of the largest categories with 123 seats, along with Indian classical dance with 125 seats and Indian vocal music with 109 seats.

The university has also earmarked 72 seats for Indian Folk Dance, 71 seats for Hindi debate, 69 seats for English debate, 65 seats for sketching and painting, 63 seats for western dance, 56



seats for National Cadet Corps (NCC) (girls), 54 seats for western vocal music and 53 seats for the National Service Scheme (NSS).

Among other categories, the university has offered 44 seats in photography, 42 in yoga, 37 in instrumental Indian music (tabla), 35 in choreography, 33 in English creative writing and 30 in Hindi creative writing. Filmmaking has 28 seats,

harmonium 26, quiz 25 and western drums 24 seats.

Several specialised ECA disciplines have a limited number of seats. Guitar (lead) has 13 seats, sculpture 10, animation eight, violin (Indian) five, bass guitar 13, sarod two and western flute one seat.

The seat matrix shows participation from colleges across the university, with institutions such as Kirori

Mal College, Hindu College, Hansraj College, Miranda House, Lady Shri Ram College for Women, Sri Venkateswara College, Gargi College, Ramjas College, Shivaji College and Zakir Husain Delhi College offering seats in multiple ECA disciplines.

The university has already opened registrations for undergraduate admissions through the CSAS-UG portal.

According to the university, candidates desirous of taking admission to the undergraduate programme under the sports quota must have appeared in CUET (UG)-2026.

"For admissions to ECA and sports supernumerary seats, a weightage of 25% will be given to CUET(UG)-2026 score and 75% to certificates/trials/ performances," according to the UG bulletin of information.

Man jumps into Yamuna from DND flyway, search operation underway



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 30-year-old man allegedly jumped into the Yamuna river from the DND Flyway in the early hours of Monday, with police probing the possible role of matrimonial discord, even as a multi-agency search operation continued through the day.

The missing man has been identified as Ankit Sharma alias Ashu, a resident of Chitra Vihar in east Delhi.

According to police, CCTV footage showed Sharma's fall into the river at around 1.35 am after he allegedly left behind his scooter, two mobile phones and slippers on the DND Flyway.

Police said information about the incident was received at around 2.25 am, following which rescue teams were rushed to the spot.

The Delhi Fire Service said it received a call early Monday regarding a person allegedly jumping into the Yamuna from the flyway.

The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) officials said they were alerted around 2.30 am, and they immediately deployed a team equipped with boats

and rescue gear to launch a search operation.

The operation is being carried out jointly by the NDRF, Delhi Disaster Management Authority and Delhi Fire Services.

Police said the NDRF has doubled its deployment from 35 to 70 personnel to intensify the search. Sharma's family also informed them that he had jumped into the river, prompting an extensive search in coordination with multiple agencies, a senior police officer said.

During inspection of the spot, police recovered Sharma's scooter, two mobile phones and slippers from the bridge. No suicide note has been found so far, police said.

During preliminary inquiry, police found that Sharma was reportedly facing matrimonial disputes and court cases linked to them. Investigators suspect that ongoing domestic issues may have driven him to take the extreme step, though the exact circumstances are yet to be established. The search operation was continuing till the filing of this report, with teams combing stretches of the river to trace him. Further investigation is underway.

Centre to lift temporary curbs on fuel sale amid West Asia conflict

RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

The Centre has decided to lift temporary restrictions on the sale of petrol and diesel from July 1. This ends emergency measures introduced earlier this month to safeguard domestic fuel supplies amid disruptions led by the US-Israeli war on Iran and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

The move will also end the cap on the diesel quantity that can be sold to a single vehicle in a day at retail fuel stations, reflecting an improvement in the country's fuel supply situation.

In an order issued on



Monday, the government said it had reviewed the prevailing supply situation of petroleum products and concluded that the restrictions were "no longer necessary in the public interest." It consequently withdrew the June 12

notification with effect from July 1, 2026.

The curbs, imposed as a precaution against potential supply shortages, had barred commercial consumers from buying petrol and diesel at retail fuel stations. Authorities had also placed a daily limit on diesel purchases to ensure adequate availability for the general public. The curbs were imposed amid fears that the US-Israeli war on the Gulf could disrupt global energy supply chains and affect fuel availability.

The order stated that the temporary measures, introduced on June 12 under the Motor Spirit and High Speed Diesel (Temporary Regulation

of Supply through Retail Outlets) Order, 2026, had been imposed to regulate the sale and distribution of petrol and diesel through retail outlets operated by Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOCL), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL).

According to the government, the restrictions were considered "necessary and expedient in the public interest to maintain supplies of Motor Spirit (MS) and High Speed Diesel (HSD) and secure their equitable distribution and availability at fair prices."

However, following a

review of the domestic fuel supply situation, the order said the Centre was "satisfied that it is no longer necessary in the public interest to continue with the directions contained in the said Order."

The June 12 order had barred industrial, commercial and institutional consumers from purchasing petrol and diesel from retail fuel stations, directing them instead to source fuel from authorised bulk suppliers. Oil marketing companies and fuel retailers were also instructed to restrict bulk purchases from retail outlets for a period of up to 90 days.

The government had said the decision was taken in

response to "the current prevailing geopolitical situation affecting certain regions of the world", which had disrupted international petroleum supply chains, shipping logistics and the availability of petroleum products.

It also cited "extraordinary demand growth", particularly for diesel, after bulk consumers shifted their purchases to retail fuel stations because of significant price differences. While retail prices remained lower, bulk consumers, including industries, telecom tower operators and firms using diesel for power generation, continued to pay market-linked rates.

Gujarat CM Patel holds meetings with Ukraine's envoy, Russian trade representatives

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Vadodra

Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel met Ukraine's Ambassador to India, Oleksandr Polishchuk, here on Monday and invited industries from his country to collaborate with the state as a reliable Indian partner.

The meeting took place on the sidelines of the 4th Vibrant Gujarat Regional Conference (VGRC), which was inaugurated by the CM.

On the opening day of the two-day conference, Patel also met Ireland's Consul General in Mumbai, Patrick Duffy, and the Head of Government Relations and Financial Sector at the Trade Representation of Russian Federation, Zlata Antusheva.

The regional conference is the fourth edition of the series being organised in run-up to the Vibrant Gujarat Global Summit 2027.

In the meeting with Polishchuk, the CM discussed strategic partnerships with Ukraine in pharmaceuticals,



agriculture, renewable energy and green hydrogen sectors, and expressed gratitude to the Eastern European country for being a partner in all four editions of the VGRC held so far.

Patel held a one-to-one meeting with Polishchuk with their discussions focused on strategic partnerships in pharmaceuticals, agriculture, renewable energy and green hydrogen sectors, stated an official release.

Patel and Ireland's Mumbai-based Consul General Duffy also held one-to-one meeting which was focused on strengthening economic partnership

between Gujarat and the North-western European nation, it said.

"Referring to the new opportunities expected to emerge from the upcoming India-European Union (India-EU) Free Trade Agreement (FTA), the Chief Minister invited Irish industries and investors to take advantage of the vast investment and trade opportunities available in Gujarat," said the release.

The Chief Minister and the Consul General discussed ways to further strengthen cooperation, particularly in the fields of skill development, technology, and sports.

Ireland's Consul General expressed his eagerness to participate in the Vibrant Gujarat Global Summit 2027 and conveyed his interest in organising a country seminar to explore areas of mutual collaboration.

Patel also held a meeting with a delegation from the Trade Representation of Russian Federation in India. At the meeting, detailed discussions were held on

strengthening mutual collaboration in sectors such as transportation, smart city development, payment systems, Indian MSMEs, rupee-based financial transactions, as well as with Russian firms Archem (specialty chemicals) and EuroChem (fertilizers), stated the release.

Speaking at a seminar on "Sports Goods Manufacturing Hub in Chhota Udepur: From Traditional Skills to Industrial Development", the CM said his state has prepared a robust roadmap for 'Viksit Gujarat' to realise Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of 'Viksit Bharat by 2047'. Referring to the success of the Vibrant Gujarat initiative launched in 2003, Patel noted the platform has evolved into a globally recognised investment summit.

He maintained that Gujarat has recorded an implementation rate of 70 per cent-90 per cent for Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) signed during Vibrant Gujarat events.

Punjab CM Mann announces 7,000 km of pipeline to take canal water to every farm

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Moga (Punjab)

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Monday said his government will lay 7,000 kilometres of pipelines by the end of this year to bring canal water to every farm in the state.

Addressing a Lok Milni programme at Bhallur village in Moga district, Mann said the state government has already laid 14,000 km of pipelines and watercourses over the last four years to improve irrigation.

Around 80 per cent of the state's farms are getting 21,000 cusecs of canal water through these pipelines, he said. The government is creating water recharge points along canals and rivers to improve the groundwater level, which has risen by two to four metres in several areas, he added.

Mann alleged that canal water under earlier regimes was meant only for influential people, and said that his government is steadfast in taking it to every farmer.

On the row that has beset him for days, the chief minister attacked opposition parties, saying they had joined hands against him after their defeat in the 2022 Assembly elections because they could not match his government's performance.



He alleged that the previous governments encouraged corruption, mafia, and the drug trade.

Under his government, Mann said, over 90 per cent of households are getting free electricity, and more than 68,000 people have got government jobs without paying a bribe or using leverage.

He said his government has constructed 3,100 sports stadiums to encourage youth to stay away

from drugs. The government's Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojna provides cashless medical treatment of up to Rs 10 lakh for every resident family in Punjab, adding that people have already availed treatment worth over ₹650 crore under the scheme, he said.

The Aam Aadmi Party leader announced financial assistance to all adult females from July 1 under Maavan Dheeyan Satkar Yojna.

FROM PAGE - 1

PM convenes meeting of Secretaries to review...

At a meeting of the council of ministers on May 21, Modi had said the Government shall leave no stone unturned to further "Ease of Living", "Ease of Doing Business" and increase opportunities for youngsters. He had repeatedly conveyed to the ministers that their aim and objective should always be bringing comfort to people's lives and ensure "ease of living".

Delhi bets big on all-electric future

The policy also provides a scrapping incentive of ₹1 lakh for owners of BS-IV four-wheelers or below standard who scrap their vehicles and switch to electric vehicles.

Further, to accelerate the transition to electric mobility across the city, owners of BS-IV four-wheelers or below standard who scrap their vehicles and switch to electric vehicles will get a scrapping incentive of ₹1 lakh.

However, there are no incentives for hybrid vehicles.

The EV Policy 2.0 forms a key part of Capital's strategy to strengthen electric mobility adoption.

The BJP Government in Delhi has set a target of ensuring that 95 per cent of all new vehicle registrations in the State are electric by 2027.

To support the transition, the Delhi Government has set a target of installing 32,000 charging points

across the city and has already identified land for the purpose. The administration plans to spend about ₹8,000 crore on EV infrastructure and tax concessions.

Transport and vehicular emissions remain the single largest contributor to Delhi's local PM 2.5 burden, accounting for nearly half of the pollution load. During last year's peak winter pollution period, vehicles contributed about 46 per cent to 53 per cent of the city's local PM2.5 levels, according to a report by the Centre for Science and Environment released on December 31 last year.

With vehicular emissions accounting for nearly 23 per cent of the city's air pollution, the policy aims to speed up the transition to electric vehicles while strengthening the infrastructure and ecosystem needed to support their widespread adoption.

JKLF chief linked to Sarla Bhat murder

The case was transferred to SIA J&K on 18th March 2024 under the orders of State DGP. According to the SIA chargesheet, investigation has revealed the involvement of Mohammad Yaseen Malik, then Chief Commander of the Jammu Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF), along with Khurshid Ahmad Chalkoo, Abdul Hamid Sheikh, Mohammad Yousuf Sofi alias Idrees and Ghulam Mohammad Taploo in planning and executing the abduction and murder of Bhat. While Abdul Hamid Sheikh, Mohammad Yousuf Sofi alias Idrees and Ghulam Mohammad Taploo are deceased, Yaseen Malik is present-

ly in judicial custody in another case.

Legal proceedings, including proclamation proceedings, have been initiated against absconding terrorist Khurshid Ahmad Chalkoo (man who pulled the trigger), who is believed to have exfiltrated to Pakistan-occupied Jammu & Kashmir.

The investigation has established that the killing of Sarla Bhat was not an isolated act of violence but part of a larger terrorist conspiracy orchestrated under the command and control of the JKLF. It has also established that the allegation portraying Bhat as an informer was entirely false and constituted a pretext to justify a premeditated assassination.

The chargesheet also establishes offences punishable under Sections 364, 341, 302 read with 34, 201 and 120-B RPC, Sections 3(2), 3(3), 4 and 6 of the Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Act, 1987 (TADA), and Sections 7 and 27 of the Indian Arms Act, 1959.

Indian delegation to attend Khamenei funeral

However, the situation remains fluid following fresh exchanges between Washington and Tehran.

Khamenei, 86, was assassinated on February 28 during the opening phase of the conflict in West Asia triggered by Israeli and US military strikes on Iran. He died in an Israeli airstrike on the Tehran compound housing his office.

India maintained official silence following

the Israeli-US military strikes that killed Khamenei. The first formal gesture came on March 5, when Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri visited the Iranian Embassy in New Delhi to sign the condolence book on behalf of the Government of India.

The Government's restrained response had drawn criticism from the Opposition Congress as well as some former diplomats and military officials, who questioned New Delhi's silence over Khamenei's killing and the sinking of an Iranian naval frigate by a US submarine within Sri Lanka's exclusive economic zone after the vessel had participated in an international fleet review hosted by India.

According to Iranian state media, the funeral programme will begin with farewell ceremonies in Tehran on July 4-5, followed by the main funeral procession in the capital on July 6. Religious ceremonies will be held in the holy city of Qom on July 7, while Khamenei will be laid to rest in his hometown of Mashhad on July 9.

Iran has also invited leaders from China, Russia, Pakistan and Qatar to attend the funeral. Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif has already announced that an official delegation from his country will participate in the ceremonies.

In May 2024, following the death of Iranian President Ebrahim Raisi and Foreign Minister Hossein Amir-Abdollahian in a helicopter crash, then Vice President Jagdeep Dhankhar had represented India at their funeral ceremonies.

Ending a 30-year-old dispute, Haryana...

These pipelines, each over 3.6 meters wide, will supply drinking water to people in Sikar, Churu, and Jhunjhunu districts in Rajasthan, as well as to Bhiwani and Fatehabad in Haryana.

The home minister described the agreement as a good example of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's idea of *Solution through Dialogue*. He described the agreement as a "win-win situation" for both states. He added that the agreement clearly sets out financial responsibilities, cost-sharing, water allocation, release rules and maintenance plans.

The home minister said the agreement also covers how to operate and maintain the infrastructure, establish monitoring systems, ensure transparency and resolve disputes. He said the framework, created by Haryana, Rajasthan and the Central Water Commission (CWC), should remain free of disputes for many years, and that the resolution was achieved within a few days under the leadership of Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil.

Shah said that Haryana, Rajasthan, and the Ministry of Jal Shakti have put Prime Minister Modi's vision of cooperative federalism into action.

The project should help millions by providing safe drinking water and supporting economic growth in Rajasthan's arid and semi-arid areas.



Devbhoomi Uttarakhand

VIKAS BHI, VIRASAT BHI



"The Honorable Prime Minister has called the third decade of the 21st century the decade of Uttarakhand. In line with the Prime Minister's vision, we are working with an uncompromised resolve a 'Vikalp Rahit Sankalp' to make the state an exemplary state in every field."

PUSHKAR SINGH DHAMI, Chief Minister, Uttarakhand

"There are two major pillars in building the developed India of the 21st century. First, taking pride in our heritage, and second, making every possible effort for development. Today, Uttarakhand is continuously strengthening both of these pillars. This decade is Uttarakhand's decade."

NARENDRA MODI, Prime Minister

Foundation Stone Laid for Iconic Ropeway Projects

The foundation stone has been laid for the construction of ropeways from Gaurikund to Kedarnath and Govindghat to Hemkund Sahib. "The 12.9 km ropeway from Sonprayag to Kedarnath will be constructed at a cost of ₹4,081 crore, while the 12.4 km ropeway from Govindghat to Hemkund Sahib will be built at a cost of ₹2,730 crore.

Expansion of Air Services

An additional terminal has been constructed at the Dehradun Airport. Regular flight services have commenced from Dehradun Airport to major Indian cities, including Ahmedabad, Bhubaneswar, Bengaluru, Mumbai, Kolkata, Delhi, Shamshabad, Jaipur, Lucknow, Pune, and Kullu.

Agricultural & Industrial Development

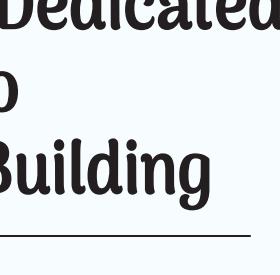
The Central Government has sanctioned a fund of ₹25 crore for farm fencing in the state. The Central Government has transferred 45.33 of land belonging to the HMT Factory in Haldwani (Ranibagh) to the Government of Uttarakhand.

Roads and Corridors

Approval has been granted for the construction of the proposed Rispana and Bindal Elevated Corridor projects to alleviate growing traffic congestion in Dehradun city. The Prime Minister dedicated to the nation the 210 km long Delhi-Dehradun Economic Corridor, built at a cost of ₹11,963 crore. The Central Government has approved ₹1,105 crore for the construction of the 12.67 km long, 4-lane Rishikesh Bypass.

Railway Expansion

Uttarakhand welcomes two Vande Bharat Express trains, making travel from Dehradun to Delhi and Dehradun to Lucknow highly convenient. "Train operations have been approved for routes connecting Lalkuan to Amritsar Junction, and Dehradun to Tanakpur. Construction of the Rishikesh - Karnaprayag rail line is progressing rapidly, with 72.5% of the work already completed. Approval has been granted for the survey of the Tanakpur- Bageshwar rail route; work on the project's Detailed Project Report (DPR) is underway at a swift pace.



NEW DIMENSIONS OF DEVELOPMENT

Development Initiatives Dedicated to Nation Building



Uttarakhand allocated ₹4,769 crore under the Rail Budget in the Union Budget 2026-27.

The chardham shrines have been connected with an all-weather road built at a cost of over ₹12,000 crore, making travel across the mountains smooth and hassle-free.

Uttarakhand secured the first position among small states in the Export Preparedness Index 2024 released by NITI Aayog.

The Jmrani Dam project received approval from the Central Government. To be constructed at a cost of ₹3,678.23 crore, the project is slated for completion by June 2029.

To economically empower women, more than 2 lakh 54 thousand women in the state have successfully become 'Lakshpati Didis'.

A dedicated Rafting Base Station will be built in Rishikesh, for which the Central Government has sanctioned ₹100 crore.

The National Games were hosted in the state for the very first time.

When we come from our hometowns to Devbhoomi for the Chardham Yatra, we do so with a resolve in our hearts. In the same spirit, I would also like to urge you to take five resolves: Narendra Modi

First Resolve : Cleanliness is paramount.

Second Resolve : Sensitivity toward nature and the environment.



Third Resolve : Emphasis on service, cooperation, & unity.

Fourth Resolve : Promotion of 'Vocal for Local'.

Fifth Resolve : Adherence to discipline, safety, & decorum.





States Focus



INDIA, MALDIVES BEGIN NEGOTIATIONS FOR FTA

India and the Maldives on Monday began negotiations for a Free Trade Agreement (FTA), the commerce department said. The discussions are being conducted in virtual mode and are scheduled from June 29 to July 7, it said. "The Government of India has officially commenced the first round of negotiations for a bilateral FTA with the Republic of Maldives," the department said in a social media post. In a trade agreement, two countries either significantly reduce or eliminate import duties on the maximum number of goods traded between them. "Every vote is crucial in shaping the future of West Bengal and strengthening democracy and the rule of law," the Governor said. (PTI)



PRASOON JOSHI-LED PANEL SET UP TO STRENGTHEN FILM INDUSTRY

The Centre on Monday announced the setting up of a study group under Prasara Bharati chairperson Prasoon Joshi to recommend measures for strengthening the Indian film industry.

It also circulated draft regulations among states, saying their adoption could increase the number of cinema halls across the country, as different states currently follow different rules for permissions required for setting up theatres.

He also highlighted that the IIA is a unique institution with a rich legacy and global standing in astronomy research, tracing its three centuries journey, beginning from the historic Madras Observatory. (PTI)

Act without political interference: Vijay tells officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Monday directed district collectors and superintendents of police to effectively tackle crimes by identifying the root cause and maximise public safety.

Stressing the need to crack down on drug trafficking and protect natural resources from plunder, he said no wrongdoer, regardless of their standing, should escape swift and impartial punishment. Addressing the first two-day joint conference of collectors, SPs and senior police officials since his TVK government assumed office in May, Vijay said the officials "could act without political interference."



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Joseph Vijay during a conference of District Collectors and Police Department officials at the Secretariat

"District collectors and Superintendents of Police should actively monitor and take action against drug trafficking and smuggling of mineral resources," Vijay said at the Secretariat here.

LG performs *Pratham Puja* to mark start of Amarnath Yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Monday performed the *Pratham Puja* at the Holy Cave of Shri Amarnath Ji, marking the ceremonial start of the annual pilgrimage. The Lieutenant Governor sought the divine blessings of Baba Barfani and prayed for the peace, prosperity, health and well-being of all.

The Lieutenant Governor extended a heartfelt invitation to all devotees of Baba Barfani, encouraging them to join the holy pilgrimage in great numbers and experience the spiritual journey.

"As the Yatra commences on July 3rd, the Administration, Shri



Amarnath Ji Shrine Board, Army, Police, Security Forces, Local Community, Service Providers, and volunteers are

working in complete synergy. Every stakeholder is devoted to ensuring a safe, hassle-free and memorable pilgrimage

for all pilgrims. With significantly upgraded infrastructure, enhanced facilities, and invaluable support of people of Jammu Kashmir, we are fully prepared to welcome devotees for a spiritually fulfilling journey," the Lieutenant Governor said.

Shri Amarnath Ji Shrine Board (SASB) organizes the Pratham Puja annually at the Holy Cave on Jyeshtha Purnima. This year's 57-day pilgrimage will formally commence on July 3rd, 2026, simultaneously via both traditional routes — the Pahalgam axis in Anantnag district and the Baltal in Ganderbal district. The Yatra will culminate on August 28th, 2026, on Raksha Bandhan.

DGHS scam probe gains momentum as ED, ACB team up

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) and Delhi's Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB) are now working together to track down suspect firms and money trails in the large-scale scam involving the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS).

After the ACB arrested former DGHS chief Dr Vatsala Agarwal on Saturday, the ED also requested detailed records from the DGHS under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). Officials said the agency is now reviewing financial transactions related to the Central Procurement Agency (CPA) to find out who benefited and to trace the flow of suspected illegal funds.

Dr Agarwal was removed from her position on May 21

and later suspended by order of Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu. She was arrested for allegedly being involved in major financial irregularities in the purchase of medicines, surgical supplies, and medical equipment worth about ₹350 crore. With her arrest, the ACB has now taken three people into custody in this case. Earlier, the ACB arrested Dr Vijay Kumar Ranga, who was in charge of the CPA, and he was remanded to four days of police custody by a Delhi court. Reports also say that Deputy Controller of Accounts Neeraj Chopra has been arrested in the same case.

The ACB says the investigation focuses on claims that CPA officials altered technical specifications and tender conditions to benefit certain private suppliers. Investigators believe that



items such as portable X-ray machines, C-arm radiological equipment, anaesthesia workstations, oral rehydration solution (ORS), bed sheets, linen, and surgical consumables such as dressings, sutures, cannulas, gloves, and medicines were bought at higher prices, resulting in losses for the public.

Earlier, the Directorate of

Vigilance, GNCTD, reported major irregularities in the CPA's operations. This led the ACB to file a case under the Prevention of Corruption Act. The agency is now reviewing procurement files, financial transactions, and potential collusion between government officials and private vendors.

With the ED joining the

Congress dividing India with foreign mindset: BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday backed party president Nitin Nabin's remarks targeting the Congress, alleging that the opposition party's leadership has a "foreign mindset" and it works at the behest of foreign powers to "divide and undermine India".

The remarks came after Nabin, addressing a public meeting in Hyderabad on Sunday, alleged that the Congress family's mindset is "Italian rather than Indian", and that a government driven by such a mindset will get no opportunity in India.

Backing Nabin's statement, BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged that the INC no longer stands for 'Indian National Congress',

but for anti-India 'Italian National Congress' or 'Islamabad National Congress'.

"Nitin Nabin ji is absolutely right. The Congress family's bodies are here but their mindset is abroad. With that foreign mindset, they constantly divide and undermine India at the behest of foreign powers," Poonawalla alleged in a video statement.

Targeting Rahul Gandhi, Poonawalla claimed that the Congress leader criticises India's economy, democracy and sovereignty during his foreign visits.

"Isn't it true that Rahul Gandhi is abroad even now, perhaps planning some conspiracy against India? He goes to foreign soil and abuses India's economy, democracy and sovereignty.

investigation, the focus has expanded from just corruption to possible money laundering as well. On Friday, the agency asked the current DGHS for full records of tenders, technical and financial evaluations, contract awards, supplies, inspections, payments, and dealings with manufacturers, authorised distributors, and other groups involved in the flagged procurements.

Officials said the ED is mainly looking for 'suspect firms' that may have benefited from the manipulated processes and is tracing where the money went. By working together, the agencies hope to investigate not just the arrested officials but also private suppliers and anyone else who may have received improper benefits. The case has also put a spotlight on how the CPA, which

handles the purchase of medicines and equipment for Delhi government hospitals, operates. Dr Agarwal had already been removed and suspended before her arrest, after complaints about irregularities.

The Government follows a "zero-tolerance" policy towards corruption, and every effort will be made to ensure a fair, transparent and time-bound investigation. The ACB is continuing its investigation into the role of other officials, while the ED is expected to register a parallel case under PMLA if evidence of money laundering emerges.

Both agencies are working together to identify everyone who benefited and recover any funds from the alleged scam. As the investigation continues, more arrests or legal actions may happen.

Trainer aircraft crash-lands in UP; pilot safe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A trainer aircraft crash-landed in a field in Kasganj, Uttar Pradesh, and the 28-year-old lady trainee pilot who operated the plane is safe, according to aviation watchdog Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA). The DGCA is investigating the incident.

"Chetak Aviation Cessna 152 aircraft VT-AFB engaged in solo flying at Aligarh has crash landed in a field in Kasganj. She (trainee pilot) is reported to be safe," the regulator said in a statement.

According to DGCA, Chetak Aviation has informed that the aircraft landed on the side of the e-way and the pilot is



safe and unharmed. Cessna 152 is a single-engine, two-seater aircraft that is mainly used for training activities. Further details could not be immediately ascertained.

The occurrence on Monday is at least the second incident involving a trainer aircraft that has happened in Uttar Pradesh in the last four days. On June 26, a

trainee pilot sustained injuries after being hit by a running propeller of a trainer aircraft at the Kanpur airport.

The incident occurred after the trainee pilot deboarded the twin-engine Tecnam P2006T aircraft VT-NBV, and the instructor concerned has been derostered from flying training duties pending investigation, DGCA

said on Sunday. The regulator is investigating the incident. The aircraft, belonging to Garg Aviation, a flying training organisation, was engaged in night instructional flying at the Kanpur (Chakeri) airport.

"A flight instructor and a cadet were on board the aircraft. After landing, the trainee pilot deboarded the aircraft with the engine running. The cadet received injuries in her back due (to being) hit by the running propeller. She is admitted to a hospital in Kanpur," DGCA had said in a statement.

Following the incident, the watchdog also issued directions that the aircraft concerned should not be utilised pending investigation.

Rahul Gandhi assured political representation, says Prajapati Forum



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A forum representing the Prajapati caste on Monday said Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has met its delegations three times since last September and assured them of addressing the community's political marginalisation, while its outreach to the BJP and the Samajwadi Party (SP) has drawn no response so far.

The statement by the Prajapati Community Service Foundation, a group advocating the community's rights, assumes significance ahead of the Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections, due in early 2027, as Opposition parties seek to counter the BJP's sustained outreach to non-Yadav OBCs (Other Backward Castes).

Addressing a Press conference, Prajapati Community Service Foundation president Raajesh Prajapati said the outfit would urge all political parties to field candidates from the community and ensure it receives its due representation.

"The first two meetings with Rahul Gandhi were held in Rae Bareilly, while the latest one took place at 10 Janpath. We have also written to BJP president Nitin Nabin and SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, but have not yet received a response," he said.

In its letter to Yadav, the foundation, formed in April 2024, urged him to "identify and empower" politicians from the Prajapati Community at the district, block, state and national levels.

BJP backs Uniform Civil Code in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday backed the implementation of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), describing it as part of the party's commitment to women's empowerment, while accusing the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the Congress of putting vote-bank politics above women's rights. The remarks came amid the West Bengal government's decision to introduce the UCC Bill in the State Assembly.

Less than two months after



BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla

ending the TMC's 15-year rule in the State, the BJP Government is expected to table in the West Bengal Assembly one of its most

ambitious and politically sensitive promises, setting the stage for what could become the first major ideological confrontation of the post-

election period. BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla said the UCC is part of the Constitution and asserted that wherever the BJP-NDA comes to power, it moves forward with its implementation.

"The UCC has been a commitment of the BJP and the (Narendra) Modi Government towards women's empowerment. Therefore, wherever the BJP-NDA Government is coming to power, it is going forward with the implementation of the UCC," he said in a video statement.

"Whether it is the steps

Satheesan writes to Suvendu over ex-Telegraph editor's passport issue

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Monday wrote to his West Bengal counterpart Suvendu Adhikari, seeking his intervention in the passport renewal application of senior journalist Rajagopal, former editor of The Telegraph. Rajagopal's passport renewal application was allegedly held up due to an adverse police verification report, prompting criticism from journalists and political leaders across the country.

"I understand that the adverse report is based on



the deletion of his name from the electoral roll during the Special Intensive Revision. While the electoral issue is being

addressed through the appropriate appeal process, I am informed that the police report has resulted in a delay in the renewal of his

passport," Satheesan said in the letter.

The CM said Rajagopal, a Malayali, is a renowned journalist who has been based in Kolkata for the past three decades. He also noted that the veteran journalist is the son of Professor V Ramadas, who served as the state secretary of the Gandhi Smarak Nidhi in Kerala and was widely respected for his public service.

"In these circumstances, I would like to request your good self to kindly look into the matter urgently," he said.

Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan described

the denial of passport renewal as "shocking" and alleged that it was an act of political vendetta.

In a statement, Vijayan said the authorities had rejected Ramadas' passport renewal application on the grounds that his name was not included in the electoral roll. He said Rajagopal was among around 27 lakh people whose names were deleted during the SIR of the electoral roll conducted in March in the Ballygunge Assembly constituency in Kolkata. According to Vijayan, Rajagopal has challenged the deletion before the tribunal.

Virus, cockroach people are gang that wants to divide country, says Nitin Nabin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

In a sharp attack on Cockroach Janata Party, BJP president Nitin Nabin on Monday alleged that the "virus and cockroach people" are a gang that wants to divide the country. Nabin, who addressed meetings of BJP's booth presidents, tribal leaders in Warangal and a gathering of students near here as part of his three-day visit to Telangana, also took a dig at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, describing him as a "part-time politician".

"Parties like virus and cockroach are coming into the country. These are people who want to make the country hollow. There is a need to pay attention to these virus and cockroach people. The gang wants to divide the country," he said, addressing the booth presidents.

Only BJP workers can teach a lesson to such people that want to divide the country, he said, also crediting the activists for the emergence of BJP as the world's largest political party. Congress leader "Rahul baba is a part-time politician", while BJP activists engage themselves in full time politics, he said.



States Focus



Flash floods in Himachal; Manali-Leh highway blocked

The Manali-Leh highway was closed and about a dozen villages were cut off from the district headquarters in Himachal's tribal Lahaul and Spiti district following flash floods, officials said on Monday.

Locals said the road to district headquarters, Keylong, is obstructed by debris collected by the floodwaters. The Jobrang bridge, which is a critical link to remate parts of the district, is also inundated with water.

Manali-Leh highway was closed following a flash flood at Jispa while several villages could not be reached following a flash flood in Jhalma nallah.

Melting of snow on the mountain peaks have caused the water level to rise in Jhalma nallah, locals said. Videos of the flash floods are widely circulating on the internet.

The BRO's 70 RCC unit is currently working through the night with three machines at the Manali-Leh highway, officials said.

Ten to twelve vehicles were successfully cleared earlier, the road is getting blocked due to the intense flooding, they said. The BRO is working diligently, making every effort to reopen the road, a Border Roads Organisation (BRO) officil said. If the situation normalises slightly, the road could be reopened tonight, he added.

The Shimla Met Centre on Monday issued an orange warning for heavy to very heavy rain at isolated places in a number of districts of Himachal Pradesh on July 2-3.

The orange alert has been issued for Kangra and Mandi districts on July 2 and 3, and for Kullu, Shimla, Solan and Sirmaur districts on July 3. Some parts of the state saw moderate rains in the last 24 hours since Saturday evening. Shimla, Kangra and Sundernagar recorded thunderstorms and lightning.

DSC a engineered scam, alleges Jagan, demands CBI probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

YSRCP chief and former Chief Minister YS Jagan Mohan Reddy on Monday launched a scathing attack on the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) Government, alleging that the so-called 'Mega' District Selection Committee (DSC) teacher recruitment process was a "carefully engineered policy sketch for a Mega scam."

Demanding an independent inquiry by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), Jagan accused Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu and his son, Education Minister Nara Lokesh, of directly orchestrating the multi-layered fraud to turn the recruitment of 16,000 teacher posts into a "money-spinning scam."

In a statement, the Leader of the Opposition stated that institutional safeguards, which historically ensured confidentiality and transparency, were completely dismantled. "Andhra Pradesh has never witnessed such a disastrous recruitment process. The responsibilities of preparing question papers and conducting the examination, traditionally separated between the SCERT and the DSC Convenor, were merged under the Director of SCERT to pave the way for irregularities," Jagan alleged.



He further pointed out that highly confidential tasks were entrusted to outsourced employees. Highlighting a specific case, the YSRCP chief noted that an outsourcing employee intimately involved in the question paper preparation secured the top rank. "Why was his data subsequently removed from the merit list, and why was he denied job verification? This is direct proof of a paper leak," he claimed, adding that the individual has since approached the court.

The former Chief Minister also questioned the lack of transparency in the declaration of results. He pointed out that the traditional practice of displaying merit lists on the notice boards of

District Collectors' offices was scrapped in favour of a centralised online system, leaving lakhs of unemployed youth in anguish. He alleged that several candidates who received 1:1 call letters and underwent successful certificate verification were inexplicably omitted from the final selection list, violating Rule 20 of the Scheme of Selection Rules 2025.

Exposing an alleged backdoor entry mechanism, Jagan said the Government manipulated the sports quota policy. "Through a new policy, sports quota candidates were exempted from appearing for the written DSC examination for the first time in history. Once their favoured candi-

dates were accommodated and the recruitment process concluded, the Government shamelessly reverted the policy to its original state, admitting it caused 'difficulties'," he alleged.

Referring to a leaked video clip of an alleged job negotiation, he criticised the State police for filing a token First Information Report (FIR) and granting station bail to the accused without a proper investigation.

Asserting that State investigating agencies report directly to the "perpetrators" at the helm of the Government, he reiterated that only a CBI probe could unearth the depth of the scandal and deliver justice to the meritorious aspirants.

Ayodhya lawyers to boycott accused in Ram Temple donation row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Ayodhya

The Faizabad Bar Association in Ayodhya on Monday announced that none of its members would represent the eight accused in the alleged Ram temple donation embezzlement case. The Supreme Court stated it will hear, after the summer break, a plea seeking a time-bound probe by a CBI-led multi-disciplinary team.

The lawyers' body passed a resolution stating that any member who represents the accused would face a ₹5 lakh penalty. The association also demanded that Champat Rai, Anil Mishra, and Gopal Rao, all of whom are associated with the temple management but not named in the FIR, leave Ayodhya. It warned that if the trio did not leave, "The association warned that if the three individuals did not leave within three days, it would blockade Ayodhya and

restrict entry. Association president Kalika Prasad stated that the body will also approach the high court to seek a CBI probe.

In 2005, after a terrorist attack at the then-makeshift Ram temple, lawyers decided not to defend the accused. A lawyer from Lucknow later represented the accused. The eight accused, arrested last Thursday, were produced before Special Judge (Anti-Corruption Court) Rajat Verma via video conferencing. They were remanded in judicial custody for an additional two weeks after police did not seek their custody, according to Special Prosecution Officer Umesh.

In a related development, Justices MM Sundresh and Sheel Nagu of the Supreme Court declined an urgent hearing on the plea alleging misconduct, stating that the matter will be listed after the summer break. The court is scheduled to reopen on July 13.



Faizabad Bar Association president Kalika Prasad Mishra addresses the media at the Faizabad District Court in Ayodhya on Monday PTI

"Heavens are not going to fall... What is the urgency?" the bench observed orally. The petition, filed by advocates Ajay Kumar Rai and Dinesh Kumar Yadav, said a CBI-led multi-disciplinary special investigation team (SIT) should investigate the alleged financial irregularities and other purported illegal-

ities concerning the affairs and administration of the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

The plea also sought directions to the Centre, the Uttar Pradesh Government and the temple trust to constitute and operationalise regulatory, supervisory and audit mechanisms necessary to safeguard

public interest and maintain the confidence of devotees and donors. The petition stated that the issues involved may constitute cognisable offences and directly impact the faith and confidence of devotees and the public. Faizabad Bar Association president Kalika Prasad stated that the association would approach the Allahabad High Court to seek a CBI investigation and, if necessary, move the Supreme Court.

"We will first approach the police for registration of the case, and if no action is taken, we will seek legal remedy through the courts," Mishra said.

Speaking on the issues, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath made it clear that exemplary punishment will be meted out to the guilty and speedy justice will be ensured. SIT is continuing the probe, and more arrests could be made once the final report is submitted.

Scindia unveils projects worth ₹350 crore in Guna

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guna (MP)

Union Minister for Communications Jyotiraditya Scindia has laid the foundation stones and inaugurated various development projects of approximately ₹350 crore in his Guna Lok Sabha constituency, Madhya Pradesh.

An official said on Monday that Scindia participated in numerous programmes related to environmental protection, water conservation, irrigation, railways, roads, energy, skill development, agricultural infrastructure, women's empowerment, health, and public welfare over the four days. He also reviewed the progress of

various development projects. The visit began at the source of the Kuno River in Kanja village, where Scindia planted 700 saplings as part of the "One Tree in the Name of Mother" campaign, the official said.

He also launched the "Jal Ganga Sanvardhan Abhiyan and inaugurated a check dam constructed at a cost of ₹17.98 lakh in Chinera village. "Conservation of water, forests, and land is possible only through public participation, and that environmental protection is the collective responsibility of every citizen," Scindia added.

On the last day of his visit, Scindia laid the foundation stone for a power substation constructed at an estimat-



ed cost of ₹278 crore at Mudra Hanuman. This substation will directly benefit more than 225,000 citizens

in approximately 225 villages. Nearly 100 km of power lines are being laid for this project. Scindia said the power infrastructure will bring new light to the homes of millions of people, and they will no longer suffer from power cuts.

During his visit, the Union Minister inaugurated the 4.5 MW Sungarner solar plant, built at a cost of ₹20 crore in Khutiyawad, which will generate approximately 7.5 million units of clean electricity annually.

He also inaugurated the modern ITI building, constructed at a cost of Rs 14.74 crore, in Tiliwara (Marki Mahu) and the Dhanwadi power substation constructed at a cost of ₹2.18 crore.

Police quiz Champat Rai, others

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Lucknow/New Delhi

As part of the ongoing investigation into alleged misuse of donations at the Shri Ram Mandir, Uttar Pradesh Police recorded the statement of Champat Rai, former General Secretary of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, on Monday. Police are also expected to take a statement from trustee Dr Anil Mishra as the investigation expands. Champat Rai and Dr Anil Mishra resigned on moral grounds three days earlier to help ensure a fair investigation. The Trust has confirmed it received their resignations and will discuss them at its next meeting. SIT findings have already led to the arrest of eight accused persons.

The issue came to light earlier this month when former Samajwadi Party MLA Pawan Pandey claimed that about ₹7-7.5 crore in cash had been taken from the temple's *hundis* (donation boxes).

At the Trust's request, the Uttar Pradesh government set up a three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) on June 13, led by Lucknow Divisional Commissioner Vijay Vishwas Pant. The SIT reviewed how donations were collected, counted, and stored, checked financial records, and spoke with nearly 150 people connected to the temple administration. Their initial report pointed out major violations of Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) that were finalised in 2025.

Some of the main problems found were the lack of security guards and frisking in the counting room, the



retention of CCTV footage for only 45 days instead of the required 180 days, and the unauthorised control of several hundis by Ramabhankar Yadav, also known as Tinnu Yadav, who used to be Champat Rai's driver. Tinnu Yadav is also accused of hiring his relative to work in the cash-counting unit. Following the SIT's recommendations, police registered an FIR on June 25 after a complaint from Trust member Krishna Mohan. Eight people involved in the donation-counting process were arrested.

Police have recovered almost ₹80 lakh in cash and some foreign currency from six of the accused so far. Those arrested include Tinnu Yadav, the donation-counting in-charge Subhash Srivastava, and six others.

In its first official statement on Saturday, the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust said it was "shocked, hurt and deeply saddened" by what had happened. The Trust assured devotees that all offerings, including silver bricks, ornaments, and other valuables,

are safe, secure, and properly documented. "The Trust has received the resignations of Shri Champat Rai, General Secretary, and trustee Shri Anil Mishra. The resignations will be considered at the next meeting of the Trust," the statement said. The Trust also said it is committed to a fair investigation and to restoring devotees' confidence.

Nripendra Misra, Chairman of the Ram Janmabhoomi Temple Construction Committee, defended Champat Rai's integrity, saying it "can never be questioned" because of his long involvement with the Ram temple movement. However, he said he could not speak for other senior office-bearers and suggested appointing a full-time Chief Executive Officer to manage temple operations, thereby improving transparency and accountability.

Opposition leaders, including Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav and AAP MP Sanjay Singh, have called for a thorough investigation and asked why senior Trust officials were not named in the FIR. The State Government has said the investigation will be fair and that strict action will be taken against anyone found guilty.

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust manages the Ram Mandir, which was consecrated on January 22, 2024. Since then, the temple has seen a large number of devotees and substantial cash and other offerings. The investigation is ongoing, and more senior Trust officials are expected to be questioned, police sources said.



President Droupadi Murmu presents the Ati Vishisht Seva Medal to Surgeon Vice Admiral Kavita Sahai (Retired) during the second phase of the Defence Investiture Ceremony 2026 at Rashtrapati Bhavan in New Delhi on Monday PTI



President Droupadi Murmu presents the Ati Vishisht Seva Medal to Lieutenant General Aditya Vikram Singh Rathoe, The Brigade of The Guards, during the second phase of the Defence Investiture Ceremony 2026 at Rashtrapati Bhavan in New Delhi on Monday PTI

NSF rejects Kuki-Zo statement on Naga killings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

The Naga Students' Federation (NSF) has outrightly rejected a recent statement by the Kuki-Zo Council regarding the brutal killing of six Naga civilians, terming it a blatant attempt to divert attention from the "cold-blooded abduction, torture, and murder" of innocent people.

In a statement issued from its headquarters, the apex Naga student body expressed deep resentment over the "divisive and derogatory terminology" used by Kuki organisations, specifically the term "Kacha Naga" to classify the indigenous Naga populace.

"It is outrageous that organisations representing the Kuki-Zo community should seek to classify or redefine the identity of the



indigenous Naga populace," the NSF stated. The federation claimed that the historical presence of the Kuki community in the Naga homeland dates back barely a century to the British colonial period, when they were brought in as porters and coolies for

administrative purposes.

The NSF slammed the deliberate attempts to compartmentalise Nagas into "Southern, Northern, Eastern, or Western" groups, calling it a malicious narrative propagated by aggressors to fragment and weaken the collective identity of the Naga people. "Our ancestral homeland may today be scattered by subjugation and militarisation, but no artificial frontier can alter our common history or shared destiny," the statement added. Emphasising that the core issue is the loss of six innocent lives and the inhuman desecration of their bodies, the NSF reiterated that no carefully crafted statement or expression of regret could substitute for actual justice.

The student federation demanded that the

Government of India immediately abrogate the Suspension of Operations (SoO) arrangement with Kuki armed groups, alleging that countless atrocities and gross human rights violations have been committed with absolute impunity under the guise of this pact. The NSF further demanded that every individual responsible for the abductions and killings, including armed Kuki militants and civilian facilitators, must be identified, arrested, and prosecuted under the law.

Reiterating the Naga people's stance on regional stability, the federation maintained that they desire neither conflict nor hostility with the Government of India, but wish to coexist peacefully with all neighbouring communities based on mutual respect.



Editor's
TAKE

India must get ready for climate extremes

Extreme weather, India's new climate reality, demands a shift from reactive relief to anticipatory resilience before it costs lives and livelihoods

For three summers running, India has broken its own temperature records, and three years running, its monsoon has refused to behave like a season at all. In 2026, nearly all of the world's hundred hottest cities were Indian; Balangir in Odisha touched 48°C, Banda in Uttar Pradesh crossed 47°C, and the power grid logged an all-time peak demand of close to 271 gigawatts as a nation reached for its air-conditioners and coolers. A year earlier, the country recorded extreme weather – heat, cloudbursts, floods, lightning – on 331 of 334 days, killing more than 4,400 people and damaging crops across 11 million hectares. This year's monsoon, by contrast, arrived late and limped along, leaving three-quarters of the country short of normal rainfall even as last year's season ended in destructive excess, with the Ganga basin alone recording three dozen river breaches in a single month. The pattern is unmistakable: India no longer has a predictable climate, it has a volatile one, swinging between drought and deluge with little warning and even less margin for error.

This is not a future risk to plan for at leisure; it is a present emergency being managed, at best, half-heartedly. Heatwaves, despite killing more people than almost any other natural hazard, are still not formally notified as disasters under the Disaster Management Act, even though the Finance Commission itself has recommended the change – a bureaucratic gap that slows emergency funding precisely when speed matters most. Heat Action Plans now exist in twenty-three states, a genuine advance, but many remain underfunded, thinly staffed, and weakest exactly where vulnerability is highest – in slums and informal settlements with little shade and less cooling. More than seven in ten Indian cities still lack adequate stormwater drainage, which is why a single intense downpour can paralyse a metropolis built for a gentler climate. Agriculture, which employs nearly half the workforce and remains substantially rain-fed, is being asked to absorb shocks it was never designed for.

What India needs now is not another plan but the political will to fund and enforce the plans it already has. Heatwaves must be formally recognised as disasters, unlocking dedicated relief funds rather than ad hoc compensation. Cities need drains, wetlands and green cover restored faster than concrete is poured, with cooling shelters and water points for outdoor workers built into municipal budgets, not added as afterthoughts. Early-warning systems for both heat and rainfall need finer, district-level granularity, reaching farmers and auto-rickshaw drivers as readily as they reach television anchors. Climate adaptation – glacier monitoring, cyclone shelters, drought-resistant crop varieties – deserves the same budgetary seriousness as the energy transition that dominates India's climate diplomacy. India's growth story has always rested on the assumption of a reasonably stable monsoon and a bearable summer. That assumption no longer holds.

The cost of pretending otherwise will only compound with every record-breaking year. Preparation, not improvisation, must become the governing instinct.

The hidden cost of India's AI boom

India's abundant workforce has emerged as an unlikely source of the data that will power the next generation of artificial intelligence. This raises a paradox with far-reaching economic and geopolitical implications: can a country become indispensable to building the machines that may ultimately replace its own workers?

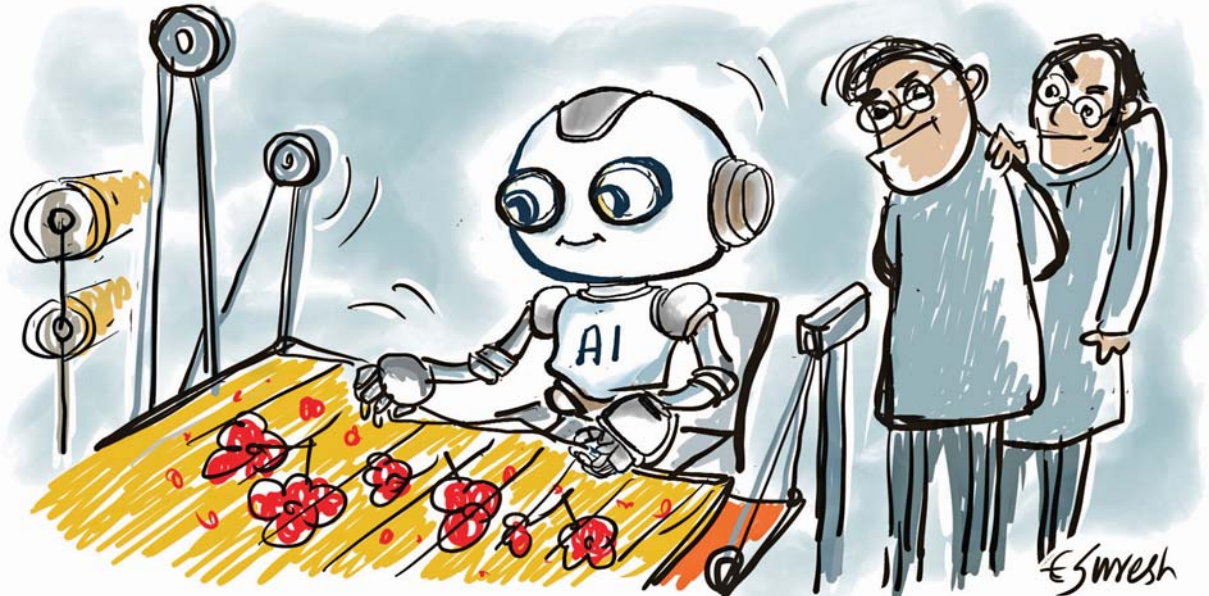


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A recent news story highlighted how machine technicians in a textile factory in Nagpur have been strapped with small recording devices during working hours to track their every action. At another textile factory in Tamil Nadu, several women workers wear smart glasses that record their hand movements as they neatly pack items into plastic covers. Many Chinese and US-based AI data solutions and robotics companies have been heavily outsourcing egocentric data collection to India's vast network of factory workers and gig labourers to equip the next generation of humanoid robots and physical AI systems. Another news story underlined that, for the tenth consecutive year, the number of newborns fell in Japan, and that the world's fourth-largest economy faces one of the world's lowest birth rates and an ageing population.

As major industrial economies encountered the challenges of shrinking workforces, as a potential solution to compensate for the 'missing workers', they moved towards automation, from specialised industrial robots for repetitive factory tasks to humanoid robots(HRs), adaptable to human-centric environments. Globally, there are about 4.66 million industrial robots in operational use, and manufacturing sectors have been integrating at a record pace of 162 robots per 10,000 employees worldwide(IFR). While global research projections for HRs indicate that from 2035 onwards they will be in massive use in highly unstructured working environments, such as in households or elderly services. By 2060, the total units in ownership (UIO) for HRs are expected to reach three billion, replace 20 per cent of the workforce in the industrial sector, and 50 per cent of the workforce in the service sector(Bank of America, 2025).

However the commercial scaling up of industrial robots and its fallout on the labour dynamics caused concern among the development economists. A 2017 study by McKinsey Global Institute warned that up to 800 million jobs globally could be lost to automation by 2030. Notwithstanding, a study on 'productivity, employment and jobs' asserted that 'if used effectively, robots enable companies to increase productivity and competitiveness, particularly in the SMEs'. A 2020 global study assessed that the 'rise in industrial robot density of one percent boosts 0.8 per cent of productivity (Select USA,Dept. of commerce, International Trade Association). Further, a 2023 study, based on data from the Chinese Annual Survey of Industrial Firms, compared the labour demands of robot



NOW, WHEN THE GLOBAL INTEGRATION OF AI AND ROBOTICS IS RESHAPING GEOPOLITICS, ECONOMIES, AND SOCIETIES WORLDWIDE, AND DOESN'T REMAIN ONLY IN THE REALM OF PURELY CORPORATE TECH COMPETITION, THE AI SUMMIT 2025, RIGHTLY POINTED OUT THE NEED FOR INTERNATIONAL GUIDELINES THAT PROMOTES AI AS A PUBLIC GOOD

The writer is former Director-General, Doordarshan, & All India Radio; was Press Secretary to the President of India

adopters with non-adopters, and found that 'deployment of robots enhanced human labour, especially the active hiring of female employees'. While studies project that in a robot-driven world, increased productivity is likely to boost in GDP growth by 10 per cent in the next decade, and up to 1.4per cent annually over the next 50 years(IFR).

Nevertheless, many social scientists opined that 'such a transformative technology may apparently enhance various aspects of human lives, but can also deepen inequalities and further concentrate economic power (Korinek and Stiglitz, 2021).

The 'winner-takes-all dynamics' advantage the technology giants and favoured the owners of capital at the expense of labour, leading to greater concentration of wealth (Acemoglu and Restrepo, 2019; Korinek et al., 2021). While the developing countries are likely to lose out on the benefits of 'demographic dividend' and 'low-cost labour'. The trend of multi-nationals 'restoring' factories closer to their primary consumer markets is already visible.

The GE brands have recently brought back a manufacturing line to the USA, and are managing operations with the help of cameras, robotic arms, artificial intelligence and autonomous mobile robots. However, the counter view goes that automation will push developing nations into high-export power-houses, as happened in many East Asian economies where the reduction in production costs triggered massive export booms, and an increase in local employment to handle the scaled-up logistics and management.

India, as a data-gathering destination, is expected to be in the global AI and machine learning supply chain. Industry experts predict that India's data annotation sector could exceed \$7 billion by 2030 and employ over a million annotators (NASSCOM Publication).

While the currently operating about 500 AI-specific global capability centres (GCCs) that are managing robotics data pipelines for MNCs, can turn India into a major intellectual property (IP) factory for physical automation. The local deep-tech companies like Humyn AI and Objectways, having access to highly synchronised data sets, could also help build up affordable humanoids.

A recent study disclosed that India's advantages of low assembly costs and skilled local engineering talent could enable it to manufacture humanoids at \$16,500 per unit, representing a massive 73 per cent cost reduction compared to US alternatives. However, on the flip side, the World Bank reports suggest that 69 per cent of existing jobs in India are under threat of being lost to automation as Indian labourers are essentially 'training themselves out of a job' by mapping their precise physical movements into datasets for foreign robotics labs, which could directly affect India's 490 million informal workers.

Many also believe that even if India becomes the owner of the actual robotic hardware and patents, it risks losing long-term employment in manufacturing and logistics to the very humanoids it helped to enrich.

Now, when the global integration of AI and robotics is reshaping geopolitics, economies, and societies worldwide and no longer remains only in the realm of purely corporate tech competition, the AI Summit 2025 rightly pointed out the need for international guidelines that promote AI as a public good. While the UN's Global Digital Compact (GDC) 2024, has spelt out the first multilateral roadmap for inclusive digital cooperation and global AI governance. Adhering to the UNGDC is essential for all nations to bridge the global technology divide, especially tech-rich countries that hold the majority of resources.

PIC TALK



Priests perform rituals during the Jal Yatra ahead of the annual Rath Yatra festival, at Jagannath Bari Temple, in Agartala

PHOTO: PTI

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When fear enters the staff room, learning leaves the classroom



SAKSHI
SETHI

2ND OPINION

Education was never meant to function as a performance industry. At its heart, teaching is a profoundly human profession, built on trust, empathy, encouragement and the shared pursuit of intellectual and personal growth.

Yet an unsettling culture is quietly taking root in many educational institutions, where fear is increasingly replacing trust as the preferred tool of management. Teachers today are expected to navigate an endless cycle of classroom observations, lesson audits, documentation, performance metrics and evaluations. Accountability is, of course, essential. Schools must uphold standards and ensure quality education. But accountability without empathy soon ceases to inspire excellence. Instead, it breeds anxiety, insecurity and emotional exhaustion. Fear-driven management rarely announces itself openly. It is

often wrapped in the language of "continuous improvement," "quality assurance" or "performance enhancement." On paper, these systems appear rational and necessary. In practice, however, when educators feel constantly watched, measured and judged, the workplace gradually shifts from being collaborative to emotionally draining. Teachers begin to focus less on inspiring students and more on avoiding mistakes. The emotional cost is significant. Every classroom demands confidence, creativity and emotional presence. But a teacher burdened by the fear of criticism, humiliation or professional insecurity cannot consistently bring their best self into the classroom.

Students may never know the administrative pressures their teachers face, but they are remarkably perceptive. They sense stress behind polite smiles, frustration hidden in gentle voices and fatigue concealed beneath professionalism. Emotional states are contagious, and classrooms inevitably reflect the well-being of those who lead them. Genuine learning flourishes where curiosity is encouraged, mistakes are treated as opportunities and psychological safety exists for everyone.

If teachers themselves are denied that sense of safety, expecting them to create vibrant, confident learning environments becomes unrealistic. As stress becomes chronic, patience diminishes, creativity fades and emotional resilience weakens. Teaching gradually transforms into a mechanical exercise of completing tasks rather than shaping minds.

Burnout, meanwhile, is often romanticised as dedica-

tion. Yet education has never been merely about delivering content. Teachers mentor, counsel, motivate and quietly carry the emotional weight of countless young lives. This is why educational leadership matters so profoundly. Strong institutions are built not on intimidation but on trust. Effective leaders understand that high standards and compassion are not opposing values. Constructive feedback strengthens teachers; public criticism weakens them. Mentorship develops capability; micromanagement destroys confidence. Schools cannot be managed like factories, where output alone defines success.

Teaching is relational work, requiring both accountability and genuine human support. Equally important is the culture of belonging. Teachers who feel respected, heard and emotionally secure are more committed, resilient and willing to grow. A sense of belonging does not dilute standards—it strengthens them by fostering ownership and purpose. As education debates curriculum reform, technological innovation and policy change, one truth deserves greater attention: the future of learning depends as much on how we treat teachers as on what we teach students. Teachers are not machines designed to perform flawlessly under relentless scrutiny. They are educators, mentors and human beings. When fear enters the staff room, learning quietly leaves the classroom. Protecting teachers is an investment in the future of education itself.

The writer is an educator and a councillor

EARTHQUAKE-HIT VENEZUELA FACES A LONG ROAD TO RECOVERY

Apropos the report, "Earthquake hits Venezuela hard" (June 26).The devastating twin earthquakes that struck Venezuela have left the world deeply saddened. The back-to-back tremors are among the most

destructive the country has witnessed in over a century, causing widespread loss of life and enormous destruction. Many buildings constructed before stricter seismic regulations were introduced in the 1970s proved unable to withstand the powerful shocks, highlighting the importance of resilient infrastructure in disaster-prone regions. Beyond the immediate humanitarian tragedy, the disaster is likely to have wider economic implications. As a major oil exporter, Venezuela plays an important role in global energy markets, and disruptions to production could aggravate existing supply concerns.

The images emerging from the affected areas—collapsed buildings, families searching through rubble and survivors mourning their loved ones—are heartbreaking. Equally commendable, however, has been the swift response of the international community in sending rescue teams, medical assistance and humanitarian aid. While the intensity of an earthquake can be measured scientifically, the suffering it leaves behind cannot.

Thousands of survivors will carry lifelong physical and psychological scars. As the world stands with Venezuela, sustained international support will be essential not only for rebuilding infrastructure but also for restoring hope and dignity to those whose lives have been shattered.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

India's image must rest on peace, not conflict

The decision of the Telangana government to rename the road adjoining the US Consulate in Hyderabad as "Donald Trump Avenue" has generated considerable attention and reportedly pleased US President Donald Trump. Whether this is simply a diplomatic gesture or part of a broader strategy to attract greater American investment into Hyderabad's thriving technology ecosystem is open to interpretation. However, the move coincides with reports that the United States has imposed sanctions on SBL Energy Limited over allegations that its explosive materials reached conflict zones in Sudan.

Such developments underline the importance of safeguarding India's international reputation. India has emerged as a significant exporter of defence equipment, including missiles, drones, small arms and explosives. While strengthening indigenous defence production is an important national objective, exports must always remain consistent with India's long-standing commitment to peace, responsible conduct and international law. India's strategic doctrine has traditionally been based on deterrence, restraint and regional stability. As the country's defence footprint grows globally, strict oversight and transparency are essential to ensure that Indian-made equipment never becomes associated with humanitarian crises.

RS NARULA PATIALA

Bonded labour has no place in Viksit Bharat

The rescue of 12 bonded labourers, including minors, from a paper plate factory in Muzaffarnagar is a grim reminder that bonded labour continues to exist in modern India despite stringent laws. Lured with promises of decent wages, these workers were allegedly confined for over a year, denied payment, subjected to torture and prevented from leaving. Even more shocking is the allegation that one worker died while attempting to escape.

Such incidents expose the painful contradiction between India's aspirations of becoming a Viksit Bharat and the harsh realities faced by its most vulnerable citizens. Bonded labour is not merely an economic offence; it is a grave assault on fundamental human rights. The authorities must ensure a swift investigation, prosecute the factory owners and all those responsible, and impose exemplary punishment that serves as a strong deterrent.

Equally important is strengthening labour inspections, protecting migrant workers and ensuring effective rehabilitation for rescued labourers. Rabindranath Tagore wrote, "Every child comes with the message that God is not yet discouraged of man." Incidents such as these test that optimism.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Accountability must prevail in UP

Apropos the news report, "Champat Rai, Anil Mishra resign" (June 28).The recent tragedies in Uttar Pradesh raise serious concerns about governance and accountability, particularly with the 2027 Assembly elections approaching. The death of nearly 20 students in the Lucknow coaching centre fire and the reported ₹200-crore theft involving donations to the Ram Temple in Ayodhya have exposed glaring administrative failures. The Lucknow fire revealed shocking violations of basic fire safety norms.

Equally disturbing are allegations surrounding the disappearance of temple donations and irregularities in appointments, pointing to weaknesses in financial oversight at one of the country's most revered religious institutions. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, who has consistently emphasised transparent and efficient governance, must ensure impartial investigations and swift action against those responsible. The Union government should also demonstrate equal commitment to restoring public confidence. Justice must be delivered both to the grieving families who lost their children and to millions of devotees whose faith and contributions deserve protection.

VANDANA CHOPRA | CHANDIGARH

When every door leads to another queue: Has India quietly redefined higher education?

For countries such as India, where electricity demand continues to rise, SMRs offer intriguing possibilities but also significant uncertainties. The technology's future will depend not on its theoretical promise, but on whether governments and industry can demonstrate that it can be deployed safely, affordably and at scale.



ANURADHA P S

through? The outcome: all the doors now open to other queues. This is not a growth that NEP 2020 had in mind. The only thing that higher education hasn't officially called is the redefinition of higher education from a system of access to a system of navigation.

The Employability Crisis

The tale starts with a figure that has been a plague on Indian education for twenty years: The landmark McKinsey Global Institute report, 'Extending India's Leadership of the Global IT and BPO Industries' in 2005 revealed that 25 per cent of engineering graduates in India were not ready for the multinational firms without any training. The percentages for the USA and China were 80.7 per cent, 10 per cent respectively. According to the Mercer-Mettl Skills Index 2025, only 42.6 per cent of the Indian graduates are overall employable. According to India Skills Report 2025, which collects data from 6.5 lakh candidates, employability has marginally improved in 2025 compared to 2024 when it was 51.2 per cent, marking nearly half of the graduates without employability. The paradox is that India is producing 350000 engineers every year and 2.5 million University graduates every year, and at any one time, there are about 5 million of them who are unemployed.

The Third-Year Preparation Gap

Teachers do not often talk about the critical juncture that marks the transition from third year to fourth year of the employability crisis. Students have taken most basic courses by the end of year three. Should they be moving towards industry readiness focusing on Internships, live projects, professional communication? Instead, they remain in a vacuum at the time when industry is reaching the height of its preparation. This failure is exposed by a comprehensive EdTech report by the TeamLease that polled 1071 respondents in public, private, deemed, autonomous and affiliated institutions across the country and found that only a small percentage of these institutions are job preparation hubs. 9.68 per cent of institutions have access to live industry projects for giving hands-on experience to the students. 37.8 per cent of institutions report that they don't have any integration of internship at all, meaning students don't have any structure where they expose themselves to a business environment. 9.4 per cent of institutions have mandatory internships embedded in all their programmes. The teaching profession is still disconnected with industry. 23.02 per cent of institutions teach students with the participation of industry professionals and only 7.56 per cent have Professors of Practice across different programmes.

The Curriculum-Communication Gap

Perhaps the most compelling evidence of systemic disconnect are the curriculum alignments numbers. 8.6 per cent of institutions have 100 per cent curriculum integration of industry needs for all programmes. Only 16.9 per cent are partially aligned in specific programmes. In one two higher-education institutions reported that there was none at all. 19.1 per cent indicate that alignment is on-going. More than 60 per cent of HEIs are not considering industry recognized certifications in their courses. It is recommended that co-creation of curriculum with industry partners must be a core component, rather than an 'add-on', if employability is to go beyond being a 'buzzword'.

Experts found three major gaps which they viewed as being responsible for poor employability outcomes: an awareness gap, a perception gap and an acquired skills gap. Past industry needs, and not future job projections, influence curricula and subject choices. Likewise, there is a lack of alignment between what industry considers important and what students and teachers are focused on. The same is true of alumni, who are essential stakeholders and bridge builders in

A hidden revolution has taken place in the higher-education system in India that's not one of accessibility but one of complexity. How a simple switch from school to graduate degree to career has become a maze of entry exams, micro-credentials, platform certifications and bureaucratic hoops to jump



the world of industry: only 5.44 per cent of institutions have highly engaged alumni. For the vast majority, these connections are weak or non-existent, severely constraining students' opportunities for mentorship opportunities, industry contacts, and informal job leads. 36 per cent of the institutions include soft skills like communication, teamwork, problem solving etc in their courses, but this is still not enough as employers constantly complain about fresh graduates lacking in spoken English, writing skills, basic digital and time management skills.

The Entrance-Test Crisis

The irony in redefining higher education in India is that the very pillars of access are creating systemic flaws. The establishment of a rationalizing body called the National Testing Agency (NTA) has led to the creation of a point of crisis, which has eroded the confidence in the entrance examination system. Only in 2024, five out of the 14 major examinations organized by the NTA were seriously affected. NEET-UG had paper leaks which caused the cancellation of results and Supreme Court intervention. The schedule for NEET-PG, UGC-NET and CSIR-NET were postponed several times resulting in the delay of admissions and employment. The nationwide anger over CUET results was caused by their delay. In JEE Main 2025, there were 12 such questions that had to be removed from the final answer key for errors. Irony abounds: entrance exams intended to make college more accessible have now become a dead end for more applicants than ever to longer lines of appeals, retesting, court action, and wasted academic years.

The Equity Cost of Complexity

All the options seem to be a good thing for women. However, the use of layered queues tends to exacerbate inequities instead of ameliorating them. The fragmentation of costs adds to the burden. Total tests, certificate and short course costs can add up to the cost of a traditional degree, causing less well-off students to go into debt or to choose less accredited providers of tests, certificates and short courses. When there is a mismatch between recognition and positioning, it is precarious. In the formal sector, jobs are becoming more demanding while in the public services, formal education remains the gateway to gain access to social safety. Students are in between two worlds - they seek informal signals for employment and keep formal qualifications for stability. Geographic and language barriers are barriers to rural students.

Platform-based up-skilling is accessible to urban and English-speaking learners, but not for rural and regional-language learners due to content, connectivity, and career networks.

There are Gender dimensions of the equity gap too: The employability of females dropped to 47.5 per cent in 2025 from 50.9 per cent in 2024 indicating the importance of inclusive skilling and policy support.

Policy Levers

- The national digital credential wallet needs to be developed in India - a secure, interoperable learner record which would store ver-

ified credentials (degrees, credits, micro-certificates) and eliminate the friction of verification, enabling them to be portable between institutions and employers.

- Government needs to implement the credits and recognition process: clear, binding regulations about transferring credit from institutions of higher education to community colleges, vocational institutions and platforms, and recognized as soon as the time is up.
- The quality assurance of micro-credentials needs to be strengthened: A streamlined, expedited process for accrediting short courses with clear learning outcomes, and carried out by third parties, would help to weed out poor quality offerings and foster innovation.
- There should be consistent data on outcomes published by institutions and platforms, such as completion rates, placement stats, and median salaries, to help inform decisions and encourage quality.
- The NTA needs basic changes in the first place: it should have independent control, it should be transparent and it should focus on pen and paper tests to ensure its leak-proof testing. The Parliamentary Committee had urged the focus on pen and paper exams, pointing to the exams which have been 'leak-proof for several years.
- Public bridging programs require investment: State-funded, first-generation undergraduate students to take bridge courses and counseling that can identify pathways and sequence of credentials at an affordable cost.
- Industry engagement is essential and should not be optional: co-creating curriculum with industry; mandatory internships; and formal partnerships between industry and curriculum should be expected.

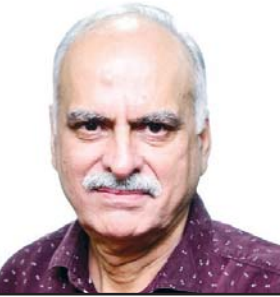
The Social Compact for Learning

India's higher education moment requires a social compact - citizens need to have the opportunity to learn throughout their lives; employers need to take note of a variety of legitimate indicators of skill; and the state needs to play its role as a steward of an equitable marketplace for credentials. When it goes unaddressed, the insidious accumulation of queues will become entrenched for not because there are not enough learning opportunities, but because it is the linkage between these learning opportunities that is flawed. The decision to be made is simple on one level, and challenging on another: to create a system where each new door becomes a bridge, rather than another line to stand in.

The 25 per cent from the McKinsey report in 2005 was a red flag. 20 years later with employability at 42.6-54.81 per cent, 75 per cent institutions not industry ready and entrance tests in crisis, India has only fallen short of remedying the predicament. It has elusively transformed higher education into something more complicated, more unequal and more perplexing.

The writer Professor Department of Commerce CHRIST (Deemed to be University)

Punjab needs solutions, not electoral engineering



ANIL ANAND

Bengal was the best pick than further antagonizing the southern India. So, the focus on West Bengal as the party already has strong imprint in the Eastern sector.

The coming set of assembly elections in 2027 includes Punjab which has rejected BJP, though it made some inroads in the past in coalition with Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) under the late veteran leader Mr Parkash Singh Badal, in its solo attempts and had to be content playing a poor second fiddle. The political dictionary of the BJP in its present manifestation knows no such word. And the only strong driving force is how to win a race solo rather than running in a relay exchanging batons. First a word of caution on how not to deal with Punjab! Don't deal with Punjab with kid-gloves and shun political and electoral experimentation that could push the state again to the brink of crisis. It should not be forgotten that Punjab extricated itself from the bloody days of terrorism with great difficulty and at a greater cost. Not to forget, it is currently in the grip of worrying drug menace and farm sector distress with agitated farmers on the road. Economy as such is posing a daunting challenge. Punjab is definitely not West Bengal, though the two states have a glorious history of making sacrifices in the Freedom Struggle, and it is certainly not Kashmir. It has its own peculiar strategic, geographic and geo-political positioning with a long history of armed struggles and wars against marauding invaders. Any "political invasion" would have dangerous consequences.

Let there be a free and fair election without any coercive attempt. Let the electoral battle take its natural course with free will of the people of Punjab. Draw a 'Luxman Rekha' even indulging in political machinations, with Mr Modi's popular slogan of "nation first" to be the guiding light. Every political party is well within its rights to plan electoral strategies and so is the BJP but with certain riders. The party has been making vigorous efforts since 2014 to make its presence felt in Punjab but with almost no success. Let the desperation not overtake everything else above all the national interest and that of Punjab.

This could be gauged from the fact that Mr Arun Jaitley contested 2014 Lok Sabha elections from Amritsar and lost. He could have easily won from any constituency in Delhi. In 2019 Hardeep Singh Puri tried his luck from the same constituency only to lose badly. The pattern was repeated in 2024, when India's former ambassador to the USA, Taranjit Singh Sandhu, entered the electoral arena, again from Amritsar but lost. Fielding high-profile candidates without any credible local leadership did no good to the BJP in finding its feat. All this while their urban base (mostly RSS supporters) oscillated between BJP-SAD combine and Congress.

At crucial times they strategically voted for Congress in anger against either BJP or the SAD due to local factors. On top of this, Haryana chief minister Mr Nayab Saini has visited Punjab 70 times during the last few months. Supporting a turban (symbolising Sikhism), reports suggested he is also learning Punjabi, he seems to be out to strengthen the BJP's position among the OBCs with 31 percent population. Though he himself is an OBC but he has no standing in Punjab. However, the BJP, ever since, has gone on a different trajectory, which was glaringly visible in Maharashtra and now in West Bengal, to import leaders from other established parties and manipulate majority. This had begun two years back with senior Congress leader Captain Amrinder Singh joining BJP along with his close aides. Later, former Congress MP from Ludhiana and grandson of ex Punjab chief minister Mr Beant Singh, who was assassinated by the terrorists while in office, was also tapped by the BJP bosses and was made a union minister via the Rajya Sabha route. On ground such moves have not brought any change to the BJP's fortune and instead caused their further alienation from the people. Captain Amrinder Singh is well past his prime and has been ignored, by his own admission, and left sulking by the BJP leadership. Mr Bittu has lowered his image in the eyes of the people of Punjab.

All other sundry characters who joined BJP from Congress, SAD or Aam Aadmi Party, are lying by the wayside. Under the circumstances Amit Shah's public proclamation that BJP will fight election on its own fielding candidates on all 117 seats, has to be viewed seriously. Such statements are usually part of his psychological warfare, but these also convey a possible design akin to West Bengal.

The contesting political parties particularly the ruling BJP, with its strong thrust on nationalism and national security, should not lose sight of the fact that Punjab is a frontline state with sensitive international border. An instable Punjab, as was seen in the past, could be detrimental to the national security. They should also not lose sight of the fact that Punjab's economy is under severe stress, with mounting public debt and an economic slowdown that has choked local enterprise. The restive youth due to unemployment is another grave challenge staring BJP and other political parties in the eye, which they can lose sight of at their own peril. A unique multi-cornered battle seems to be on the cards across 117 seats as the ruling AAP led by Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, is distressfully fighting to retain its fortress. Defending its governance model against a multi-pronged assault, AAP faces a deeply determined Congress aiming to reclaim its traditional stronghold. Concurrently, the SAD fights for its political revival, while the BJP seeks to expand its footprint in the agrarian state. The election hinges on pressing economic challenges, agrarian issues, and whether AAP's welfare initiatives can secure it a consecutive term. Manipulations and machinations have little or no space under the prevailing circumstances.



The writer is a political analyst



SAYAN CHATTERJEE

named the "Harpoons."

In naval aviation nomenclature, number-plating does not mean death. It means preserving a squadron's identity while retiring the aircraft that defined it. Yet for hundreds of officers and sailors who spent their youth around Sea King, the moment feels deeply personal. Military history is often written around wars, ships, missiles, and admirals. Rarely is it written around an aircraft. The Sea King deserves an exception. For more than fifty years, the Sea King family has been woven into the story of the Indian Navy. The original variants arrived in 1971, participated in the Bangladesh Liberation War, and helped shape India's naval aviation doctrine. But it was the Sea King 42B, inducted during the late 1980s, that transformed how the Navy thought about maritime warfare. Built originally by Westland Helicopters under license from Sikorsky Aircraft, the Sea King was never designed to be glamorous. It was designed

On 14 June, the Indian Navy softly closed a remarkable chapter in its aviation history. The Sea King 42B helicopters—known affectionately across generations of naval aviators simply as the "Bravo"—has seen its operational journey come to an end with the number-plating of INAS 330, nick-

to endure. Weighing close to ten tonnes, powered by twin Rolls-Royce Gnome engines, and capable of operating hundreds of miles from its parent ship in some of the world's harshest maritime conditions, the aircraft earned a reputation that few naval helicopters have matched. Across navies worldwide—from the United Kingdom and India to Canada and Germany—the Sea King became synonymous with reliability, versatility, and survivability. In Indian service, however, it evolved into something more. The Sea King 42B was not merely a helicopter; it became an airborne extension of the fleet itself, carrying sensors, weapons, and capabilities that fundamentally changed how the Indian Navy fought at sea.

To understand why, one must appreciate the era into which it arrived. The Cold War was still alive. The Indian Navy was expanding rapidly. Aircraft carriers INS Vikrant and INS Viraat were operational. Guided missile destroyers and frigates were entering service. Yet one challenge remained constant: the ocean is vast, and ships can only see so far. The Sea King changed that equation. Perhaps, for the first time, the Indian Navy possessed a helicopter capable of doing nearly everything its parent warship could do. Equipped with advanced radar, anti-submarine sensors, sonobuoys, torpedoes, electronic surveillance systems and the formidable Sea Eagle anti-ship missile, the Sea King became what naval officers fondly called a "flying frigate." Its radar could peer hundreds of kilometers beyond a ship's horizon. Its sonar could hunt submarines hidden beneath the waves. Its missiles could strike hostile vessels far beyond visual range.



In a single sortie, it could search for surface ships, switch to anti-submarine warfare midway, conduct electronic intelligence gathering, and return to its deck carrying information that could shape an entire fleet's battle plan.

One such veteran, speaking in the recently released Meluha Maritime Conversations podcast hosted by Cmdr. Srikant B. Keshnur, an Indian Navy veteran and naval historian, perhaps captured its legacy best when he opined that the Sea King had the capability to make the vast Arabian Sea feel no larger than a pond. That may sound like nostalgia speaking. It is not. At the time, few naval helicopters in the world combined so many capabilities on a single platform. While other navies operated specialized helicopters for individual missions, the Indian Navy's Sea Kings evolved into true multi-role combat systems. They extended the fleet's eyes, ears and striking arms far beyond the horizon. But aircraft do not create legends. People do. Listening to former operators recount their experiences reveals that the Sea King's real story

lies not in hardware but in human endeavour.

Night anti-submarine missions remain part of naval aviation folklore. Picture a moonless Arabian Sea. A helicopter hovers 52 feet above black water. The sonar is lowered into the depths below. Two pilots maintain a delicate hover while operators at the rear scan acoustic signatures, attempting to locate a submarine commander equally determined not to be found.

For four hours, both sides engage in an invisible contest of patience, skill and nerves. The pilot worries about engine failures. The sensor operator worries about missing the faintest acoustic clue. The submarine captain below worries about being detected. That was the world of the Sea King. The aircraft also demanded a level of teamwork rarely seen elsewhere. Every mission depended on pilots, tactical coordinators, sensor operators, engineers and maintainers functioning as a single organism. Veterans still recall standing shoulder-to-shoulder rehearsing emergency drills, each crew member knowing precisely what to do should disaster strike. And then there were the rescues. While much attention is paid to anti-submarine warfare and anti-ship missions, the Sea King's humanitarian record is equally impressive. Whether responding to maritime disasters, floods, search-and-rescue operations, or medical evacuations, the aircraft repeatedly demonstrated that military aviation serves people as much as strategy.

Perhaps that explains why so many former Sea King operators speak about the aircraft with emotion rather than professionalism. In the said podcast episode, one retired rear admiral revealed

that he carries a tattoo of the Sea King on his hand. Another described how veterans from around the world are travelling back for the squadron's farewell. These are not reactions typically associated with machines. They are reactions associated with identity. The Indian Navy is, of course, moving forward. The MH-60R Seahawk, alias "The Romeos," represents a new generation of maritime helicopters. It is more advanced, more networked, and better suited to the requirements of a twenty-first-century navy. Progress is inevitable. Yet every modern capability rests upon foundations built by those who came before. The Sea King arrived at a time when India was still discovering its maritime ambitions. It served through the rise of the Indian Navy from a regional force into a genuine blue-water navy. It flew from four different aircraft carriers, supported countless deployments, participated in major operations, and helped shape generations of naval aviators. In many ways, the story of the Sea King is also the story of a Navy finding its confidence. When the last Sea King Bravo lifted off and the squadron standard was lowered, the aircraft left behind more than a service record. It left behind a culture. A culture of professionalism, camaraderie, innovation, and quiet excellence. The Sea King may be leaving active service. But for the men who flew it, hunted submarines from it, maintained it, rescued lives with it, and grew up around its unmistakable roar, the Arabian Sea will always sound a little different without it.

The writer is a Delhi-based independent contributor to print and online publications



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Court acquits man in 2016 crash case involving ex-MLA

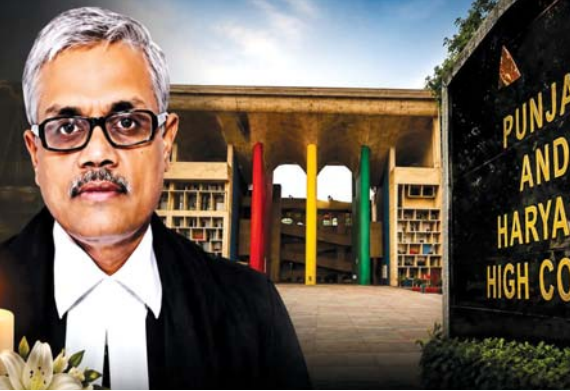


An additional sessions court on Monday acquitted Naresh Kumar, who was accused of crashing car into two vehicles, including one carrying a former MLA of Sundernagar, under the influence of alcohol. Additional Sessions Judge Hoshiyar Singh Verma allowed a criminal appeal and set aside Kumar's sentence, citing lack of evidence.

The incident took place on May 31, 2016, around 10.45 pm, when a car allegedly driven by Kumar rammed into two cars at Kangoo near Sundernagar. Former MLA Sohan Lal Thakur was said to be travelling in one of those vehicles, along with his driver, Dharmender, and police security officer Parkash Chand. On October 15, 2023, the Court of Chief Judicial Magistrate sentenced Kumar to six months' imprisonment and fined Rs 1,000 for offences under sections 279 (rash driving) and 337 (causing hurt due to negligent act) of the erstwhile Indian Penal Code. The additional sessions court held that the police deliberately withheld evidence during the trial.

The court noted that the prosecution failed to identify Kumar as the sole driver of the vehicle, because it was revealed that three other persons were also in the car and it could not be conclusively proved who was behind the wheel at the time of the accident. (PTI)

Justice Mahabir Singh Sindhu passes away



Justice Mahabir Singh Sindhu, a sitting judge of the Punjab and Haryana High Court, passed away at a hospital in Gurugram on Sunday. Singh, 59, had been unwell for some time, officials said. Justice Sindhu was elevated as an additional judge of the high court on July 10, 2017, before being appointed a permanent judge on December 2, 2018. Born on April 4, 1967, in a small agriculturist family, Sindhu hailed from Masudpur village in Haryana's Hisar district. He received his LLB degree in 1992 from the Panjab University in Chandigarh, before enrolling as an advocate with the Bar Council of Punjab and Haryana.

He practised civil, criminal, constitutional and service laws, mainly in the Punjab and Haryana High Court here. During his career, Justice Sindhu represented several institutions, including municipal councils, Government boards/corporations, the Haryana Public Service Commission, and the Kurukshetra University.

In 1999, he was appointed additional Central Government standing counsel in the high court and in 2000, as additional Government pleader, Union territory of Chandigarh. He later served as a deputy advocate general, Haryana, from 2004 to 2008. In September 2008, he was appointed additional advocate general, Punjab, a post he held till December 2009. He was then appointed additional advocate general, Haryana, in December 2009. He resigned from the AG office in February 2013 and resumed private practice. In 2016, he was included in the panel of advocates to represent the high court as well as subordinate courts in Punjab, Haryana and Chandigarh. Punjab Assembly Speaker Kulraj Singh Sandhwan expressed grief over the demise of Justice Sindhu. (PTI)

CPI(M) top leadership conspired in attack on its officers, ED tells court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The ED on Monday told a court that the attack on its officers after they carried out a search at the residence of former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan in connection with a money laundering case involving his daughter was the result of a conspiracy engineered by the top leadership of the CPI(M).

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) made the allegation in an objection filed before the Thiruvananthapuram District and Sessions Court opposing the bail plea of the 12th accused, Lenin Raj. Last month, an ED team conducted a search at the rented house where Vijayan was staying in



Ex- Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan

Thiruvananthapuram as part of a money laundering probe involving his daughter, Veena T.

While the ED officials and security personnel were returning after the search, CPI(M) activists allegedly blocked their vehicles and damaged

them. A case was registered against around 300 people, and several CPI(M) activists were arrested.

The controversy intensified after the ninth accused, Harish Kumar, was granted bail by a district court.

The police claimed they had submitted a report citing 13 grounds for opposing the bail application, but alleged that the then public prosecutor did not place their objections before the court. The ED later moved the court, seeking to implead itself in the case, and also approached the Kerala High Court, challenging the bail granted to Kumar. In its objection petition, the ED alleged that the attack on its officers was the outcome of a criminal conspiracy involving the CPI(M)'s top leadership.



Defections or new device of power play?



DEVENDER SINGH ASWAL

Defections have been synonymous with the politics of *Aaya Ram* and *Gaya Ram*. But the recent spate in defections seem to be a 'method in madness'— in the game of power play. The insatiable lure of lucre and office behind defections was sought to be curbed by the 52nd and 91st Constitution Amendments, but defections continue unabated.

In fact, the pejorative of *Aaya Rams* and *Gaya Rams* has become a thing of the past. In the new normal, defectors claim to be the rebellious knights-at-arms of the republic. The anti defection law envisages disqualification of a legislator if he voluntarily gives up membership of his political party or votes or abstains from voting in the legislature in violation of the party directive. It also provides that disqualification on ground of defections will not apply if two-thirds of the legislators split in a legislature party. This salutary provision of the law has been grossly abused overtime.

The anti defection law, enshrined in the Tenth Schedule to the Constitution, provides that if any question of disqualification arises on ground of defection or any claim arises related to merger of a political party or formation of a new political party after a split, it shall be decided by the Speaker, (or the Chairman, as the case may be) whose decision shall be final. Interestingly, the law as enacted,



barred jurisdiction of courts. But, later, thankfully, the Supreme Court in *Kihoto Hollohon v. Zachillu* and others (1992) declared that the decisions of the presiding officers shall be subject to judicial review, which is an integral part of the basic structure doctrine.

The most recent case of whole sale defection or split is of the Rajya Sabha members of Aam Aadmi Party, who defected and merged with the BJP Legislature Party. The Chairman Rajya Sabha approved the merger without much hassle as the defecting group constituted clear two-thirds of Aam Aadmi Legislature party in the Rajya Sabha. However, legal luminaries continue to debate the merger.

Some describe the merger “unconstitutional”. They opine that the anti defection law permits merger only if the party is merged first, and “anyone cannot simply merge on their own.”

Notably, after recognition of the said split, there is a spurt in defections led by the MPs of the TMC and Shiv Sena Uddhav (UBT) in the Lok Sabha. Out of 29 MPs of TMC, 20 MPs have joined the National Citizens Party of India, (NCPi) a registered but unrecognised obscure Political party. Also, there has been a revolt in the TMC

West Bengal Legislative Assembly as 58 MLAs, out of 80, have formed a separate block and its leader has been recognised as LoP by the Assembly Speaker with great despatch. The decision stands challenged in the Kolkatta High Court on the ground that it's not a case of merger.

Also, 6 of the 9 MPs of Shiv Sena (UTB) are said to have crossed over to Eknath Shinde led- Shiv Sena. The rebel MPs of both have met the Speaker Lok Sabha and sought recognition for their merger on the ground that they constitute two-thirds of their respective legislature party. Per contra, both the original parties have urged the Speaker to disqualify the rebel MPs on the ground that such a merger can be recognised if two-thirds of the entire political party merges with another political party.

Such a spate in defections is a matter of grave concern for every-one passionate about our democracy. It's speculated whether these defections reflect lack of ideological commitment; sheer pursuit for naked power; lack of intra party democracy; or, they are part of a larger design? Are we really heading for the beginning of end of multi party democracy? Is it conceivable to watch and control the Govt., to

throw the light of publicity on its acts', without effective opposition?

In this view of the matter, the anti defection law casts a great responsibility on the Speaker, who, as a high Constitutional Tribunal, has to decide the petitions before him. The petitions regarding recognition of mergers qua disqualification of the defecting MPs are in the High Court of the Hon'ble Speaker, Lok Sabha. The Tenth Schedule does not impose any time limit on the Speaker, although in *Meghachandra Singh v. Speaker Manipur Legislative Assembly* (SC 2020), the SC ruled that the Manipur Legislative Assembly must decide the case within a reasonable time frame, preferably within 3 months. But that was a case specific and not a general direction.

It is hoped that the Hon'ble Speaker will decide the cases in right earnest, according to the Rules framed by the House - Disqualification on ground of defection Rules, 1995, which unambiguously lay down the procedure for entertaining petitions for disqualification on ground of defection. Every petition thereof is verified in the manner laid down in the Code of Civil Procedure, 1908. If satisfied about the bonafide split, and after assuring himself that the splits have occurred without any external coercion or inducement, the Speaker may, if not found otherwise, approve the merger, bringing down the curtain.

However, there is apprehension that the recognition of such mergers is bound to give further fillip and stimulus to the politics of Aaya Ram and Gaya Ram, and it would negate the very objective of the anti- defection law. But under the law as it stands today, the Speaker has little option but to decide it according to the provisions of the Tenth Schedule. Its pertinent to note that para 4 of the Tenth Schedule allows valid merger

into another political party, but bars formation of a separate party. The defectors therefore choose the escape route of merger with an existing party as did the defectors of Aam Aadmi Party in Rajya Sabha with the BJP and, so is the case of the MPs of TMC and the Shiv Sena (UBT), who have merged with NCPi and Eknath led Shiv Sena, respectively.

In *Subhash Desai v. Governor of Maharashtra* (2023), the SC held that Parliament has recognised the independent existence of a legislature party and that political party and legislature party cannot be conflated. The SC held that had Uddhav Thackeray refrained from resigning, they would have considered the grant of the remedy of reinstating his Government. The splinter group led by Eknath Shinde, though commanding two-thirds majority in the Assembly, had not joined any political party but formed a separate party which is not protected by para 4, Tenth Schedule but they escaped disqualification due to resignation by Uddhav Thackeray, said the Supreme Court. So, the law is settled that if there is a split in the legislature party, and the splintered group, constituting two-thirds, merges with any party, they escape disqualification.

Nevertheless, the allegations of horse trading, betrayal of electoral trust, political uncertainty and the resultant weakening of opposition, remain unaddressed.

The gross inadequacies, the flaws and absurdities in the anti defection law can only be remedied if the Anti defection law is amended to provide that the defecting legislators shall lose their membership and shall stand debarred from contesting election for five years, at least.

The author is Lawyer and former Secretary, Lok Sabha

Ram temple donation row: SC refuses urgent hearing on plea seeking fair probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday refused urgent hearing on a plea seeking a fair and time-bound probe into the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

A bench of Justices MM Sundresh and Sheel Nagu said the matter will be listed for hearing after the summer break. “Heavens are not going to fall. What is the urgency,” the bench observed orally.

The petition, filed by advocates Ajay Kumar Rai and Dinesh Kumar Yadav, said a CBI-led multi-disciplinary special investigation team (SIT) should investigate the alleged financial irregularities and other purported illegalities concerning the affairs and administration of the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

The petition calling for an FIR in the matter also sought directions to the Centre, the Uttar Pradesh Government and the temple trust to constitute and operationalise such regulatory, super-



visory and audit mechanisms as may be necessary to safeguard public interest and maintain the confidence of millions of devotees and donors.

“Whether or not the reports regarding missing funds and other alleged irregularities concerning the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust are ultimately found to be true, such reports have caused deep concern among the generations that struggled for the restoration of the glory of Ayodhya,” the plea said. The SIT constituted by the Uttar Pradesh Government has commenced its inquiry into the matter without the registration of an FIR or any regular criminal case, it alleged. The plea

said the veracity of reports concerning alleged missing funds and other purported irregularities involving the temple trust ought to be independently verified through a professional investigation conducted by a unified agency possessing the requisite expertise, resources and institutional mechanisms for handling complex financial and criminal investigations.

“Such an inquiry would inspire greater public confidence than a preliminary probe conducted by a special investigation team (SIT) comprising administrative officers who may not possess specialised credentials in criminal investigation,” the plea said.

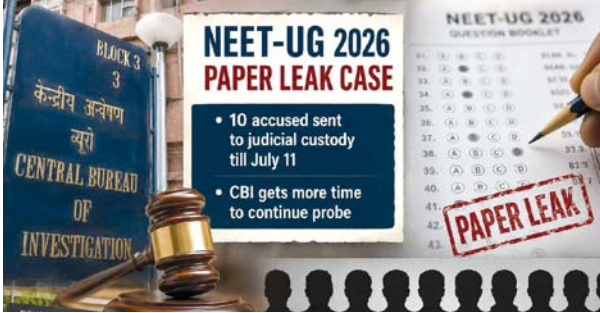
It said the issues involved not only concern the possible commission of cognisable offences but also directly affect the faith, sentiments and confidence of countless devotees and the public. On June 13, the Uttar Pradesh Government constituted the SIT on a request from the temple trust following allegations of misappropriation of donations received at the Ram temple.

NEET leak: Court extends judicial custody of 10 accused

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Monday extended the judicial custody of 10 accused arrested in connection with the NEET-UG 2026 examination leak till July 11.

Special Judge Vijeta Singh Rawat was hearing the Central Bureau of Investigation's (CBI) plea filed by Special Public Prosecutor VK Pathak to extend their custody for further investigation in the case and allowed the plea. Ten of the 13 accused arrested in the case were produced virtually before the court after their judicial custody ended on Monday. The court extended the judi-



cial custody of Yash Yadav, Mangilal Biwal, Dinesh Biwal, Vikas Biwal, Dhananjay Lokhande, Tejas Harshad Shah, Shubham Khairnar, Manisha Waghamare, Manisha Havaladar and Dr Manoj Shirure. From the remaining three accused, the alleged

kingpin P V Kulkarni and Shivraj Raghunath Motegaonkar have already been sent to judicial custody till July 8. Another accused, Manisha Gurunath Mandhare was sent to 14 days' judicial custody till June 30 by the court. On May 12, the National

Testing Agency (NTA) cancelled the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, held on May 3 for medical admissions amid allegations of paper leak. A re-exam was conducted on June 21.

More than 20 lakh medical aspirants took a second shot at the NEET re-exam after the original test was cancelled due to paper leaks, an issue that became a hot potato for the Government.

The CBI registered a case in connection with the paper leak based on a written complaint received from the Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education.

Delhi HC asks CAT to examine candidate's plea alleging wrong answers in answer key

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has asked the Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT) to examine a candidate's plea alleging that the suggested answers to certain questions in the official answer key for Forest Service Examination 2022 were incorrect.

A bench of Justice C Hair Shankar and Justice O P Shukla said the tribunal erred in rejecting the candidate's plea on grounds that a candidate has no absolute right to seek re-evaluation of his examination papers. The



court said in the present case, the petitioner was not seeking re-evaluation of examination papers, but was merely questioning correct-

ness of the suggested answers in the model answer key released by the authorities. Remitting the matter back to the tribunal for fresh



HC overturns bail in Janakpuri school rape case; asks caretaker to surrender

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday cancelled the bail granted to a 57-year-old private school caretaker accused of raping a three-year-old girl on the premises in west Delhi's Janakpuri area, and asked him to surrender on July 1.

A vacation bench of Justice Vinod Kumar passed the verdict on the pleas by the Delhi Police and the complainant against the trial court's May 7 decision to release Lalit Kumar on bail in the case under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

“I have agreed with the State and the petitioner (complainant). Both petitions are allowed. Accused Lalit Kumar is directed to surrender before the jurisdictional POCSO court on July 1 at 2 pm,” said Justice Kumar.

Additional Solicitor General SV Raju, appearing for the police, had earlier argued that it was not a case where the trial court should have given a reprieve to

the main accused, i.e. the caretaker. He had submitted that it was a clear case of aggravated penetrative sexual assault under Section 6 of the POCSO Act, which was punishable with a minimum term of 20 years in jail, as the child had already identified the perpetrator and made specific allegations.

The counsel for the accused had denied all allegations of sexual assault against him, stating that the “foundational facts” of the present case cannot be sustained. The incident came to light on May 1 when the girl's mother filed a complaint at Janakpuri police station, alleging that her daughter was sexually assaulted during school hours by the accused. According to the complaint, the child had gone to the school on April 30, the second day after her admission.

After returning home, she complained of pain. When questioned by her mother, the girl said that she was taken to an isolated area in the school, where the man allegedly assaulted her.

consideration, the bench said there was no bar on a court examining such a contention and it can even interfere if the suggested answers are patently incorrect.

“Of course, where the matter is arguable, or where the suggested answer in the answer key is even a plausible answer, the Court would not interfere. Where, however, the answer is demonstrably unacceptable, the Court would definitely interfere ex debito justitiae (as a matter of right),” said the court in the judgement passed May 29.

PIOTECH

From Hijli to the world: The IITs Go Global

PRABHAT KUMAR

The Indian Institutes of Technology have arrived on the world stage — not as exporters of talent, but as institutions planting their flags on foreign soil. On 26 June 2026, IIT Bombay announced its first-ever overseas sub-campus in the United States, in collaboration with the State University of New York (SUNY) at Old Westbury. Beginning with certificate programmes in artificial intelligence, sustainability, and clean technology from 2027, the institute plans to develop full-fledged degree programmes open to students from across the globe. This is not merely an academic partnership. It is a declaration that the IIT brand has come of age.

The Seeds Have Been Planted

This was not a sudden decision. The IITs have been methodically expanding their global footprint. In 2023, IIT Madras established the first-ever international campus of an IIT in Zanzibar, Tanzania. In 2024, IIT Delhi inaugurated its campus in Abu Dhabi, welcoming its inaugural cohort of students. Now, IIT Bombay is taking the IIT brand to the United States — the very country that once “imported” IIT talent through the brain drain pipeline.

From Hijli to Zanzibar. From Kharagpur to Abu Dhabi. From Bombay to New York. The IITs are no longer just India’s temples of learning—they are becoming global institutions.

Why This Matters

This expansion is not about building monuments abroad. It is about taking the IIT ethos—the rigour, the hustle, the frugal innovation, the first-principles problem-solving—to the world. Brand Globalisation. Twenty-three years ago, in 2003, CBS’s 60 Minutes aired its iconic segment “Imported from India,” where Lesley Stahl told millions of viewers: “Put Harvard, MIT and Princeton together, and you begin to get an idea of the status of this school in India.” IIT undergraduates, she noted, “leave their American counterparts in the dust.” That segment captured the world’s awe of the IITs. Today, the IITs are not waiting to be discovered—they are taking their brand to the world’s most prestigious academic markets. Reverse Brain Drain. For decades, we lamented the exodus of our brightest minds. The 1970s saw 68 per cent of IIT graduates leave for American shores. Today, the tide is turning. IIT Bombay’s sub-campus in the US will not primarily serve Indian students. As Director Shireesh Kedare clarified, “The courses will be open to American students and students from around the world. The idea is not to admit Indian students through JEE (Advanced) there.” This is a reversal of the old model. Instead of Indians going abroad for education, the world will come to IIT—even on American soil.

Financial Sustainability. Revenue generated through these overseas programmes can be reinvested to strengthen research infrastructure in India, including advanced laboratories and new research centres. International campuses can add an additional revenue source for IITs, charging higher fees and, if properly managed, channelling surplus funds back to the main campus. This is not charity; it is strategic institution-building.

The T-Rex on American Streets

In my book, I describe the IITs as a T-Rex in the global education ecosystem—a creature of immense power, legacy and primordial instinct. That T-Rex is now walking the streets of America just like ‘The Lost World’ the movie from Spielberg. The same rigour that built the IITs from the ruins of Hijli will now shape classrooms in New York. The same hustle that produced the Bhakra Brigade will now produce engineers who work across continents. From Silicon Valley to the Indus Valley—and Beyond my appeal to the global IIT diaspora has been simple: From Silicon Valley to the Indus Valley. Build here, scale here, die here. But that appeal was never about isolation. It was about choice. It was about creating an ecosystem where IITians could build world-class careers in India—not because they had no other option, but because the most exciting opportunities were at home. Today, that ecosystem is maturing. The India AI Mission, the ₹1.2 lakh crore RDI fund, the National Quantum

Mission, the semiconductor push—all of these are creating opportunities that did not exist a decade ago. The IITs are no longer just suppliers of talent to the world. They are becoming institutions that the world seeks out. The Hijli watchtower still stands—not as a relic, but as a beacon. Its light now falls on a startup in Bengaluru, a policy desk in Delhi, a manufacturing facility in Chennai and a research lab in California. And soon, it will fall on a classroom in New York. The IIT story is India’s story. And the next chapter—the chapter of IITs going global—is being written now. Earlier the IITians have taken the IIT spirit abroad but now the institution itself is taking the IIT spirit to the world.

(The author is a 1994-batch IRS officer, Chairman of Pan IIT Alumni India, and author of ‘IIT: The Story of India’s Most Prestigious Educational Ecosystem’ (HarperCollins India)



Why India wants its own internet root server from ICANN

India wants to host a key piece of the internet on its own soil. It is a good idea — but it can’t do everything people are promising



NISHANT SAHDEV

Every time you open a website, send an email or run a search, your phone or computer has to do one thing first. It has to find the address.

You typed a name — say, “thepioneer.com.” But machines don’t understand names. They understand numbers. So your device asks: which number goes with this name? That question travels up a chain of computers until it reaches the very top of the internet’s address book. At the top sit a small set of machines called root servers. For most of the internet’s history, they have been based in the United States. For a country with more than a billion people online, that can feel like depending on someone else for something basic. That feeling is what’s driving India’s push to bring a root server home.

On June 19, a senior official raised the idea again. Speaking at an event held by the National Internet Exchange of India (NIXI), the body that runs much of the country’s internet backbone, IT Secretary S Krishnan said India has been asking ICANN — the international organisation that oversees the internet’s address system — to place a root server in the country. His reasons: India has a huge online population, and the network should be more resilient. The request isn’t new. India first raised it at least two years ago, and a parliamentary report in February 2024 pushed for it too, pointing to a rise in cyber and terror-linked attacks. Krishnan admitted the process is slow, and said India is building backups in other ways as well.

To see why this matters — or doesn’t — it helps to know what a root server actually does.

Think of the internet’s address system as a giant phone book. You know the name. The machine needs the number. This system, called DNS, looks up the number for you. The phone book is organised in layers, and the root servers sit at the top. They don’t know the address of every website in the world. They simply know where to send your question next — to whoever handles “in,” or “.com,” or “.org”. From there, your question is passed down the chain until it reaches the right place. It is the first signpost on a very fast trip — one that happens billions of times a day, in a fraction of a second. Here is where most people get it wrong. They picture 13 lonely computers sitting in a basement somewhere abroad. That’s not how it



works. There are 13 “addresses” at the top of the system, run by 12 organisations. But each address isn’t a single machine. Each one is copied onto thousands of computers spread across the world — more than 2,000 of them today. When your device sends its question, it’s answered by whichever copy is closest to you. You never know which one replied, and you never need to. It works a bit like a single phone number that automatically connects you to the nearest branch of a chain: same number, but the

connect. So you’re stuck. A copy that stays identical gives India no special control; it’s just another mirror. And a copy that’s changed in any way simply stops working. The only way to run a truly separate Indian root is to cut India’s internet off from everyone else’s. That isn’t independence. That’s breaking the internet into pieces — what experts call the “splinternet.” A policy paper by the think tank ICRIER reaches the same conclusion: there is no real difference between a copy and the so-called original. They are the same thing.

There’s a second problem, and it matters even more given the security fears behind India’s push. The address system isn’t actually the weak spot. If the real

worry is an enemy knocking India offline during a crisis, the dangerous targets are elsewhere — the physical cables on the ocean floor, the way internet traffic is steered between networks, the basic rules that move data around. A root server in Mumbai does nothing about any of that. It won’t stop a cable being cut or traffic being hijacked. The real fix is to build separate, self-contained networks for the places that truly need them — defence systems, the Prime Minister’s Office — not a public root server whose main product is a feeling of safety.

So why does almost every ambitious country now want a piece of this? Because “internet sovereignty” has become a global trend. The idea makes sense on its face: a country shouldn’t have to depend on rules, companies or hardware it can’t influence. Europe is writing laws about which cloud providers its Government may use. Countries from the Gulf to Southeast Asia are keeping data and equipment on home soil. Hosting a piece of the internet’s backbone is partly practical and

partly a statement. It says a country with a billion users deserves a seat at the table where these systems are run — not just a spot in the waiting room.

That argument isn’t empty. For a long time, control of the internet’s core has sat mostly in the West. India’s basic request — host more of the infrastructure your own people rely on — is completely fair. India is reportedly asking for a full set of copies of all 13 addresses on home soil. As an upgrade, that’s real and worth having. So here is the honest score card. As a practical upgrade, hosting more copies brings small but real gains: faster access, local backup, lower costs, and a stronger voice in the rooms where these decisions are made. As a path to independence, a root server gives India almost nothing. It can’t hand over control India doesn’t already have. It can’t be changed without breaking. And its only truly “sovereign” version — a walled-off Indian internet — would damage the openness that makes the internet worth using in the first place.

The real risk isn’t the server. It’s the story told about it. If “a root server in India” is sold as a shield against some future digital attack, people may believe a problem has been solved when it hasn’t — while the real weak spots get ignored. But if it’s understood for what it is — a sensible local upgrade and a fair claim to a place at the table — then it’s worth doing, and worth not overselling.

So should you care? Care less about where the server physically sits. Care more about whether the people in charge are honest about what it can and can’t do. On the internet, as everywhere else, a power you can’t actually use is just a flag planted on someone else’s map.

(The writer is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems)

Who should be allowed to use artificial intelligence?

SANJAY KAUL AND AASHIVA KAUL

In the early days of automobiles, almost anyone could buy a car and drive it without training. Roads were chaotic and accidents frequent. Eventually, societies realised that powerful machines required responsible users. Driving tests, licenses and traffic laws were introduced not to limit freedom but to protect everyone using the road.

Artificial intelligence may now be approaching a similar moment. Within just a few years, AI systems have become astonishingly capable. With a few prompts, they can generate legal arguments, explain medical symptoms, design financial strategies, write computer code and summarise complex research papers. Tasks that once required years of training can now be approximated in seconds. The democratisation of knowledge is extraordinary. Expertise that once lived inside universities, laboratories and professional institutions is suddenly accessible to anyone with an internet connection.

But this transformation raises a question that public debate has barely begun to confront: “Should everyone be able to use powerful AI systems in specialised fields without any form of certification?” For centuries societies have been careful about who is allowed to exercise expertise where mistakes carry serious consequences. Doctors must obtain medical licenses before treating patients. Lawyers cannot represent clients in court without accreditation. Pilots undergo years of training before flying aircraft carrying hundreds of passengers. Artificial intelligence, by contrast, has entered everyday life with almost no expectations about the competence of the user.



Anyone can ask an AI system to interpret medical symptoms, analyse legal disputes or propose investment strategies. The responses often appear structured, confident and authoritative. Yet AI does not understand truth, responsibility or consequences. It generates responses by predicting patterns from massive datasets. In other words, it can sound knowledgeable even when it is wrong. Artificial intelligence is not merely a tool, it is an amplifier of human capability. In the hands of trained professionals it can accelerate discovery, expand knowledge and improve decision making. But in the hands of those who lack the expertise to evaluate its outputs, it can magnify misunderstanding just as easily. As AI systems become more powerful, their responses will also become more persuasive.

The danger will not necessarily be malicious use but misplaced confidence in answers that appear authoritative. This is why society may eventually need to consider an idea that initially sounds radical

but is entirely consistent with how we manage other powerful technologies, licensing certain uses of artificial intelligence. Such a framework would not restrict everyday interaction with AI like writing assistance, translation, coding help and creative brainstorming could remain widely accessible.

But advanced applications in fields such as medicine, law, engineering, financial advisory and scientific research might require basic certification demonstrating that the user understands the limits of AI-generated information and the importance of verification.

The goal would not be to control knowledge but to align capability with responsibility. Critics will argue that regulating AI use would be impractical. But history suggests that societies eventually adapt when transformative technologies reshape daily life. Aviation, pharmaceuticals and nuclear energy all developed oversight systems once their risks became clear. Artificial intelligence may soon influence decisions affecting health, safety, markets and public policy. As its role expands, the question of user responsibility will only grow more urgent.

Because the greatest risk of artificial intelligence may not be that machines become too intelligent. It may be that humans gain access to extraordinary intelligence tools without ever learning how to use them wisely.

(Sanjay Kaul is a Professor of Energy Management in the School of Business and Technology at Fitchburg State University, who writes on technology, society and global affairs and Aashiva Kaul is Secretary of Centre for Women and Child Rights at Gujarat National Law University. She writes on General Corporate, Dispute Resolution law and Technology law)

India’s AI-Driven agent state needs a sustainable foundation



ROHIT YADAV

A new race is quietly reshaping the global technology landscape. It is no longer just about building the most powerful AI models or manufacturing the fastest chips. The next frontier is using AI to transform how Governments serve citizens. Intelligent systems can anticipate, learn, and meet citizens’ needs, and automate repetitive administrative processes to proactively provide public services rather than simply responding to requests. This is the promise of agentic AI. India enters this race with an advantage that few countries possess.

Agentic AI is not like traditional AI systems, which follow directives from humans; It is a smart system that understands its environment, can engage in reasoning in complex tasks, and can take action on behalf of a person. For instance, instead of informing a citizen that they qualify for a subsidy, an agent could verify eligibility, submit the application, monitor approvals, and notify the beneficiary when funds arrive. The citizen no longer navigates Government offices or multiple portals. The Government comes closer to the citizen.

This shift represents far more than technological progress. Governments have spent decades digitising services. Agentic AI offers the possibility of digitising governance itself.

India has been investing for over 10 years in setting up the digital foundation required for this. Aadhaar provides a trusted identity layer. UPI enables seamless payments. DigiLocker offers secure document access. ONDC demonstrates how open networks can connect multiple participants through common standards.

Collectively, they have developed the rails on which intelligent AI agents can run. The United States has no nationwide digital identity platform. The eIDAS regime is still unevenly adopted in Europe. Unknowingly, India has built one of the most complete DPIs in the world.

Early deployments already demonstrate what this future looks like. In the last two years, the Pradhan Mantri Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana has increased the number of rooftop solar systems from 7.3 lakh to almost 30 lakh households. The first one lakh installations required 118 days; today, the same number is completed in nine days. The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy is working on an interface through WhatsApp to register, monitor progress, and give the citizens a subsidy of up to ₹78,000 in one conversational platform. Chhattisgarh’s CHIPS platform connects departmental databases and scaled annual welfare applications from 30 lakh to nearly 70 lakh without proportionate administrative expansion.

Its AI layer recognises common rejections and can warn applicants prior to submitting. These are not experimental pilots. They are functioning systems pointing toward an Agent State where entitlements find the eligible citizen rather than the other way around.

There is another side to this story that receives far less attention. Every Agentic AI system relies on a physical infrastructure. Operational servers, cooling systems, electricity, and data centres are required for digital interaction. The digital and physical infrastructure, therefore, works in tandem.

According to PwC India, the country’s data centre value chain could generate an order book worth \$280 billion by 2035. Installed capacity is likely to increase from 1.6 GW today to 13.8 GW in 10 years. Direct investment in core facilities



alone may exceed \$71 billion, while spending on chips, servers, and networking equipment could account for another \$180 to \$210 billion.

However, for each digital capability that grows, so do the physical resource requirements. That’s the debate India now has to face. Modern AI infrastructure is rapidly moving beyond the limits of traditional cooling systems. Workloads approaching 150 kW, can be supported by digital cooling, while immersion cooling can exceed even that. These are not routine engineering upgrades. They represent an entirely different scale of energy and water consumption.

A single hyperscale data centre can consume as much water in a day as a small village. Over 60 per cent of the current data centre installed capacity is projected to be in water-stressed regions in India. The geography sharpens the problem further. Hyderabad, Bengaluru, and parts of Maharashtra have attracted major

data centre investments because of connectivity and talent. These cities are already under stress and have shrinking groundwater reserves. Public opposition has emerged in Pune against the allocation of water in the new data centre projects. Unlike electricity, water is a local resource. Every litre diverted to industrial cooling competes with households, agriculture, and small businesses drawing from the same supply. India supports nearly 18 per cent of the world’s population but controls only about 4 per cent of global freshwater. As AI adoption accelerates, this imbalance will become harder to ignore.

Corporate commitments to water positivity are encouraging but insufficient as substitutes for public policy. Replenishing water in one basin does little to relieve stress in another. When it comes to voluntary sustainability reports, there is no uniform methodology, making it challenging to independently assess. Without standardised disclosures, policymakers cannot accurately compare water use across facilities or verify whether conservation targets are being met.

The strategic risks extend beyond water. PwC report highlights that India relies on imports of mechanical, electrical, and plumbing (MEP) equipment in data centres. Many components have long procurement cycles and remain vulnerable to geopolitical disruptions.

A supply chain shock could slow AI infrastructure deployment precisely when demand is rising. Strengthening domestic manufacturing, therefore, becomes a critical part of India’s AI strategy. Production Linked Incentive scheme for critical data centre equipment should be seriously considered, and the manufacturing clusters in the Make in India initiative should be expanded.

(The writer is Assistant Professor, School of Business Management, Narsee Monjee Institute of Management Studies, Mumbai)

FROM THE WORLD

MALAYSIA

MH370 hunt extended

Malaysia has extended for another year its contract with marine robotics company Ocean Infinity for a deep-sea search in the southern Indian Ocean for wreckage of a Malaysia Airlines flight that disappeared 12 years ago. The Cabinet on Friday approved the extension of a “no-find, no-fee” agreement with Ocean Infinity until June 30 next year, Transport Minister Anthony Loke said. “This decision is a manifestation of the Government’s continuous and unwavering commitment to provide a closure for the next of kin of the passengers aboard flight MH370,” he said in a statement. The extension enables Ocean Infinity to complete the remaining 7,428.54-square-kilometre search area, after temporarily redeploying its primary search assets to fulfill other commercial contracts, he said.

AUSTRALIA

Nakamal ties blocks China

Australia and Vanuatu signed a long-awaited bilateral security and economic treaty Monday that prevents China creating a military base on the South Pacific island nation. Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese signed the so-called Nakamal Agreement with his Vanuatu counterpart Jotham Napat in the Australian capital nine months after the Vanuatu Government rejected an earlier draft. Vanuatu had feared the deal would limit its ability to attract infrastructure investment. “Our agreement reflects and confirms Australia’s role as Vanuatu’s largest and most comprehensive economic, security and development partner, a responsibility that we take seriously,” Albanese told reporters. Napat said the pact “reaffirms our shared commitment to continuing and strengthening the comprehensive partnership.”

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that the Bank of Baroda, Surya Nagar Branch, A-13 Rampuri, Ghaziabad, U.P. - 201011, intends to accept the undermentioned property standing in the name of M/s Arun Enterprises, through its partners Shri Charanjit Lal Dhir S/o Shri A.N. Dhir, Shri Arun S/o Shri C.L. Dhir & Shri Tarun S/o Shri C.L. Dhir, as security for the loan credit facility requested by M/s Arun Enterprises, having its Registered Office at B-48, Site-IV, Industrial Area, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh - 201010, India.

If anyone has any right, title, interest, or claim over the undermentioned property, they are advised to approach the Bank within 10 days along with the necessary proof to substantiate their claim.

If no response is received within the stipulated period, it shall be presumed that the property is free from any charge/claim/encumbrance, and the Bank shall proceed with the mortgage.

Details of Property -1: Property No.: B-48, Block-B, UPSIDC Sahibabad Industrial Area, Site-4, Ghaziabad, Tehsil & Distt. Ghaziabad (U.P.) - 201011, Land Area: 7,788.46 Sq. Mtrs., Structure: Two-storied (Ground + First + Mummy) Industrial Building with RCC roof and G.I. Sheet.

Details of Property-2: Property No.: 64/6B, UPSIDC Sahibabad Industrial Area, Site-4, Ghaziabad, Tehsil & Distt. Ghaziabad (U.P.) - 201011, Land Area: 4,103.50 Sq. Mtrs., Structure: Three-storied (Basement + Ground + 2 Floors) Industrial Building, semi-finished, RCC load-bearing frame structure.

Branch Details/Contact No. :-
Mr. Arun Kumar, Branch Head
Contact: +91-6201067245
Bank of Baroda, Surya Nagar Branch, A-13 Rampuri, Ghaziabad, U.P. - 201011

Advocate Details/Contact :-
Deepak Singh, Delhi High Court
Contact: 9999170066

KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED

(A Government of India Undertaking)

OPEN-E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Engineer, Konkan Railway Corporation Ltd. inviting Open E Tender For the following work. **TENDER NO: KR/KW/OL/W/2025/70-CB-RT-1. Name Of The Work:** Provision of Loop line 1 and 2 with 60 Kg Rails and 60Kg Sleepers by laying Yard and linking of track at Sarzora station under SSE/P-way/Madgaon section over Konkan Railway in Goa State (Comp No 67302). **Cost Of The Work In Lakhs:** ₹.82.03 Lakh (Excluding GST) **Closing Date & Time: 14/07/2026 at 15.00 Hrs.** For further details, contact Office of Sr. Divisional Engineer, Konkan Railway Corporation Ltd. Karwar. For more details visit (<https://www.ireps.gov.in>)

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e - TENDER

Delhi Transco Ltd., a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, invites online tender for the work : **Tender No. T25P111924: Design, Supply, Erection, Testing & Commissioning of 33 KV GIS with complete civil works at various 220 KV Substation of DTL on turnkey basis. (IP, Parkstreet, Wazirpur, Naraina & Okhla)**

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites:- <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_294402_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-0063-250626

Last date for bid submission:- **14.08.2026, 01:30 P.M.**

All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/Date of Extension/Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kabul

Pak strikes Afghanistan border, Kabul claims 36 civilians dead

Overnight airstrikes by Pakistani forces have killed at least 36 civilians and injured more than 160 others, Afghan officials said Monday, as tensions between the neighbours further escalated.

Pakistani security forces carried out a ground operation along the Pakistan-Afghanistan border late Sunday, followed by strikes against militant hideouts and safe havens, killing 29 fighters, Pakistan’s Information Minister Attaullah Tarar said. They said the operations were launched in response to multiple militant attacks across Pakistan.

Afghanistan condemned the strikes as a “cowardly act of aggression” and an “act of brutality.”

Hamdullah Fitrat, the deputy spokesman for Afghanistan’s



Residents walking through the rubble in the Village of Mandokhai Afghanistan

Taliban Government, said the Pakistani forces targeted a home in Chamkani district, in Paktia province, killing an elderly man and a child, while other family members were injured. When residents gathered to rescue people, the area was struck again, killing 28 villagers and wounding 158, he said.

Six people, mostly women and children, were killed in a village in Giyan district, Paktika province, when another home was struck, he said. A civilian home in Kunar province was also hit, causing no casualties but killing some 30 livestock.

Militant attacks targeting Pakistan’s police and security forces have surged in recent years. Authorities have blamed the Pakistani Taliban - known as Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan, or TTP

- and allied militant groups for most of the violence.

The Pakistani Taliban are separate from but allied with the Afghan Taliban that returned to power in 2021.

The Pakistani security operation followed a militant attack targeting the regional headquarters of the paramilitary Rangers in Karachi that killed three soldiers. Security forces killed three attackers and arrested another assailant, whom the military identified as an Afghan national in wounded condition.

Jamaat-ul-Ahrar, a breakaway faction of the Pakistani Taliban, claimed responsibility for the Karachi attack.

Sunday’s cross-border strikes and ground operation came less than three weeks after Pakistan’s military launched airstrikes on

what it said were militant hideouts in Afghanistan. They ended about a month of relative calm following what Islamabad had described as an “open war” between the neighboring countries, despite international efforts to broker a lasting peace.

The escalation follows months of tit-for-tat military action. Hundreds of people have been killed in cross-border fighting since February, when Afghanistan launched retaliatory strikes after Pakistan carried out airstrikes inside Afghan territory.

Multiple rounds of talks have failed to secure a lasting ceasefire. China also hosted the two sides in April and Beijing later said Pakistan and Afghanistan had agreed not to escalate their conflict and to explore a solution.

WAFAA SHURAF/ SAMY MAGDY ■ Deir Al-Balah

Child among 3 killed in Israeli Gaza strike

An Israeli airstrike killed at least three Palestinians, including a child, in the Gaza Strip on Monday, after hitting a tent sheltering displaced people that Israel said housed a militant.

Health authorities in the coastal enclave said the strike hit a neighbourhood in Deir al-Balah, one of the least damaged towns in central Gaza. Al-Aqsa Martyrs Hospital said the fatalities were two men and an 8-year-old while a third man was wounded.

Israel’s military identified the target as Zaher Abu Salem, who it said was a member of Islamic Jihad and was involved in the October 7, 2023, attack on Israel that triggered the war. While the heaviest fighting has subsided since a ceasefire took hold in October, Israeli forces have carried out repeated airstrikes, killing 1,045

Palestinians, according to health officials in Gaza.

Israel has announced a series of strikes targeting militants, including three over the weekend.

The ministry, which is part of the Hamas-led Government, maintains detailed casualty records that are seen as generally reliable by UN agencies and independent experts. But it does not give a breakdown of civilians and militants.

Militants have carried out shooting attacks on troops, and Israel says its strikes are in response to that and other violations. Five Israeli soldiers have been killed since the ceasefire.

The October 7 attack by militants on Israel killed some 1,200 people and saw 251 taken hostage.

Israel’s retaliatory offensive in Gaza has killed more than 73,058 Palestinians, including those killed since the ceasefire, Gaza’s Health Ministry said. (AP)



PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Anita Devi owner Property No. 574-F, Area 57.1/2 sq yds, Kharsa no. 94/24, B Block, Gali No. 4, Baba Colony, Barari Delhi, and My Client Purchased afore-said property from Ved Prakash vide notarized GPA, ATS and Will dated 10.08.2016 now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

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HANNA ARHIROVA/ BARRY HATTON ■ Kyiv

Russian strikes kill 8, wound 35 in Ukraine

Russian missiles and drones killed at least eight civilians and injured 35 others in Ukraine on Monday in what Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy described as “horrific attacks”.

Since Russia launched its all-out invasion of its neighbour more than four years ago, its forces have conducted strategic bombing in an effort to destroy the country’s infrastructure and sap Ukrainian morale. More than 16,000 Ukrainian civilians have been

killed, according to the UN.

A Russian missile targeting infrastructure struck the central city of Dnipro, killing five people and wounding 29, Zelenskyy said on social media. Russian drones also hit a passenger minibus in the southern city of Zaporizhzhia, killing three and wounding six, including a child, he said.

In addition, Russia drones killed a 69-year-old woman and a 77-year-old man in Ukraine’s northeastern Sumy region, National Police said.

SEEMA HAKHU KACHRU ■ Houston

Indian-American community across Texas celebrate 250 years of US independence

Indian-American communities across Texas organised events to commemorate America’s 250th independence anniversary, with programmes highlighting the deepening India-US partnership.

The events were organised in Houston and Dallas-Fort Worth over the weekend. Consul General D C Manjunath attended the “250 Years of USA Independence Day” celebration in Frisco, organised by the India Association of North Texas, where he met with newly elected Mayor Mark Hill and city council members, according to a social media post on



X by the Consulate General of India in Houston on Sunday. The United States celebrates its Independence Day on July 4.

The “enduring friendship and growing partnership between India and the United States” was highlighted during the event, the consulate said. Over 2,500 Indian

Americans attended a parallel festival on Saturday at Independence Park in Pearland, featuring cultural performances by children, a 26-flag US display and a Declaration of Independence exhibit. Newly elected Pearland Mayor Quentin Wiltz said the community values diversity and recognises contributions made by Americans of Indian heritage.

The BAPS Shri Swaminarayan Mandir in Houston also celebrated the 250th anniversary as an official America250 supporting partner, hosting a ceremony featuring patriotic and traditional musical presentations by children and youth volunteers. (PTI)

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Caracas

Indian Army field hospital begins operations in Venezuela

An Indian Army field hospital, deployed in earthquake-hit Venezuela under Operation Amistad, has become fully operational and is providing free round-the-clock medical services, officials said on Monday.

The Indian Embassy in Venezuela said an Indian medical team comprising highly experienced doctors has established a camp at the International La Rinconada Racetrack in Caracas.

The medical camp is “now fully operational. Services are open 24 hours. All ser-



Indian Army personnel attending to an earthquake-affected person under Operation Amistad in Venezuela

vices are free,” it said in a social media post. The 7.2 and 7.5-magnitude earthquakes that struck Wednesday evening were

among the strongest in Venezuela in more than a century and were felt throughout the region.

The death toll from two

powerful quakes in Venezuela rose to 1,450 on Sunday, with thousands more injured and many more missing. Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal, in a social media post, also said that Operation Amistad is “underway” in Venezuela. The Army field hospital is extending “a caring hand to those impacted by the earthquake”, he said. Indian Army doctors are taking care of people, Jaiswal said, adding that Venezuelan vice health minister and head of Government of the Capital District of Venezuela visited the field hospital.

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Berlin

2 arrested after 6 killed in German facility shooting

Six people were killed in a shooting on Monday at a youth welfare facility in the northern German town of Stade, police said. Two people were arrested, including the suspected shooter.

Other people were wounded, police said, but they did not give a figure.

Police said the shooting took place in the facility on Dankersstrasse, a street south of the town centre. That facility includes temporary accommodation for pregnant women or young mothers with children. There



was no danger to the public, police said. Video footage after the shooting showed a large police presence, along with other emergency service personnel and several ambulances on a residential street.

Two suspects were arrested, one of whom is believed to have fired the shots.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

India, Saudi Arabia ink MoU to boost water cooperation

India and Saudi Arabia have signed a Memorandum of Understanding to boost cooperation on water resource management, according to an official statement on Monday.

The agreement was signed at the inaugural edition of Saudi Arabia’s national water conference, Saudi Water Week, being hosted in Jeddah. “A significant step in advancing the India-Saudi Arabia strategic partnership,” said the Indian embassy in Riyadh on Monday.

The Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) was signed by Indian ambassador Suhel Khan and Abdulrahman Abdulmohsen AlFadley, minister of environment, water and agriculture in Saudi Arabia.

Consul General of India Fahad Suri was also present during the signing.

“The MoU aims to foster collaboration, strengthen capacity building, and facilitate the exchange of best practices in water resources planning, sustainable water management, irrigation systems, and other related areas,” the Indian mission said.



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SWREL bags \$560-mn solar project in Egypt

Sterling and Wilson Renewable Energy on Monday said it has secured an order worth around \$560 million in Egypt. Once complete, this 1,000 MW-capacity solar power project integrated with a 600 MWh Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) will become one of Egypt's largest utility-scale renewable energy developments, Sterling and Wilson Renewable Energy Limited (SWREL) said in a statement.

"SWREL, in a 50-50 joint venture with Hassan Allam Construction, has secured an order valued at approximately \$560 million for the West Minya Solar Power Project in Minya Governorate, Egypt," it noted. The joint venture will be responsible for the full engineering, procurement, and construction of the solar power plant, including the installation of photovoltaic generation facilities, battery energy storage infrastructure, grid interconnection works, transmission facilities. (PTI)

Eleven infuses ₹216 crore into financial services business

Eleven, a diversified group with interests in healthcare, financial services and energy, on Monday said it has invested ₹216 crore in its financial services business, including its NBFC arm. With the latest infusion, the group's total investment in the business rose to ₹470 crore over the last four years through a mix of primary and secondary investments, Eleven said in a statement.

The investment reflects Eleven's continued focus on building a scaled financial services franchise, the company said, adding that its NBFC arm, SVCL, has served more than 19 lakh customers cumulatively and disbursed over ₹10,000 crore in credit since inception. (PTI)

Zerodha plans to foray into investment banking space

Online brokerage firm Zerodha has applied to capital markets regulator Sebi for a merchant banking licence as it looks to expand its financial services offerings. The application was filed through its wholly-owned subsidiary Zerodha Corporate Advisors Pvt Ltd, according to Sebi records.

The application, submitted on April 27, is currently under review. If the licence is granted, Zerodha will be able to manage Initial Public Offerings (IPOs), advise companies on fund raising, and offer other merchant banking services.

Currently, the broking house has over 1.6 crore customers, who place billions of orders every year. Apart from its brokerage business, Zerodha manages its own mutual fund operations through Zerodha AMC.

Moreover, 12 more applications including those from InCred Capital Financial Services, Neo Wealth Management and Societe Generale Securities India have been filed with Sebi seeking clearance for a merchant banking licence, the regulator's website showed. (PTI)

Tata to complete Iveco deal by September: Chandrasekaran

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Commercial vehicle maker Tata Motors has secured the majority of regulatory approvals for the Iveco acquisition, and the transaction is likely to be completed by the second quarter of this fiscal, Chairman N Chandrasekaran said on Monday.

The combined revenue of Tata Motors and Iveco at the time of the merger will be around \$25 billion with a potential to grow to \$35-billion in the next five years, Chandrasekaran said at the second Annual General Meeting of Tata Motors held here virtually.

"Over the period of the next five years, it has got a sig-

nificant potential to grow to \$35-billion. So there is a lot of growth opportunity, and there are a lot of synergies," Chandrasekaran said.

The proposed acquisition of the Iveco Group marks a significant strategic step forward in advancing the company's global ambitions. A transac-

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | JUNE 30, 2026

Experts welcome Delhi's new EV policy, seek better charging network

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Experts have welcomed the Delhi government's EV Policy, saying its proposed phase-out of petrol and CNG-powered two- and three-wheelers and incentives for zero-emission vehicles could significantly reduce vehicular pollution in the national capital.

Sharif Qamar, Fellow and Associate Director at The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI), described it as a forward-looking policy that could serve as a model for other states.

"The policy gives a good framework which can result in a reduction in vehicular emissions in Delhi in the next few years," he said, adding that states in the Indo-Gangetic plains, which witness a sharp rise in pollu-

tion during winter, could benefit from a similar approach.

Qamar said the policy was also likely to attract private investment and strengthen the city's EV ecosystem.

However, he stressed a significant expansion in charging infrastructure for the policy to become a success.

Maruti Suzuki onboards five startups to co-create solutions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Car market leader Maruti Suzuki India on Monday said it has onboarded five startups to co-create solutions across multiple business areas to enhance operational efficiency and elevate customer experience.

The five startups are MiniMines, Easework AI, Sarvam AI, Siftly and CodeMate AI – winners of the 5th cohort of the Maruti Suzuki Incubation Program (MSIP), the company said in a statement. Commenting on the development, Maruti Suzuki India Managing Director & CEO Hisashi Takeuchi said the company has been actively working

with startups to co-create innovative and practical solutions to address real business challenges.

"One of these startups, MiniMines, will support us in safely recycling end-of-life batteries, while the other four startups will help improve customer engagement and drive efficiency across our business operations," he added.

Gold rebounds ₹1,300 after 3-days; silver slides ₹2,000

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Snapping the three-day falling streak, gold prices rebounded by ₹1,300 to ₹1.46 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Monday on value buying by traders.

According to the All India Sarafa Association, gold of 99.9 per cent purity increased by ₹1,300 to ₹1.46,600 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) from the previous close of ₹1,45,300 per 10 grams on Thursday. Bullion markets were closed on Friday for Muharram. However, silver fell for the fourth consecutive session, declining by ₹2,000 to ₹2,24,000 per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes). In the previous session, the white metal had settled at ₹2,26,000 per kg.

Analysts attributed the

recovery in gold to bargain buying after the recent correction, while silver continued to mirror weakness in the overseas markets.

"Silver prices faced downward pressure in the domestic market on Monday amid ongoing global uncertainties," said Gaurav Garg,

Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk.

In the international markets, spot gold fell by \$54.14, or 1.32 per cent, to \$4,035.12 per ounce, and silver declined nearly 3 per cent to \$57.62 per ounce.

"Crude oil prices in the global markets and US dollar

capacity for private users.

He also called for greater participation by housing societies, resident welfare associations, and apartment complexes in setting up charging facilities.

Anumita Roychowdhury, Executive Director at the Centre for Science and Environment, said the decision to allow only electric three-wheelers and N1 trucks to be registered from next year was a welcome move.

"Along with subsidies on new purchases, there was an urgent need for a legal mandate to properly implement the new EV policy so that the desired results to reduce vehicular emissions can be achieved," she said.

According to Roychowdhury, two-wheelers are a major contributor to vehicular emissions in Delhi.

Sensex falls 370 points on geopolitical tensions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty ended lower on Monday as renewed hostilities between the US and Iran and rising oil prices unnerved investors.

Profit booking in select counters and selling pressure in IT, auto and oil stocks also dragged the benchmarks lower, traders said.

The 30-share BSE Sensex declined 372.10 points, or 0.48 per cent, to settle at 76,728.37. During the day, it tanked 478.72 points, or 0.62 per cent, to 76,621.75. A total of 2,629 stocks declined, while 1,712 advanced and 218 remained unchanged on the BSE.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 109.75 points, or 0.46 per cent, to end at 23,946.25. "Geopolitical tensions escalated sharply over the weekend as the US and Iran exchanged attacks over the Strait of Hormuz before agreeing to halt hostilities and renew

Index	Open	High	Low	Close	Change
BSE SENSEX	77,095.21	77,100.47	76,728.37	76,358.27	-372.10 (-0.48%)

Top Losers	Change	Top Gainers	Change
Kotak Bank	-3.24	ETERNAL	1.39
M&M	-2.79	TRENT	1.34
Maruti Suzuki	-2.12	BEL	1.34
IndIGO	-2.05	NTPC	1.09

talks, keeping losses in check, but raising serious questions over the deal's durability and heightening the risk of a breakdown, leaving headline risk and volatility deeply embedded in market reactions," Ponnudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and

Rupee falls 9 paise to close at 94.54 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee pared initial gains and settled lower by 9 paise at 94.54 (provisional) against the US dollar on Monday, as renewed geopolitical tensions hit investors' risk appetite.

Forex traders said the rupee opened on a positive note with crude oil prices remaining supportive and foreign inflows improving, but a renewed flare-up in geopolitical tensions after fresh military exchanges between the US and Iran dented investor sentiment.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.36, then gained momentum and touched an intraday high of 94.25 and a low of 94.56 against the American currency. At the end of Monday's trade, the rupee was quoted at 94.54

Time	Rate (₹ vs \$)	Change
Open	94.33	(+0.00)
Low	94.03	(-0.30)
High	94.55	(+0.52)
Close	94.54	(-0.09)

(provisional), down by 9 paise over its previous close.

On Thursday, the rupee settled at 94.45 against the US dollar. Indian stock, currency, and commodities markets were shut on Friday on account of Muharram.

"We expect the rupee to trade with a negative bias on renewed geopolitical tensions. Overall strength in the US dollar on hawkish Fed may also pressurise the rupee. "However, a decline in crude oil prices and easing concerns over inflation may support the rupee at lower levels.

wealth tech firm, said. From the Sensex pack, Kotak Mahindra Bank declined 3.24 per cent after the firm said its MD and CEO, Ashok Vaswani, will quit upon completion of his three-year tenure and will not seek re-appointment when his current term ends on December 31, 2026.

Mahindra & Mahindra, Maruti, InterGlobe Aviation, UltraTech Cement and Larsen & Toubro were also among the laggards.

In contrast, Eternal, Trent, Bharat Electronics and NTPC were among the gainers. The BSE SmallCap Select index declined 0.65 per cent, and the MidCap Select index dipped 0.60 per cent.

Sectorally, Auto tumbled 2.11 per cent, Focused IT tanked 1.53 per cent, Oil & Gas (1.40 per cent), Services (1.21 per cent), IT (1.04 per cent) and Consumer Discretionary (0.91 per cent).

Healthcare, Utilities, Capital Goods, MidSmall Private Banks, Quality Tilt and Power were the gainers.

Serentica to invest ₹1 lakh crore in Rajasthan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Serentica Renewables on Monday announced plans to invest ₹1 lakh crore in Rajasthan's clean energy space.

The company's strategy is focused on enabling hard-to-abate sectors through firm and dispatchable renewable energy solutions that combine scale, reliability and affordability.

"Underscoring its long-term commitment, Serentica has announced plans to invest Rs 1 lakh crore in coming years in the state of Rajasthan, with more than ₹10,000 crore already deployed," the statement said. The company

said Rajasthan now accounts for over 50 per cent of its total solar portfolio, with major assets located in Bikaner and Jaisalmer. The portfolio is expected to expand to Bhadla in the next phase. Together, these projects are part of the company's planned renewable energy pipeline of 27,000 MW.

named National Strategy for Sustainable Secondary Steel is expected to be launched in the next three months, a senior Government official said.

"The scheme may go for approval of the union cabinet," another official in the know of the development said.

The scheme will cover all steelmakers in the country. However, a major share of

the funds will be earmarked for secondary players.

The National Strategy for Sustainable Secondary Steel aims to promote the adoption of clean technologies and alternative materials across various steelmaking processes to reduce carbon emissions from the domestic steel industry.

The move assumes significance as India is a signatory to the Paris Agreement

and aims to become a net-zero country.

Steel sector is among the largest carbon-emitting industries. India's steel industry accounts for 10-12 per cent of country's greenhouse gas emissions with an emission intensity of 2.55 tonnes CO2 per tonne of crude steel, higher than the global average of around 1.9 tonnes CO2 emissions, according to official data.

BPCL to buy 40% stake in Tiki Tar and Shell India for ₹85 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

State-run Bharat Petroleum Corporation on Monday said it will acquire a 40 per cent equity stake in Tiki Tar and Shell India for ₹85 crore in cash, as it seeks to expand its presence in India's fast-growing value-added bitumen market.

The acquisition, which has received approval from the Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM), is expected to be completed within 90 days, Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) said in a regulatory filing.

The transaction is not a related-party deal. Incorporated in October 2019, Tiki Tar and Shell India Pvt Ltd (TISIPL) manufactures and markets bitumen and bituminous products used in highways and airport runways.

Its portfolio includes VG Grade Bitumen, Polymer Modified Bitumen (PMB), Crumb

Rubber Modified Bitumen (CRMB), and emulsions. The company also exports to Nepal, Bhutan and Bangladesh.

BPCL said the investment aligns with its strategy to tap growing demand for value-added bitumen driven by India's infrastructure expansion.

INERA, CropNXT tie up to roll out bio-inputs across 5 states

INERA Crop Science and CropNXT Solutions have entered a multi-year strategic partnership to expand farmer access to science-led biological agricultural solutions across Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Odisha. The tie-up is projected to unlock a business potential of about ₹500 crore and aims to reach over 65 lakh farmers through a network of more than 5,000 channel partners and retail outlets. The initiative is expected to drive adoption of biological agri-inputs across roughly 20 lakh acres of cultivated land. Chhattisgarh has been identified as one of the key focus markets under the partnership due to its strong agricultural base and extensive cultivation of crops such as paddy, maize and vegetables. Science-led biological solutions can play a significant role in addressing these challenges by improving input-use efficiency, supporting crop performance, strengthening soil vitality and helping farmers build more resilient farming systems. (PNS)



MHA to ensure ease of doing business for private security

The Private Security Industry Associations under aegis of Union home ministry organised a joint workshop on PSARA compliance and enforcement. The workshop brought together senior officials from Union home minister, Directors General of Police and Additional DGPs, over 400 representatives of private security agencies, industry stakeholders to discuss challenges and opportunities related to the implementation of the Private Security Agencies (Regulation) Act, 2005. The collaborative platform for dialogue between Government authorities and industry representatives was aimed at strengthening compliance mechanisms, enhancing regulatory effectiveness, promoting the professional growth and Ease of Doing Business of the private security sector in India. In his inaugural address, Kunwar Vikram Singh, Chairman, Central Association of Private Security Industry, highlighted the significant contribution of private security industry towards national security, public safety, and employment generation. He also underscored the importance of coordinated efforts between regulators and industry stakeholders to ensure effective implementation of PSARA across country. (PNS)

Modi Govt's 12 years: Viksit Bharat in making



When Narendra Modi first took the oath as Prime Minister 12 years ago, India was going through a tough phase. It was a difficult time to assume charge as the nation was facing policy paralysis, corruption was rampant, and the morale of citizens was at an all-time low. People were waiting in anticipation, ready to support a leader who had the real capabilities to lead the nation. They found a leader in Modi and entrusted him with the responsibility to transform and reform India, the way he changed the fortunes of Gujarat. The journey of Narendra Modi as India's longest continuously serving Prime Minister is not a simple story of effective and transformative governance. The story of the Modi era is that of restoring confidence in the masses about a responsive and sensitive Government; it is about unleashing the aspirations of all; rediscovering the ethos, rich culture and history of a nation; regaining lost stature in the international arena, et al. Though 12 years in the life of a nation is a relatively short period, the long-lasting impact the Modi era has created, it has led to a change in India's growth trajectory, which is going to impact generations to come. Though previous Prime Ministers will be remembered for their commendable achievements, the Modi era is a class apart from numerous reasons, particularly for tackling issues which were considered "untouchable" or "impossible". By surpassing Jawaharlal Nehru as longest serving Prime Minister, Narendra Modi has been able to carve several unique distinctions.



Both Prime Ministers served the nation in two different eras, facing varied challenges and creating legacies. Jawaharlal Nehru inherited a newly independent nation emerging from colonial rule, suffering the pains of Partition, tackling poverty and several serious challenges. He was tasked with building institutions, preserving democracy, and laying the foundations of a modern republic. On the other hand, Narendra Modi faced numerous modern-day challenges. His primary task was to restore a nation's confidence and bring transformational changes in order to make India future-ready. There are several factors which are incomparable when it comes to India of 1947 versus that of 2014. India's population had swelled from 34 crore in 1947 to 130 crore in 2014 (now surpassing China to become the most populous nation). From the governance point – economy, infrastructure, social welfare, education, healthcare, security – today's India operates on a massive scale compared to a newly independent nation. Since Independence, India's electoral democracy has grown multi-fold – from 17 crore voters and 53 political parties in the first general elections in 1951-52 to nearly a billion voters and 744 parties in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. From one-party national dominance to intense competition, regional and coalition politics today – Indian democracy is more robust than ever. Narendra Modi's political success in today's political environment is truly remarkable. No Indian Prime Minister has governed for so long under such high political contestation and public expectation. It is the impact of governance on the masses that differentiates the Modi era from his predecessors. The most enduring contribution of the last 12 years may well be the shift from a culture of entitlement to a culture of empowerment. Since Independence, poverty alleviation has remained a recurring political promise. Under Prime Minister Modi's leadership, governance increasingly focused on creating systems through which citizens could directly access dignity, opportunity and state support. Financial inclusion through Jan Dhan accounts, direct benefit transfers, housing and sanitation for all, electricity, clean cooking fuel, healthcare protection, and tap water connections have transformed everyday life for millions.

Today, governance is no longer distant and bureaucratic; it is increasingly immediate, accountable, and citizen-centric. The Nehruvian model of development was all about state-led planning and centralised institutions. But the Narendra Modi model of development combines state capacity with mass participation. It believes in the development and participation of all. The philosophy of "Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas" has shaped India's economic growth and prosperity. At the time of Independence, India's GDP was estimated at approximately ₹2.7 lakh crore, while in 2014 it was around ₹113 lakh crore. Under Prime Minister Modi, it has grown to a whopping ₹357 lakh crore, making it one of the fastest-growing major economies in the world. And this has been achieved despite facing tough times, which include a global pandemic, conflicts leading to supply chain disruptions and inflationary pressures. From being in the list of "Fragile 5" in 2013, today India is seen as a driver of global growth. The Modi Government has realised this through major economic reforms which include GST implementation, a push to the digital economy and e-governance, major infrastructure expansion, a technology and startup boom, and improvement in social parameters. Massive investments being made today are shaping India's economic future opportunities that will help our generations to come. Two other sectors where the Narendra Modi Government has made decisive strides are tackling national security challenges and reshaping our foreign policy. From being a nation with a limited strategic approach, today's India acts with confidence, deterrence and national resolve. From the abrogation of Article 370 to cross-border strikes and stronger responses to terrorism, under Modi, India has shown the world that old doctrines have no place in modern India. Similarly, from Nehru's non-alignment policy to Modi's multi-alignment doctrine, which focuses on being a part of the multipolar world while preserving strategic independence, India is no longer a mere participant in global forums. Today, India is shaping the global discourse – from playing the role of the G20 Presidency, to helping shape the Global South or displaying leadership during global crises. For decades, our nation reeled under so much of external and internal pressures that it forgot what 'Bharatvarsh' stood for. While dealing with global challenges, Prime Minister Modi has toiled hard to establish our cultural and spiritual identity, and re-connected us from our roots. Today, Ram Mandir in Ayodhya is a reality. Redevelopment and renovation of the symbols of our historical identity is a sterling story of 12 years of Modi's rule. History often judges leaders not merely by the challenges they inherited but by the direction in which they moved the nation. Jawaharlal Nehru will be remembered for laying the foundations of a democratic republic. Narendra Modi's legacy may be defined by his effort to scale governance for 140 crore citizens, accelerate development and position India for the next phase of its national journey. As India moves towards 2047 – the centenary of Independence – Modi's ambition of building a 'Viksit Bharat' has become a defining national goal. The strong foundations being laid by Prime Minister Modi today will play a crucial and decisive role in shaping the India of tomorrow.

The writer is a freelance journalist

Peru embassy marks 205th Independence Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Embassy of Peru in India commemorated the 205th anniversary of Peru's independence on June 23, highlighting growing bilateral ties. Minister of State for External Affairs, Pabitra Margherita, attended as the guest of honour. The embassy stated his presence demonstrated the Indian Government's high regard for its bonds of friendship and cooperation with Peru. Ambassador of Peru to India Javier Paulinich felicitated Minister Pabitra Margherita on the occasion. The ceremony drew over 400 guests, including senior Government officials,



Ambassador of Peru to India Javier Paulinich felicitating Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita on the occasion of the 205th anniversary of Peru's independence

diplomats, business leaders, and the Peruvian community. Attendees sampled Peru's signature cocktail, the pisco sour,

alongside an exquisite buffet curated by Peruvian chef Julio Castillo. A unique artistic programme showcasing cultural complementarity between the two nations featured Ananga Manjari, a Peru-born Bharatanatyam dancer, and musician Ricardo Delgado. Their innovative performance fused Peruvian and Indian traditions. Additionally, the event inaugurated the fifth edition of the "Taste of Peru in Delhi" gastronomic festival, which concluded on June 28. The embassy emphasised that Peruvian cuisine is gaining significant recognition in India, serving as a vital instrument of cultural diplomacy to strengthen the friendship between both nations.

Indian Army honours Kargil hero Captain Kenguruse

TONY DAS ■ Kohima

The Spear Corps of the Indian Army and the Assam Rifles on Sunday solemnly commemorated the 27th Memorial Day of Captain Neikezhakuo Kenguruse, Maha Vir Chakra (Posthumous), at Nerhe Phezha Village in Kohima district. Fondly remembered as the "Hero of Nagaland," Captain Kenguruse made the supreme sacrifice during the Kargil War on 28 June 1999. The solemn



ceremony at the Kenguruse War Memorial was graced by Lieutenant General Girish Kalia, GOC, Spear Corps, alongside the fallen hero's proud parents, Mr and Mrs Neiselie Kenguruse, veterans, and serving personnel.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (29.6.26)

6	5	3	2	1	7	8	9	4
8	7	1	9	4	5	2	3	6
9	4	2	3	6	8	7	1	5
4	3	5	6	7	9	1	8	2
1	8	6	5	3	2	4	7	9
2	9	7	4	8	1	6	5	3
7	2	4	8	9	3	5	6	1
3	6	8	1	5	4	9	2	7
5	1	9	7	2	6	3	4	8

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

TUESDAY | JUNE 30, 2026

ACROSS

4 Egg timer (6)
7 Legendary loser who got the gold (8)
8 Old-fashioned and formal about material matters (6)
10 Bind broken parts (5)
13 Familiar name for part of a motherboard (4)
14 No longer the financial centre (4)
15 A game of pool, possibly (4)
16 Dry in next to no time (3)
17 A piece of cake? (4)
19 Yes, the Italian prison! (4)

DOWN

1 Character of the American in rich surroundings (5)
2 Large African river or middle-sized English one (5)
3 Temporary fireplace! (4)
4 Stand a trainee at ease (5)
5 What's left is maybe bust (4)
6 He could have engineered a file out of a piece of ferrous metal (6)
9 One prepared to work like a horse? (6)
11 A southern English article (3)
12 So Ann's going around with an old sailor! (5)
13 In Belgium or America, a tramp has a name for it (7)
15 Is it for all-in cooking? (3)

19 Co.-W
20 End
21 Ponchos
22 Ten
23 Merlin
24 (Fr.) Eddy
25 Dodger
26 Spitz
27 Villa
28 Job
30 Far-M

Minister Jayanta Mallabaruah meets Purnima Devi Barman, vows Hargila conservation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Assam Forest Minister Jayanta Mallabaruah on Monday met internationally acclaimed wildlife conservationist Purnima Devi Barman to discuss ongoing efforts towards the conservation of the Greater Adjutant Stork (Hargila) and explore measures to further strengthen wildlife conservation



initiatives in the State. The meeting comes a day after Prime Minister Narendra Modi, during his

PFC-REC merger approved; loan book over ₹11 lakh crore



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Board of Directors of Power Finance Corporation Limited (PFC) and REC Limited (REC) approved the Scheme of Merger (Scheme) for the merger of REC (Transferor Company) into PFC (Transferee Company) and their respective shareholders and creditors, under Sections 230 to 232 and other applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013. The merger of REC into PFC shall create a financing entity with an aggregate loan book of over ₹11 lakh crore. The Scheme is conditional upon and subject to, inter-alia receipt of all requisite approvals and consents required under applicable law including, approvals from the respec-

tive shareholders and creditors of both the companies, and all relevant regulatory and governmental authorities; and the Merged Entity continuing to qualify as a 'Government Company' under the Companies Act, 2013 and the Government of India continuing to retain majority voting rights and control in the merged entity (directly or indirectly). Pursuant to the Scheme and valuation report, the Share Exchange Ratio for the Proposed Merger of REC into PFC shall be 88 equity shares of PFC of ₹10 each fully paid up for every 100 equity shares of REC of ₹10 each fully paid up to be issued to the shareholders of REC as existing on a record date to be determined by the Boards of PFC and REC (as may be applicable) at a future date.

GUWAHATI HOSTS INDIA'S DISASTER NETWORK TRIALS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Guwahati on Monday hosted Proof of Concept trials for India's Broadband Public Protection and Disaster Relief (BBPPDR) network, a key initiative aimed at building robust mission-critical communication systems for public safety and disaster response. The trials were chaired by Akhlesh Kumar Singh, IPS, Inspector General of Police (Law & Order), Assam Police. Senior officials from the Ministry of Home Affairs, Assam Police, the Department of Telecommunications and the Central Reserve Police Force, along with other Central Armed Police Forces, participated in the exercise.



PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it known to general public that our client is in discussion / negotiating with the present land owners Ramesh Saikia and Kalyani Saikia, residents of Baihata, Kamrup, Assam - 781380, for purchase of the following parcels of lands (Total land measuring 10 Bigha 12 Lechas) situated at Revenue Village : Bamungaon, Mouza : Pub Par, under Kamalpur Revenue Circle, District Kamrup, Assam (hereinafter referred to as the said lands) and the said lands are free from all encumbrances, charges, liens, claims, or third-party interests of any nature whatsoever.

S.No.	Land Measuring	Dag No.	Patta No.
1.	12 Lechas	1228	150
2.	13 Lechas	1230	31
3.	1 Katha 19 Lechas	1232	142
4.	1 Bigha 2 Kathas 13 Lechas	1233	142
5.	1 Katha 10 Lechas	1234	142
6.	2 Bigha 3 Kathas	1517	429
7.	2 Kathas 15 Lechas	1572	440
8.	2 Bigha 4 Kathas	1531	448
9.	2 Kathas 15 Lechas	1531	448
10.	2 Bigha 1 Kathas, 5 Lassa	1231	142

Any person(s), institutions, government authorities, having any claim/s or interests, title of any kind whatsoever in the said Lands, are hereby requested to inform in writing with supporting documents on the address given herein below through post and email, within 15 days from the date of this publication, failing which, it will be deemed that there is no claim against the said Lands and the said Lands are free from all encumbrances whatsoever and our client may proceed with the transaction in respect of the said Lands. No further claim of any person in any nature whatsoever, will be entertained thereafter.

Advocate Simanta Deka
House No.-1, C/o. Dr. H. N. Sharma,
Near GNRC Hospital,
Dispur Super Market, Dispur,
Guwahati - 781006
Mob.: 70026-88870
E-mail : dekasimanta5@gmail.com

BRIEFLY

I hate it: Serena calls anti doping system grueling



Serena Williams took aim at tennis' anti-doping system ahead of her Wimbledon return, calling the system "unprofessional" and "unreasonable." The 44-year-old Williams returned to the testing pool before she could announce her comeback to professional tennis and was asked Sunday about her experiences complying with the rules.

"It's grueling. They changed the rules now. I didn't know some of the rules. So apparently if you miss a test outside of your window, it still counts as missed. I'm like, I guess I can't go pick up my kids," said the seven-time Wimbledon champion, a mother of two. "It's unprofessional. I hate it. I think it's necessary, but I think a lot of the stuff, if I want to go places outside of my window, I should be able to go without having it count as a missed test." Williams' first match at the grass-court Grand Slam since 2022 will take place Tuesday when she faces Maya Joint as part of her tennis comeback. She returned to the sport this month in a doubles match at the Queen's Club grass-court tournament. The anti-doping protocol was in the spotlight last week when Marketa Vondrousova, the 2023 Wimbledon champion, was suspended for four years for refusing an anti-doping test, the latest high-profile player sanctioned. (AP)

Scheffler forces Monday playoff against Hovland



Scottie Scheffler made an 8-foot par putt on the 18th hole Sunday and pumped his fist with more emotion than he showed all day, just for the right to return on Monday at the rain-delayed Travelers Championship to face a sudden-death playoff against Viktor Hovland.

The final round was stopped for ninety minutes as storms moved over the TPC River Highland, and officials deemed there was not enough daylight for them to play another hole.

Scheffler and Hovland each had birdie chances at the end. Scheffler rammed his 30-foot putt 8 feet by the hole. Hovland's 25-foot attempt missed by inches and he tapped in for a 69. Scheffler made his third big par putt for a 68 to match Hovland at 21-under 259.

That was one shot ahead of Collin Morikawa, who closed with a 61 and was briefly tied for the lead, though it never looked as though it would be enough. (AP)

India need to rethink T20 strategy; Bowling, fielding let us down: Coach Amol Muzumdar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ London

India head coach Amol Muzumdar admitted that the side will have to rethink its approach in the shortest format after a disappointing Women's T20 World Cup campaign which ended in a group-stage exit, saying Harmanpreet Kaur and Co were below par in all three departments throughout the tournament.

Needing a win to qualify for the semifinals, India failed to defend 170 against six-time champions Australia and crashed out in the league stage for the second successive edition here on Sunday. "We really have to



rethink our strategy or our T20 game. We really need to put our heads around what combination we are going to play," Muzumdar told reporters after the loss.

While India recorded comfortable wins over Pakistan, Bangladesh and the Netherlands, defeats to fellow semifinal contenders South Africa and Australia

exposed several shortcomings.

"If I have to pinpoint on certain things in the entire tournament, I think we really need to think about our bowling and our fielding. We also need to be a little aggressive with the bat, and we could have maybe 15-20 runs as cushion (against Australia)," the coach said.

Muzumdar felt India's total was competitive but conceded that Australia

were the better side on the day.

"I thought it was a good score, a par score on this pitch. We even got the momentum towards the end of that innings, and I think we carried it on the field as well. It's just that I think at the end of the day, Australia were a better side than us."

In reality, India's batting never quite clicked throughout the tournament. Despite regular contributions from the top order, the middle order repeatedly failed to capitalise on good starts, losing wickets in clusters and allowing the opposition to regain control.

Asked if India could have upped in the ante in the powerplay against Australia where they managed just 43/0, Muzumdar said "Yes, we could have had."

"I mean, every time you lose a game, you would want 10-15 runs more in the pocket, but I guess that wasn't the case. Of course, the powerplay didn't really go our way. It could have gone maybe 10-15 runs more at that time. Maybe that could have been the difference.



Jaspal Rana's mother dies days after his death



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Days after Indian shooting legend Jaspal Rana's shocking death owing to cardiac complications, his mother Shyama Devi has also passed away after battling multiple health issues during her prolonged hospitalisation.

Jaspal, who was relatively young at 49, died on June 12, a few days after undergoing an emergency heart procedure. Shyama Devi was hospitalised a few days after that and died on Sunday, which would have been Jaspal's 50th birthday.

"We have received the extremely sorrowful news of the passing of Smt. Narayan Singh Rana Ji's wife and the revered mother of the renowned Indian shooter, Padma Shri Late Jaspal Rana Ji," posted Pushkar Singh Dhami, the Chief Minister of

Uttarakhand, which is also the home base of the Rana family.

"In this hour of grief, my deepest condolences are with the bereaved family. May the Lord grant a place at His divine feet to the departed soul and bestow strength upon the grief-stricken family to bear this unbearable sorrow."

Shyama Devi's death comes as a massive blow to Jaspal's father Narayan Singh Rana, who had been mourning his son.

Jaspal is survived by his wife Reena Rana, daughter Devanshi, son Yuvraj, and his two siblings, Sushma Singh and Subhash Rana.

Jaspal was one of India's finest pistol shooters who made a hugely successful transition to coaching and guided Manu Bhaker to epoch-making twin bronze medals at the Paris Olympics.

Defending champion Sinner comes back to beat Kecmanovic in 5 sets in 1st round of Wimbledon

ANDREW DAMPFAP ■ London

Defending champion Jannik Sinner had to come back from a set down twice and regain his composure following a worrisome tumble to the grass in a five-set victory over 50th-ranked Miomir Kecmanovic in the first round of Wimbledon on Monday.

A month after his French Open meltdown, the top-ranked Sinner produced a 4-6, 6-3, 6-7 (6), 6-2, 6-3 win that lasted 3 hours and 30 minutes in the honorary opening match on Centre Court reserved for the past year's men's singles champion.

Sinner said he was "a little tight in the beginning," noting that it was his first grass-court match of the season.

"I'm happy that I turned it around," Sinner said.



Lleyton Hewitt, the 2002 champion, remains the only Wimbledon men's singles winner in the professional era (since 1968) to have lost in the first round the following year. The Australian was defeated by Ivo Karlovic in his 2003 opener.

Sinner hadn't played an official match since he struggled with dizziness during a heat wave at Roland

Garros, where after being within one game of concluding his second-round match in straight sets, he was beaten by Juan Manuel Cerundolo in five.

The match with Kecmanovic was played in ideal conditions, with sunny skies and the temperature 24 degrees Celsius (75 Fahrenheit).

Sinner is a big favorite to repeat as Wimbledon champion since his main rival Carlos Alcaraz, who he beat in last year's final, is missing the championships due to a right wrist injury.

Sinner felt the pressure from the honors reserved for the defending champion. "It was a very, very different feeling," he said. "There's a lot of nerves when you go down the stairs behind the court. Also mentally knowing it's such a prestige court and such a historical court." (AP)

Kemar Roach takes his 300th Test wicket

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ North Sound (Antigua)

Veteran fast bowler Kemar Roach claimed his 300th test wicket as West Indies rolled Sri Lanka for 101 in its second innings to win the first test by an innings and 217 runs and take a 1-0 lead in the two-test series.

Roach took 4-51 and with fellow seamers Jayden Seales, Shamar Joseph and Alzarri Joseph combined to end Sri Lanka's innings in only 31 overs, just after lunch on the fourth day, as the West Indies claimed their sixth-largest win in tests.



Dinesh Chandimal, who made 43, was one of only two Sri Lanka batters to reach double figures. Sonal

Dinusha finished on 12 not out.

West Indies set up the win on the third day when Amir Jangoo and captain Roston Chase shared a world record 401-run sixth wicket partnership which allowed the home side to declare at 626-9, with a first innings lead of 318.

The pitch had looked particularly placid on the third day but Roach, Seales and the two Josephs caused the ball to seam and swing Sunday. Roach, who came into the day with 296 test wickets, was almost unplayable though the Sri Lanka resistance was thin.

Emma Raducanu withdraws from Wimbledon before opening match

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

Emma Raducanu withdrew from Wimbledon because of a stress fracture in her right leg, leaving the tournament without its highest-profile British player.

Raducanu, the 2021 US Open champion, announced the decision on Instagram on Sunday evening. She had been set to open play on number 1 Court on

Monday against Antonia Ruzic. She had been dealing with the injury since a run to the final at Queen's Club this month, but said earlier Sunday at a news conference that she still hoped to play at the All England Club.

"I've done everything possible to try to get to the start line tomorrow but after a final scan tonight, the niggle I've been managing has developed



into a stress fracture and I've been medically advised to stop pushing through," Raducanu wrote. "Playing at Wimbledon, in front of a home crowd, means everything to me, so this is really difficult to process."

Raducanu has not won a tour-level tournament before or after her surprising run to the US Open title as a qualifier at the

age of 18. But she impressed at Queen's Club with some of her best tennis since that triumph, before losing to Donna Vekic in the final.

She said earlier Sunday that she first felt her injury during the clay-court season before it was aggravated at the grass-court warmup event.

"Queen's, during that week, was a lot of load for me," she said.

South Korea leaves World Cup in turmoil as early exit prompts fierce criticism from president

JIM VERTUNO ■ Seoul

South Korea left the World Cup in turmoil after the team's quick elimination from the group stage that drew heavy criticism from the country's president and South Korea media reports that coach Hong Myung-bo had quit.

South Korea won its opening match against Czech Republic, then lost its next two Group A matches to South Africa and Mexico.

South Korea hoped it would qualify for the next round as one of the third-place teams to advance in this year's expanded tournament. That ended when Congo defeated Uzbekistan 3-1 on Saturday.

The quick exit for a team that expected to advance prompted harsh criticism from President Lee Jae Myung.

"As a former honorary profession-

al football club chairman and, at heart, a member of the Red Devils, I feel not just surprise but deep bewilderment at this unexpected result," the president said in a lengthy statement critical of national team structure and oversight and coach Myung-bo's appointment in the first place.

"Once again, it has been proven that personnel decisions determine everything. If loyalty and factionalism are valued over com-

petence and an incapable person is appointed as a leader, the outcome is as predictable as fire," the president said.

Hong, 57, was in his second stint with the national team. He was the coach at the 2014 World Cup in Brazil when South Korea also failed to advance past the group stage. (AP)

Money can't buy success in WC for Saudi Arabia and Qatar



JAMES ROBSON ■ Atlanta

Gulf countries like Saudi Arabia and Qatar that poured a fortune into soccer and infrastructure experienced unceremonious exits from the World Cup, proving that big money doesn't guarantee success on the sport's biggest stage.

Saudi Arabia is out at the earliest point. Again. Bottom of a group that included tiny Cape Verde, the third-smallest nation ever to compete on this stage and into the knockouts for the first time.

By signing the likes of Cristiano Ronaldo, Neymar and Karim Benzema as part of a spectacular recruitment drive in recent years, Saudi Arabia has been a major disruptor of club soccer. But on the international stage it

still has a long way to go eight years out from hosting the World Cup in 2034.

Qatar, the host four years ago, is also on its way home after just three games, so too are the other gulf nations Iran and Iraq. Compared to the success of African teams at this World Cup, with nine out of 10 advancing to the round of 32, gulf nations are struggling mightily to make their mark.

A goalless draw against Cape Verde ended Saudi Arabia's hopes of advancing from the group phase for the first time since 1994.

"It was not what we wanted because when playing in such a match against a team that is more or less the same level as us, our performance was not good. So this gives rise to concern," Saudi coach Georgios Donis said. (AP)

Eustaquio's foot delivers late strike for Canada's first World Cup knockout win



BETH HARRIS ■ Inglewood (US)

The tension kept building between two teams making their first appearance in a World Cup knockout match. With no goals on the scoreboard, the minutes ticked down with extra time looming.

Then Stephen Eustaquio scored in the second minute of second-half stoppage time, and Canada beat South Africa 1-0 on Sunday.

"I shot with everything I had," Eustaquio said.

The party was on, for red-clad fans in the stands at SoFi Stadium and at watch parties across Canada, one of three World Cup hosts.

"Overall, it's pretty much a perfect knockout performance," right back Alistair Johnston said.

Hockey dominates Canada in the winter months. Now, summer belongs to the men's national soccer team.

The country's previous best men's international result was winning CONCACAF Gold Cup

championships in 1985 and 2000. The women's Olympic team won gold at the 2020 Tokyo Games.

"For Canadian sports history, it's going to be a moment where you're going to kind of know where you were when that moment happened," Johnston said. "That's something that is not lost on us. We know that not only are we writing history in Canadian soccer, but in Canadian sport, and that's a magical thing."

Just when it looked like 30 minutes of extra time was coming, Johnston's pass to the right side was cleared to the edge of the box and found Eustaquio, who drilled a clean strike into the bottom corner. (AP)





Badminton: Srikanth ends runner-up at US Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Fullerton (USA)

India's Kidambi Srikanth ended his impressive run with a runner-up finish at the US Open Super 300 badminton tournament after going down fighting in three games to Chinese Taipei's Su Li-yang in the men's singles final.

The 33-year-old Srikanth, a silver-medallist at the 2021 World Championships, recovered from the loss of the opening game to force a decider but couldn't match the pace and intensity of world number 46 Su, who is nine years his junior.

Srikanth, who had claimed six Super Series titles between 2014 and 2017, eventually lost 15-21, 21-16, 9-21 in a physical battle that lasted just over an hour here on Sunday.

"I could have played a little better maybe in the opening set. Otherwise,

I feel I've played okay. The second half of third set it was just hitting really well all of a sudden," said the man from Guntur after the match.

A Rio Olympics quarterfinalist, Srikanth also ended second at the Malaysia Masters Super 500 and Syed Modi International Super 300 last year.

"I just feel like whatever I've been doing is working. I just have to keep working hard. I feel like I'm there. It's just about being able to win those crucial points," added Srikanth, who had become the first Indian to secure four Super Series titles in a single calendar year in 2017.

Playing his first final of the season, the former world number 1 was the quicker off the blocks but a rare error, where his racquet crossed the net during a rally, appeared to disrupt his rhythm as a string of unforced mistakes allowed Su to open up a 7-2 lead.

Srikanth, however, regrouped to win eight of the next 11 points and draw level at 10-10 after a series of fast-



paced rallies. His powerful smashes proved crucial, helping him edge ahead by a point at the mid-game interval after Su smashed wide.

However, Su wrested back control

after the break, quickening the pace of the rallies and using subtle deception to force errors from Srikanth. He soon extended his lead to 17-12.

A cross-court smash followed by a delicate net shot helped Srikanth reduce the deficit to 14-18, but another error handed the initiative back to Su.

Su earned six game points with a thunderous smash. The Indian saved one before sending the shuttle long as Su wrapped up the opening game in 17 minutes.

After the change of ends, the contest remained evenly poised with neither player giving an inch. From 4-4, Srikanth reeled off three straight points to move 7-4 ahead, capping one extended rally with a superb cross-court block at the net.

Another breathtaking rally followed, with Su making the Indian cover every corner of the court before restoring parity at 8-8.

A deft backhand cross-court net shot took Srikanth to 10-8, and he entered the interval with a three-point

cushion after Su smashed wide.

Su responded with two thunderous smashes after the break, but Srikanth's excellent net play helped him maintain a 14-10 advantage.

The Chinese Taipei player broke the rhythm with a flat push into the corner to close the gap to 13-15 as Srikanth sprayed two shots wide.

Su then sent one long before Srikanth's cross-court return made it 18-13. The Indian won the next flat exchange and earned seven game points when Su again went wide. Although Su saved three game points, Srikanth forced the decider with a powerful down-the-line smash.

Su came out firing in the deciding game, opening with a lightning smash before putting Srikanth under sustained pressure to race to a 4-1 lead.

Maintaining his aggression and injecting greater pace into the rallies, Su surged to 7-4 before another rocket smash made it 9-5. Srikanth alternated between moments of brilliance and costly errors, often undoing his good work with loose shots.

WI Test tour: Pak set to drop pace stalwarts



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

Pakistan selectors have decided to go with a revamped pace attack for the two-Test series against the West Indies next month with the seasoned Shaheen Shah Afridi, Hasan Ali and Naseem Shah and veteran spinner, Nauman Ali being dropped for the tour.

According to a source, senior selector and former pacer Aaqib Javed on

Monday showed the probable squad to the Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) chairman Mohsin Naqvi, who has given a free hand to the selectors to take whatever decision they feel is best for Pakistan cricket.

"Muhammad Abbas, 36, Muhammad Ali 33, Khurram Shehzad, 27, and uncapped Ubaid Shah will be leading the pace attack in the upcoming series with Aamer Jamal, 29, included as the pace-bowling all rounder," the source said.

Kiwis clinch Test series, spoil Ben Stokes farewell

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Nottingham

New Zealand won a Test series in England for the fourth time by wrapping up a 160-run victory in the third Test at Trent Bridge on Monday, bringing an end to the international career of home captain Ben Stokes.

Resuming on 103-4 and chasing an unlikely 373 to win, England was dismissed for 212 soon after lunch on Day 5 as New Zealand clinched the series 2-1.

The New Zealanders' other series wins on English soil were in 1986, 1999 and in 2021 - the latter being in a two-match series.

Stokes announced on Sunday he would be stepping down as England captain after four years after this test, and also retiring from the international game after 15 years with national team. He didn't have an active role on Day 5 since he was dismissed for 30 late Sunday after opening the batting.

"It would have been great



to have gone out with a series win and a win," Stokes said, "but that's in a perfect world and this world certainly isn't perfect."

It was England's first defeat in a home series of three or more tests since 2012. The team has lost seven of its last nine test matches, a streak that piles the pressure on the leadership team of coach Brendon McCullum and director cricket Rob Key. England's final-day hopes



realistically rested on Joe Root and Emilio Gay — the remaining specialist batters who resumed from overnight — but they both departed in the fourth over, having walked to the middle with the boundary boards around the ground displaying the message: "Thank you Ben Stokes." Gay (10) edged behind and Root, England's all-time leading run scorer, was brilliantly run out by Henry Nicholls for 18.

Not surprised by India's loss to Ireland; Tilak struggling on slower tracks: Rayudu

DEVARCHIT VARMA ■ Mumbai

Former India player Ambati Rayudu is not surprised by the team's 0-2 loss to Ireland as he believes that Shreyas Iyer and his men were under-prepared for the assignment, a case in point being finisher Tilak Varma's inability to get going on slower wickets.

Speaking exclusively to PTI, Rayudu, who played 55 ODIs and six T20Is for India, said the change in conditions after the IPL became too difficult for the reigning T20 world champions, who lost the second T20I by a mere one run on Sunday in Belfast.

"No, I'm not really surprised because I don't think they were prepared well enough



for the conditions that they have encountered. It's always very, very difficult to go from really flat tracks to slightly spongy wickets which have some lateral movement as well," the former batter said.

"Most of the guys are so used to having these really fast bat-swings, the in-between game and the control of the down-swing is a major concern," added the 40-year-old. (PTI)

Vaibhav ready for international cricket but has to follow process: Ten Doeschate

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Belfast

India assistant coach Ryan ten Doeschate has declared Vaibhav Sooryavanshi ready for international cricket but also made it clear that the 15-year-old batting sensation will have to go through the same process that other players in the side have followed before being handed their debut.

Sooryavanshi's omission from the T20 series against Ireland has become a major talking point after the T20 world



champion Indian team ended up being white-washed 0-2, the second loss being by just one run on Sunday.

"He is absolutely ready to play

international cricket, there is no doubt about that but also Sanju Samson is a guy who went a long way to win us the World Cup three months ago," Ten Doeschate said when the inevitable query on Sooryavanshi came up during the post-match press conference.

Badminton Asia Junior Team C'ship: India lose to Hong Kong in quarters



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Yatsushiro (Japan)

India's campaign in the Badminton Asia Junior Mixed Team Championship came to an end following 1-2 loss against Hong Kong in the quarterfinals in Japan on Monday.

India started strong in the opening match with Dev Ruparelia and Tanvi Patri giving the team a strong start as India led 22-12 after two matches.

The doubles combinations then ensured that their was no hiccup as they clinched the set 55-44.

Chopra will deliver at big stage again: Anju Bobby George

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Legendary athlete Anju Bobby George believes it's just a matter of time before Indian javelin star Neeraj Chopra gets his mojo back and delivers for the country at the big stage — the Asian Games and 2028 Olympics.

Recovering from a lower back injury he had sustained before the Tokyo World Championships in September 2025, Chopra made a late start to the season at the Doha Diamond League where he finished fourth with a throw of 85.69m.

The 28-year-old two-time Olympic medallist has recently confirmed his participation in the Glasgow Commonwealth Games and the Asian Games to be held in Aichi-Nagoya from September 19 to October 4.

"Neeraj, I guess, when the competition toughness goes up, he will respond to that well. He's an Olympic champion and a world champion



medallist. I mean, that's something no Indian has ever done. Yes, that experience will speak when the time comes," world championship bronze medallist long jumper Anju told PTI in an interview.

"He has been in the international arena for almost 10 years. We cannot tell that he is not in his great form or he is not doing well. He gave enough during his prime, still he is in his prime. He did a lot for us. Let

him enjoy the game now."

Chopra had won gold in the last edition of the Asian Games in Hangzhou, China, in 2023, with a throw of 88.88m.

In Aichi-Nagoya, Chopra is expected to face rising Sri Lankan star Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage, who breached the 90m mark earlier this year and won two Diamond League titles, including in Doha where Chopra finished fourth.

Meanwhile, Anju strongly



believes that her 22-year-old national record in long jump was always breakable and had pinned her hopes on two jumpers — her own student Shaili Singh and Ancy Sojan from her home state Kerala — to obliterate her mark.

"I was expecting that Shaili or Ancy would break my record because in the Asian Games or Commonwealth Games this year, where athletes always perform their best. But since 2021, when Shaili started performing in the international level, I was expecting a good jump from her. At last Ancy could do this. Records are meant to be broken. I guess Shaili will soon come close too or she will break that," she said. (PTI)

PHF to appoint foreign coaches and trainers for hockey team



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lahore

Disappointed with the national team's disastrous FIH Pro League campaign, the Pakistan Hockey Federation (PHF) has decided to revamp the entire structure of the game and rope in foreign coaches and trainers to revive the sport in the country.

Pakistan failed to win a single match in the FIH Pro League this season, which includes two defeats against arch-rivals India in London and finished last in the nine-team competition. Pakistan lost 3-4 and 1-7 against India in the just-concluded London leg of the Pro League.

The PHF, which is being run by interim president Muhhudyin Wani,

said in a statement that it would bring in foreign coaches and trainers from Australia, Netherlands or Germany to not only work with the senior team but also junior players and at the domestic level.

It said the recent results in the FIH Pro League had pushed the agenda for a major restructuring in the sport as the country had a proud hockey legacy. The PHF said it was time to prepare the national team as per requirements of modern day hockey.

The PHF appointed number of former stalwarts, who played in the 60s, 70s and 80s to different positions, including the contentious appointment of Manzoor ul Hasan as head coach at the age of 74 for the FIH Pro League.